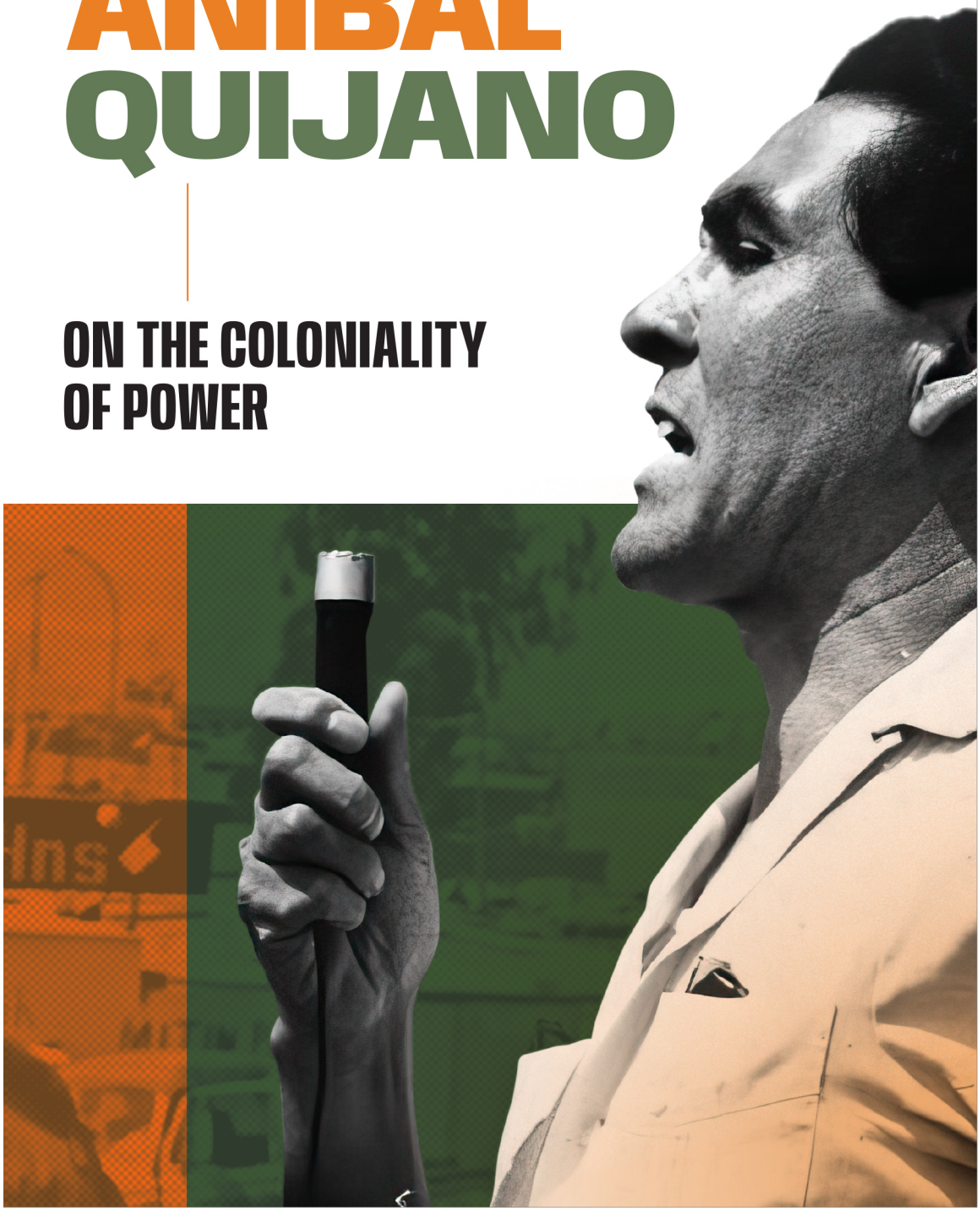
FOUNDATIONAL ESSAYS

EDITED BY
WALTER D. MIGNOLO,
RITA SEGATO, AND
CATHERINE E. WALSH

ANÍBAL QUIJANO

ON THE COLONIALITY OF POWER



ANÍBAL QUIJANO

ON DECOLONIALITY

A series edited by Walter D. Mignolo and Catherine E. Walsh

On Decoloniality interconnects a diverse array of perspectives from the lived experiences of coloniality and decolonial thought/praxis in different local histories from across the globe. The series is concerned with coloniality's global logic and scope and with the myriad of decolonial responses and engagements that contest coloniality/modernity's totalizing violences, claims, and frame, opening toward an otherwise of being, thinking, sensing, knowing, and living, that is, of reexistences and worlds making. Aimed at a broad audience, from scholars, students, and artists to journalists, activists, and socially engaged intellectuals, On Decoloniality invites a wide range of participants to join one of the fastest-growing debates in the humanities and social sciences that attends to the lived concerns of dignity, life, and the survival of the planet.

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Cover art: Aníbal Quijano at a political rally in Villa El Salvador, December 1979.

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INTRODUCTION

Catherine E. Walsh, Walter D. Mignolo, and Rita Segato

Aníbal Quijano: Foundational Essays on the Coloniality of Power is the first collection in English of selected essays of this influential Latin American thinker.[1] Yet, as we argue here, this volume not only introduces English-language readers to Aníbal Quijano's thought but also provides a fundamentally distinct lens for reading today's modern-colonial world-system from its origins in the so-called periphery, that is, from South America and the Global South.

For some time now, Aníbal Quijano's proposition to see history and society from what he has called the "perspective of the coloniality of power" has crossed the North-South geopolitical border in the opposite direction—from South to North—when this border normally regulates the traffic of theoretical models and other "patents" in only one direction. Some of what Quijano has said, specifically his vocabulary and his approach, have traveled. The terms he used can be heard at conferences and in seminars and classrooms. However, as he himself pointed out in frustration, often these terms have circulated like coins of an academic market or even as clichés of an intellectual fashion. By presenting this collection, we encourage the fuller understanding and broader implementation of Quijano's astute analyses and concepts, developed over the course of his long career as an activist, a militant, and a scholar.

I. The World Relevance of Quijano's Work

The fact that Quijano thought in and from Latin America and toward the globe may be motive enough for some to question what this collection of his essays might offer to English-language readers in the Global North and other regions of the world. Here we outline four of Quijano's key interventions crucial for understanding the planetary relevance of his thought and work.

The first intervention is the intimate relation that the coloniality of power constructs among race, global capitalism, and Eurocentered modernity and knowledge. For Quijano, an understanding of today's globally hegemonic matrix of power requires a consideration of its historical foundations and processes. It was in sixteenth-century "America" that this model of power took form and established its global vocation. According to Quijano, in America two historical processes converged. One was the codification of the differences between conquerors and conquered in the idea of "race," a supposedly different biological structure that placed some in a natural situation of inferiority to the others. The conquistadors assumed this idea as the constitutive, founding element of the relations of domination that the conquest imposed. On this basis, the population of America and later the world was classified within the new model of power.[2]

The second historical process was "the constitution of a new structure of controlling labor and its resources and products. This new structure was an articulation of all historically known previous structures of controlling labor including slavery, serfdom, small independent commodity production and reciprocity, which wove them together and placed them upon the basis of capital and the world market."[3] As Quijano further explained, "the new historical identities produced on the foundation of the idea of race in the new global structure of the control of labor were associated with social roles and geohistorical places." Both race and the division of labor remained structurally linked and mutually reinforcing. In this way, a systematic racial division of labor was imposed in which Western Europe became the central site for the control of the world market, the commodification of the labor force, and the establishment of raced assignments and relations of waged and nonwaged labor.

It is in this context, argued Quijano, that modernity took form and took hold. "Starting with America, a new space/time was constituted materially and subjectively: this is what the concept of modernity names," a concept that localized the hegemonic center of the world—and, relatedly, of

knowledge—in the north-central zones of Western Europe.[4] Moreover and as Quijano explained, "the intellectual conceptualization of the process of modernity produced a perspective of knowledge and a mode of producing knowledge that gives a very tight account of the character of the global model of power: colonial/modern, capitalist, and Eurocentered." This perspective of knowledge "was made globally hegemonic, colonizing and overcoming other previous or different conceptual formations and their respective concrete knowledges, as much in Europe as in the rest of the world."[5]

For Quijano, the necessities and interest of capital alone are not sufficient for explaining the character and trajectory of this perspective of knowledge. Thus, he gave importance to the intimate ties of race, global capitalism, and Eurocentered modernity, which formed the foundation and reason of the coloniality of power. That these ties first took shape in the Americas is important for not only understanding the foundational relation today of "Latin" America in the globe but also comprehending the significance of colonialism and coloniality in the organization, establishment, and continuance of hegemonic global power. This relation and significance are, without a doubt, crucial today for all who struggle against this power and for building an otherwise of knowledge, existence, and life.

The second major intervention Quijano offers is related to the first and is based on the lived weight of coloniality particularly for Native peoples.

In his analysis of the idea of "race" as the basis of social classification, social domination, colonial relations, and new historical social identities in America, Quijano evidences the invention of the term *indio*, meaning "Indian," as a racialized, homogenous categorization. With the imposition of "Indian" as a new identity, the colonial power aimed to erase millennial cultures, languages, cosmologies, and knowledges as well as forms of collective organization, governance, and existence tied to the land. "Indian" racialized, inferiorized, objectified, negated, grouped, dispossessed, and controlled Native peoples, marking the colonial difference in "Latin" America, in settler-colonial nations such as Canada and the United States, and later in other parts of the world. Christianity, civilization, and modernity were tools to counter a supposedly savage and barbarian precolonial past. While the processes and practices that have maintained the colonial difference vary in different regions of the globe—including with respect to the contexts of invader, settler, and internal colonialisms—the project remains much the same: to sustain the colonial matrix of power and its idea of "inferior races." As Quijano made clear, this power matrix, which originated

five centuries ago, has been hegemonic worldwide since the eighteenth century, enabled and further consolidated by the nation-state system, "a *private* system of control over collective authority, as an exclusive attribute of the colonizers, and thus of 'Europeans' or 'whites.'"[6] Indigenous peoples continue to make evident today the problem of nonnational and nondemocratic nation-state systems; their demands, as Quijano wrote, are not for more nationalism or increased state power but rather "for an 'other' state, that is, to decolonize the state which is the only way to democratize it."[7]

As Native peoples know all too well, dispossession and genocide, along with capture, cooptation, and individuation (including through inclusion-based policies) continue to characterize the present. "In much of today's former colonial world, especially the Americas and Oceania, the 'whites' and 'Europeans' have managed to keep local control of power in all its basic dimensions. In the Americas, therefore, the issues surrounding the debate on 'the Indigenous' can only be investigated and discussed in relation to and from the perspective of the coloniality of the power matrix that haunts us, because outside of that perspective, such issues make no sense."[8]

Despite being up against coloniality's lived weight, Indigenous peoples have always engaged in collective resistance and affirmative refusal, constructing and maintaining decolonial/decolonizing otherwises.[9] While coloniality/decoloniality may not be the referenced terms, with colonization/decolonization the more usual ones, the relation is clear: subversions, resurgences, and dignification of existence, knowledge, and life.[10] This is something Quijano understood well. It is present in his analysis of the coloniality of power and the intimate relation it constructs between race, global capitalism, Eurocentered modernity, and knowledge. And it is present in his critique of state hegemony, his notes on decoloniality, his reflections on Indigenous movements, and his thinking with the decolonial Indigenous concept of "life in plentitude," or *bien vivir*. In all of this, Quijano opens paths of rumination that move from Latin America to elsewhere in the world, encouraging interconnections.

A third major intervention Quijano offers is his argument that the structure of coloniality is an open rather than a closed totality.[11] As he maintained, the coloniality of power is not a homogeneous historic whole. If this were the case, change would imply the complete departure from one historic totality with all its components so that another derived from it could take its place. Change happens in a heterogeneous and discontinuous way, within a historical field of social relations that is open and moves with time and space and whose matrices of power are also discontinuous and heterogeneous.[12] As

such, the coloniality of power does not profess to depict all forms of colonial/modern power and structural domination over existence. Rather, it is an analytical and conceptual framework that invites use, provoking reflections on and expansions of its operation, domains, and configurations.

This, in part, was María Lugones's project in identifying the coloniality of gender. Lugones used and expanded Quijano's lens, recognizing its heteronormative and male-centered perspective and broadening and complicating coloniality's matrix of power. Despite the limitations she saw in Quijano's framework, Lugones also saw its value and possibility. "I mean to begin a conversation and project," said Lugones, "to begin to see in its details the long sense of the process of the colonial/gender system enmeshed in the coloniality of power into the present, to uncover collaboration, and to call each other to reject it in its various guises."[13] In this crucial work—reflected in the growth of decolonial feminisms throughout the globe—Lugones clearly evidences coloniality's open framework and invitational character.

As Quijano argued in his later texts, the matrices of global power today are never static but instead are in constant mutation and configuration, with direct effects on our daily lives, behavior, and social relations.[14] The insurgencies against this power are also in constant flux and creation, as are the decolonial constructions, subversions, and affirmations. By inviting thought, analysis, and reflection on both the colonial matrix of power and decoloniality's lived practice, Quijano calls forth the presence and possibility of radically different worlds.

Hope is the fourth major intervention, that is, Quijano's hopeful and forward-looking vision of the possibility of radically different worlds.

In a 1988 text that critiques neoliberalism in its public (i.e., state) and private capitalist manifestations, both part of the same instrumental rationality according to Quijano, he closes with this line: "The ship of liberating rationality travels today with a new hope."[15] This opinion and conviction, further elaborated in his later texts, was that a liberating and liberation-based rationality was and is in process. The concept and practice of decoloniality embodies this hope.[16]

As two of us have pointed out elsewhere, "decoloniality was born in response to the promises of modernity and the realities of coloniality, in the sense that Quijano introduced it. The conceptualizations and actionings of decoloniality are therefore multiple, contextual, and relational; they are not only the purview of people who have lived the colonial difference but, more broadly, of all of us who struggle from within modernity/coloniality's borders and cracks, to build a radically distinct world."[17]

While the historical relation of coloniality/decoloniality is certainly key in many of Quijano's texts, his frequent reference to the "new" encourages considerations of the multiple ways that the coloniality of power is actually being contested and subverted. In "Latin America: Toward a New Historical Meaning," for instance, he argued that the contemporary acceleration, polarization, and deepening of the control over labor "has produced not only a lot of polarization but also two irreversible limits." Moreover, "new approaches take into consideration the limits relating to the living conditions on the planet . . . and address the limits on relations regarding social existence based on the perverse combination of two mental constructs, race and gender. The thing called race is being subverted. The victims of the coloniality of power are creating true subversion."[18] Even more, these victims are also producing radical critiques of Eurocentrism and with it a subversion of authority, Quijano contends. While subversion has certainly been present since colonial times, Quijano's words offer hope in and for these times, new rationalities of and for the present.

Still, the "new" for Quijano does not pretend to discard the old. "What is going on is that new rationalities are reappearing out of those that were colonized; they are even producing other new ones. What we will probably have in the future," he maintains, "is not so much a rationality shared by all, decreed by some God, but rather several rationalities—that is, several means of producing meaning and explanations—that nevertheless must have common ground so as to be able to communicate. We are speaking of something new where people can communicate, learn from each other, and even choose to leave one identity for another or have many diverse identities."[19]

While Quijano's reflections here are from his native Latin America, they open dialogue on what is occurring in other regions of the world. To use another of Quijano's phrases, a "new alternative horizon of historical sense" is emerging.[20] Herein lies Quijano's hope and forward-looking vision: a proposition and guide for decolonial thinking and doing across the globe today.

II. Quijano's Conceptual Framework

> *. . . another distinctive episteme is emerging. There's an epistemic subversion, and it not only has an important field of activity in Latin America, it also forms part of the ideas that are up for debate around the world at this moment, ideas that originated in*

> *Latin America*. The very notion of the coloniality of power and its epistemic foundations, the idea of decoloniality of power, are of Latin America in origin. It is no historical accident, of course; quite the contrary.
>
> This is why the coloniality of power must be called into question, its bases called into question, the very idea of race called into question, the idea of gender and of ethnicity as well. It isn't an idle question. *The answer to it isn't just academic; it is political and vital*. That is, it doesn't refer to official politics via the state but to the politics of daily life.
>
> —"Notes on the Decoloniality of Power" (emphasis added)

The impact of Aníbal Quijano's work has been felt since the 1990s and has grown consistently since then even though he left no major books in either Spanish or English. His talks, workshops, teaching, activism (e.g., the World Social Forum), and articles were all conducted in Spanish. A few of the resulting works have been translated into English through the years and dispersed in unrelated publications.

Quijano was trained as a sociologist, and his life and work were not those of an academic, although he was one.[21] He was mainly an intellectual activist, thinking on his feet and delivering his thinking orally. His intellectual work and activism go back to the late 1960s and the 1970s when the debate on economic and political dependency in Latin America was extensive, involving scholars from Brazil, Chile, Peru, and Argentina. From these years came his friendship and professional relationship with Immanuel Wallerstein as well as the Fernand Braudel Center that Wallerstein founded at Binghamton University in 1976.

There are four theories that originated in Latin American during the 1960s that have had a global impact: the theology of liberation, the pedagogy of the oppressed, dependency theory, and, more recently, the coloniality of power. The latter introduced a discontinuity in the social sciences that must be understood in the context of the change of era unlocked by the fall of the Berlin Wall and the end of the Cold War.[22] Such observation is helpful to distinguish Quijano's coloniality of power from Wallerstein's modern world-system. Wallerstein devised the modern world-system based on his lived experience and intellectual formation in the North Atlantic. Quijano devised coloniality and the modern/colonial world-system ground on his lived experience in the South American Andes and his intellectual immersion in the debates of his time, mentioned above. While the

relationship between Quijano and Wallerstein was friendly, solidary, and intellectually connected, a closer look reveals their divergent paths.

Quijano added "coloniality" to Wallerstein's modern world-system. The North Atlantic modern world-system became the modern/colonial world-system, sensed and perceived in and from the South American Andes. The content may be similar, but the lived experience that sustains the content is engrained in the partition and ranking of planetary regions. Because this distinction is overlooked, however, the groundings in which Quijano and Wallerstein enunciate had already been shaped by coloniality of power. Wallerstein sensed and perceived modernity and the First World. For Quijano, it was coloniality that permeated life and memory of the Third World. The fracture, the slash (/), that divides and unites modernity/coloniality had been earlier perceived by Raúl Prebisch's distinction between center and periphery. Prebisch (1901–1966) was an Argentine liberal economist and executive secretary of the United Nations Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean who called into question the idea of developing the underdeveloped. Wallerstein added "semiperiphery" to Prebisch's compound center/periphery, First World/Third World.

Eastern Europe was Wallerstein's semiperiphery. Two other Wallerstein sources, beyond his debt to Prebisch, were Frantz Fanon's Africa and Fernand Braudel's historical capitalism. The latter overruled the former in Wallerstein analytics. Of the three sources (Prebisch, Fanon, and Braudel), Wallerstein named the research center he created in Binghamton after the latter. The point I am stressing with these tidbits is the geopolitics of knowing, sensing, and believing, upon which conceptual structures are displayed, that relates and at the same time differentiates Quijano from Wallerstein. In a nutshell, while Braudel was an anchor for Wallerstein, the intellectual, activist, and dissident Marxist José Carlos Mariátegui (1894–1930) was the equivalent for Quijano. Consequently, the modern world-system is a North Atlantic (critical) perspective, while the modern/colonial world system and the coloniality of power are a South American (decolonial) perspective.[23]

It was Prebisch also who introduced the concepts "economic dependency" and "unequal development" in the 1950s, which opened up the debate known today as "dependency theory" during the 1960s in which Quijano was involved.[24] A frequently cited Quijano essay is "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America."[25] This essay is revealing of what Prebisch meant to Quijano and to Wallerstein. Quijano perceived and sensed the power differential while dwelling in the periphery like Prebisch,

while Wallerstein sensed and perceived the weight of the center. Decolonially speaking, knowing and understanding are sensorial before being rational. Quijano wrote:

> When Raúl Prebisch coined the celebrated image of center and periphery to describe the configuration of global capitalism since the end of World War II, he underscored, with or without being aware of it, *the nucleus of the historical model for the control of labor*, resources, and products that shaped the central part of the new global model of power, starting with America as a player in the new world economy. Global capitalism was from then on colonial/modern and Eurocentered. Without a clear understanding of those specific historical characteristics of capitalism, the *concept of a "modern world-system," developed principally by Wallerstein but based on Prebisch and the Marxian concept of world capitalism*, cannot be properly understood.[26]

Quijano did not mention the concept of race in this specific paragraph, although it is explicit in the essay from which this quotation is extracted. Race was for Quijano what class was for Prebisch and Wallerstein. Quijano, following up on Mariátegui instead of Braudel, reformulated center/periphery by following the path of his Peruvian intellectual predecessor, Mariátegui, who was a self-taught intellectual, journalist, and philosopher. Mariátegui and Quijano distinguished themselves for their essayistic writing and wide thinking beyond academic and disciplinary regulations, while Wallerstein respected the formality of the social science's disciplinarity.

Quijano's extensive reflection on Mariátegui could be found in his foreword in the 2007 reprint of *7 ensayos de interpretación de la realidad peruana*.[27] Here, Quijano outlined the political, economic, and subjective transformation of Peruvian society, connected to the mutation of international political economy and the conflicts between the ascending Peruvian bourgeoisie, in connivance with the elite landowners of Peru, pertaining to the disputes between the United States and Britain in Latin America. It was at this juncture that the question of land and the "the problem of the Indian" were made evident, first denounced by Peruvian liberal thinkers (e.g., González Prada), and later followed by Mariátegui from a dissident Marxist perspective: race and racism were outside orthodox Marxism, but it was central for Mariátegui and later on for Quijano.

Mariátegui's own Marxism placed the question of the land, the question of the Indian, and the question of race in the front row. In so doing he was quickly excluded from Eurocentric Marxist orthodoxy. Quijano's

essay on Mariátegui did not miss this point, as Quijano distanced himself from Marxist materialist orthodoxy. Quijano's path paralleled similar reactions in the 1960s among a new generation of Marxist followers of Antonio Gramsci to reject Marxist orthodoxy.[28] However, the concept of race and land were absent in Gramsci and in many of his Latin American followers who held onto the Eurocentered concept of class. For Mariátegui, race and land took over class, and for Quijano, race became the anchor to justify the exploitation of labor and the expropriation of land.

All of these take us to the crucial decolonial shifting from Eurocentric epistemology. This shift appears in Quijano's foundational article on coloniality and modernity/rationality (in this volume). Here Quijano's emphasis on the question of knowledge (rather than the economy) is of note. The radical epistemic shift was to place the control of knowledge over the control of the economy. Quijano certainly understood the role of the economy in the colonial matrix of power. After all, he was deeply familiar with Marxism. But he believed that the economy known today as "capitalism" was not limited to the expropriation of land and the exploitation of labor. In order to make that possible, the control of knowledge and consequently of intersubjective relations is necessary. There is a deviation, if not a reversal, here from the canonical infrastructure/superstructure. The colonial will to power, mediated by knowledge, becomes the infrastructure, while the economy becomes the instrumental superstructure to implement the colonial will.

Quijano realized that what there is (the ontic dimension of living) and what we do are always regulated by the knowledge and understanding (the ontological) we have about what there is, what we do, and what is done by others. Hence, although he kept employing the word "capitalism" in reference to economic coloniality, the decolonial meaning of the word was distinct from Wallerstein's modern notion of "historical capitalism." In one of Quijano's last essays, "Notes on Decoloniality of Power" (written in 2015 and included in this volume), he argues that "there is a bigger issue that is in crisis, which is this power structure, whose legitimacy is in crisis, whose foundations no longer have legitimacy." He motioned us to look beyond the surface of capital and capitalism, to focus on the colonial matrix of power.

Quijano confronted not only "the question of knowledge" but mainly the question of the "totality of knowledge" head-on. At this point it is crucial to delink from the canonical Western distinction between epistemology and ontology. They are two related philosophical concepts. The first frames the regulation of scholarly knowledge, while the second refers to what there

is (*onto*) that appears to the discursive (*logos*) gazes according to certain regulations of scholarly knowing. The ontic is meaningless without the ontological. Hence, ontology is a philosophical concept mediated by epistemology. Economy and capitalism are two ontological entities that cannot be changed without chafing the epistemology that supports the concepts of economy and capitalism. For that reason, Quijano proposed in his foundational article "Coloniality and Modernity/Rationality" that "decolonization" requires "epistemological reconstitution." Now, epistemological reconstitution cannot be a universal model but instead must come from the local histories disrupted by the coloniality of power. The "bigger issue that is in crisis" is the colonial matrix of power of which economic coloniality (capitalism for liberals, neoliberals, and Marxists) is one of the four domains outlined by Quijano.[29]

As said earlier, the meaning of "capitalism" differs in Wallerstein's historical capitalism and Quijano's colonial matrix of power. Here, the economy is one of the four domains articulated by the modern/colonial structure of knowledge. Thus, decolonization, particularly the decolonization advanced in specific local histories, must be connected to the coloniality of power that requires the task of epistemological decolonization. Without this specification, any invocation of decolonization and decoloniality would be floating invocations lacking the specifics of what is being claimed to be decolonized. For these reasons, decoloniality after Quijano is not an abstract universal but rather the connector among diverse and specific localities that have been disrupted by coloniality, both as will to colonial power and the implementation of the instrument, the colonial matrix of power. In this regard, decoloniality is the general grammar that connects specific local works of decolonization that presuppose gnoseological reconstitution of epistemology, or epistemological reconstitution in Quijano's own vocabulary.

Through Mariátegui, Quijano focused on the modern/colonial concept of race. Although race accounts for the power differentials and inequalities undergirding the formula center/peripheries, the experience, and debates, treatment of racism acquires its specificities in particular local histories and historical periods. Racism in the United States is not experienced, conceived, debated, or treated as it is in China, South Africa, and the South American Andes. However, the concept of race is the colonial connector among diverse planetary localities disrupted by coloniality. In his celebrated work *7 Interpretive Essays on Peruvian Reality* (1928), Mariátegui framed the racial question in the South American Andes:

> La suposición de que el problema indígena es un problema étnico se nutre del más envejecido repertorio de ideas imperialistas. El concepto de las razas inferiores sirvió al Occidente blanco para su obra de expansión y conquista. Esperar la emancipación indígena de un activo cruzamiento de la raza aborigen con inmigrantes blancos es una ingenuidad anti-sociológica, concebible solo en la mente rudimentaria de un importador de carneros merinos. La degradación del indio peruanos es una barata invención de los leguleyos de la mesa feudal.
>
> The belief that the Indian problem is ethnic is sustained by the most outmoded repertory of imperialist ideas. The concept of inferior races was useful to the white man's West for purposes of expansion and conquest. To expect that the Indian will be emancipated through a steady crossing of the aboriginal race with white immigrants is an antisociological naivete that could only occur to the primitive mentality of an importer of merino sheep. The people of Asia, who are in no way superior to the Indians, have not needed any transfusion of European blood in order to assimilate the most dynamic and creative aspects of Western culture. The degeneration of the Peruvian Indian is a cheap invention of sophists who serve feudal interests.[30]

Quijano identified the concept of race as a mental category of modernity and by so doing was able to translate Mariátegui's insight into the larger picture of global coloniality. That is, race/racism was not a specific problem in the Andes. What Mariátegui perceived in Quijano's reading was the local manifestation of the crucial issue of global coloniality and in the constitution of the colonial matrix of power. But that was not all. It was a mental category of knowledge that fulfilled the ideal of the human/humanity modeled on males' experience during the European renaissance. Consequently, the concept of race anchored and implied, outside of the Christian European experience, the sexual aspects in defining and ranking Western concepts of the human/humanity. Furthermore, the concept of race was instrumental in separating the human/humanity from all the living energies on Earth, immobilized and objectified by the Western concept of nature. Nature, or what is not made by humans, was imagined as distinct from culture, which is everything made by humans.[31] As Quijano stated,

> The idea of race, in its modern meaning, does not have a known history before the colonization of America. Perhaps it originated in reference to the phenotypic differences between conqueror and conquered. However, what

> matters is that soon it was constructed to refer to the supposed differential biological structure of those groups.
>
> Social relations founded on the category of race produce new historical social identities in America—Indians, Blacks and mestizos—and redefined others. Terms such as "Spanish" and "Portuguese" and, much later, "European," which had until then indicated only geographic origin or country of origin, acquired from then on a racial connotation in reference to the new identities. Insofar as the social relations that were being configured were relations of domination, such identities were considered constitutive of hierarchies, places, and corresponding social roles.[32]

Quijano's argument demonstrates that racialization goes beyond skin color and what was called the "ethnoracial pentagon" in the United States during the 1970s.[33] The ethnoracial pentagon of white, Asian American, African American, Native American, and Hispanic/Latino is the current and local manifestation in the United States of a larger phenomenon: the classification and ranking of people, continents, nations, and regions of the world. Quijano's groundbreaking argumentation brought to light that the colonial differential, that which holds together the modern/colonial world-system, was built and maintained on the concept of race. In that sense, the above quotation elucidates the distinction between Wallerstein's modern world-system and Quijano's coloniality of power (or modern/colonial world-system).

Distinctions such as barbarian and civilized, developed and underdeveloped, and First World and Third World are all Western conceptualizations that create two opposing poles. What are seen as oppositions in the rhetoric of modernity are invented entities, which are entangled with the colonial difference. Barbarians are not ontically inferior or anterior to the civilized. The constitution of ideas of the civilized and of civilization needed to invent the idea of the barbarian in space and the primitive in time. They needed these ideas to trace their frontiers. The logic of either/or is the logic of Western modernity enacting coloniality. It was a convenient opposition and ranking, since it justified the claims to civilize the barbarians, develop the underdeveloped, democratize the undemocratic, and contain any invented threat to the modern/colonial world's order. Mariátegui was already intuiting the large problem when he said that "the belief that the Indian problem is ethnic is sustained by the most outmoded repertory of imperialist ideas."

The concept of race fuels and holds together the colonial matrix of power.[34] Projected over people and regions of the planet, race served to

constitute the idea of the civilized human and the lesser human: barbarians, primitives, and underdeveloped.[35] This illuminates our understanding of the past and current international world order as well as the emotional impact on people with the privilege to classify, the people who are being classified, and the people who occupy the gray zone between these groups. The process of colonizing the land called America in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, conquering the people of the continent, and capturing and transporting enslaved Africans was the foundation of a pattern of intersubjective relations. These processes entangled the European population with Native peoples and enslaved Africans.[36] No one escaped from the emerging hierarchical relations being established, which were transformed and have persisted until today. The arrogance of power settles in the subjectivity of the conquering (and classifier) population in the same way that the sense of inadequacy and inferiority is implanted in the subjectivity of the classified population.

The established power differential, however, is not static. The dominated, Quijano suggested, "learned, first, to give new sense and meaning to the outsiders' symbols and images and then to transform and subvert them by including their own in regard to images, rites, or expressive matrices of outsider origin."[37] It was impossible for the invaded and disrupted Native population to continue living as they did, and it was impossible to dwell in the shoes of a language, memory, culture, and praxis of living that was alien to them. The burden was passed to future generations who would adapt themselves to the imposed foreign culture or reoriginate their own, no longer as it was but enriched with the Native appropriations of the invading culture.

Once the logic of coloniality enters like a virus in the subjectivity of all parties involved, it invades all areas of experience from everyday life to institutional political and economic governance. For the Native population (in the Americas, Asia, and Africa), there is no possibility of returning to the past or belonging to the subjectivity of the settlers or invaders. Adaptation always leaves a residue in the population of the origin country and the population that migrated to the North Atlantic region. For the invading population, a new dimension disrupts their historical continuity until that moment. Once the colonial matrix of power is established, no one is outside of it. The current rise of the "white replacement theory" in words and deeds in the United States and in the European Union bears witness. But now, the directionality of the power differential has paradoxically changed direction: the intruders are Blacks, Muslims, Jews, immigrants, and refugees, while the intruded

upon are white and Western Christians. Although this is obvious, it poses a reversal of fortune from the previous 450 years, when the intruders were Western Christians and secular whites and the intruded upon were everyone else. But it is also a powerful sign of the discredit and disbelief in the reality of classifications and in the reliability of the classifiers.

Recent shootings in the United States, the European Union, and New Zealand are all domestic cases of increasing national racial conflicts. Less discussed but there for everyone to see are the racial conflicts in the global interstate order, also known as international order. The officers of the state, of any state, national or monarchic, are human beings also embedded in the racial matrix. Diplomacy, of course, is there precisely to keep interstate relations as detached as possible from personal emotions, but these emotions have not yet been eliminated. Race/racism connects the emotions (pro and cons) of the public sphere with the state.

Quijano's conceptualization of race as an epistemological issue has enormous consequences. Race is generally not discussed, for instance, in interstate relations. It seems obvious from the history of the colonial matrix of power that the racial component is present in the current international conflicts between the United States, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, and the European Union on the one hand and China, Russia, and Iran on the other. While the economy and historical-political power differentials exist between the states and regions, something more moves the emotions that can be observed in the discourse of politicians and the anchors of mainstream media. That the Chinese are "yellow" is a European myth invented by the scientific classification of Carl Linnaeus (1707–1778) and the ideological rendering of Immanuel Kant (1724–1804).[38] The European image of Africans, the people and the state, has been shaped by the long history of the European mentality. Russians are Slavics and Christian Orthodox. The expression "white superiority" obtains at all levels of experience, from the public sphere to interstate relations, but is not restricted to skin color. A large part of the Russian and Iranian population is white-skinned.

"Globalization" was not alien to Quijano. However, he departed from mainstream debates on globalization mainly because he injected race into the equation and revealed that globalization is not just something that happened in history but instead is the outcome of globalism: the five hundred years of Western global designs and racial classifications, since the sixteenth century, managed through the colonial matrix of power. Quijano introduced the decolonial perspective on globalization through the concept of race. In the last decades of the twentieth century and the beginning of the

twenty-first century, he routinely observed, "What is termed 'globalization' is the culmination of a process that began with the constitution of America and colonial/modern Eurocentered capitalism as a new global power. One of the fundamental axes of this model of power is *the social classification of the world's population around the idea of race*, a mental construction that expresses the experience of colonial domination *and pervades the more important dimension of global power*, including its specific rationality: Eurocentrism."[39]

"Notes on the Decoloniality of Power" (2015), presented in this volume, is a short although overwhelming statement of the formation and consequences of coloniality and of the decoloniality of power. There, Quijano explicitly connects race with gender and ethnicity. Together, they form the three energies that govern the coloniality of power and the colonial matrix of power.[40] But what does he understand by power structure, on the one hand, and the colonial matrix of power, on the other? For him "power" is a mesh of relations of three forces: domination, exploitation, and conflict. This model of power could be found in many geohistorical civilizations before 1500. What distinguished the mesh of relations that Quijano called the "matrix of power" from the colonial matrix of power? To understand this distinction means to understand his radical departure from Western political theory and ways of thinking.

As we mentioned before, Quijano posited coloniality as the main feature of the colonial matrix of power. It consists in the classification of the global population anchored on the idea of race.[41] Hence, classification is not a manual operation. Sure, it can be done in images, but arguments would be necessary to make sense of the images. If race/racism is a mental category that shapes people's sensorium, it is because it is the outcome of thoughts manifested in oral and written expressions. Classifications are neither given nor inscribed on the bodies and the regions classified. Classifications are signs projected onto what is classified. To do so requires actors, institutions in positions of power, and a sign system to materialize the destitution of alien sign systems.

For example, "America" was a name invented and imposed on existing sign systems of the territories theretofore known as Anahuac, Tawantinsuyu, Mapu, Abya Yala, and Turtle Island. Asians did not know they lived in Asia until Christian missionaries landed in Japan and China toward the end of the sixteenth century with the Western world map dividing the planet into four continents. The idea of race restructured ethnic relations. Ethnically speaking, "European" was not only the descriptor of a given ethnicity, coexisting with others such as "Chinese," "African," "American," and

"Asian." It was also the marker of a superior ethnic rank and the generation of the classification. In its turn, gender relations were also remodeled by the idea of race: Spanish women in the colonies and British women in the plantations were in a dominating position vis-à-vis Indian and African men. The classificatory logic of coloniality remains active today, although it is increasingly contested in the interstate system and within nation-states.

Quijano's demand in the epigraph at the start of section II that "the coloniality of power must be called into question in all its domains" is not an academic but rather an existential call, Quijano insisted. It is a political and vital one. He insisted on bringing back together the tree of life with the tree of knowledge that were separated in Western modernity. How should this call be pursued? In "Coloniality and Modernity/Rationality" (1992), Quijano's foundational article on the coloniality of power, he called for "decolonization as epistemic reconstitutions" in the following terms:

> The critique of the European paradigm of rationality/modernity is indispensable; even more, it is urgent. But it is doubtful if the criticism consists of a simple negation of all its categories, of the dissolution of reality in discourse, of the pure negation of the idea and the perspective of totality in cognition. *It is necessary to extricate oneself from the linkages between rationality/modernity and coloniality*. . . . It is the instrumentalization of the reasons for power, of colonial power in the first place, that produced distorted paradigms of knowledge and spoiled the liberating promises of modernity.[42]

The urgency of Quijano's call can be understood through Albert Einstein's well-known dictum that problems cannot be solved within the same frame of mind that created the problems. Einstein was alluding to the physical sciences, but his notion could be extended to the colonial matrix of power. One of the failures of decolonization during the Cold War was to leave the colonial matrix of power untouched. The colonial matrix of power was also unseen because it was covered by the rhetoric of modernity. How should it be pursued? First, we must extricate and delink ourselves from the linkages between modernity/rationality and coloniality. Second, we must engage in epistemological and subjective reconstitution. This means delinking in order to relink with something else. For this second step, there cannot be one global or universal model. The entire planet, local histories and selves, have been subjected through the years to the promises and demands of modernity. Therefore, the path of reconstructing epistemology will depend on whoever, communally, needs to engage with it. If there is no one model, it is indispensable to start from someplace else. It must begin

from the exteriorities of what modernity destituted and what is relevant for any decolonial project whose basic premise is epistemological and subjective reconstitutions.[43] How did Quijano do it? He shifted the geography of knowing, and instead of starting from modernity and moving toward coloniality, his experiences, emotions, and reasoning began from coloniality. From there he unveiled the fictional promises of modernity.[44]

The promises of modernity never went without being contested. The reason is simple: there is no promise of modernity without implementing coloniality. And that creates conflicts. Quijano's latest essays explored the growing and creative thinking and doing of the Pueblos Originarios/First Nations in reconstituting their knowledges and paths of knowing (gnoseology), reducing Western knowledges and paths of knowing (epistemology) to their own limited dimensions. One of these essays was titled "'Bien Vivir': Between 'Development' and the De/Coloniality of Power" (in this volume). The quotation marks around "Bien Vivir" and "Development" indicate that the political horizon of *bien vivir* cannot be achieved by developmental projects. Development promises and provides better life (*vivir mejor*) for a minority and worse living conditions (*vivir peor*) for the vast majority. Here you have in a nutshell why there cannot be modernity without coloniality.

Raúl Prebisch earlier realized the trap in the rhetoric of development and modernization announced in 1949 by US president Harry Truman (1884–1972).[45] Given the power relations between industrial centers and peripheries, which have provided raw materials and labor to the benefit of the industrial center, development was a dead-end road. The horizon of *bien vivir* originated someplace else: in the praxis of the living and thinking of Pueblos Originarios/First Nations. The horizon has been stamped in the constitutions of Bolivia and Ecuador. Doing and thinking in the horizon of *bien vivir* has different meanings for Indigenous and non-Indigenous people. The horizon is the same, but the roads leading toward it are parallel and cannot be fused or absorbed. Hence, delinking from Western universality brings to the fore decolonial pluriversality that emerges, precisely, from people working and following the common path of their destituted local histories and praxis of living and thinking.

Quijano sensed the global momentum of the double processes of delinking/relinking and constitution/reconstitution (learning to unlearn). He perceived the momentum not as a universal model but instead as the plurality of decolonial epistemological and subjective reconstitutions of what has been destituted:

> There's a process of decoloniality of power, an indigenized population around the world that's starting to emerge. Therefore, *another distinctive episteme is emerging*. *There's an epistemic subversion, and it not only has an important field of activity in Latin America, it also forms part of the ideas that are up for debate around the world at this moment, ideas that originated in Latin America*. The very notion of the coloniality of power and its epistemic foundations and the idea of decoloniality of power are of Latin America in origin. This is no historical accident, of course; quite the contrary.[46]

What is emerging is not a new universal within the universal frame of Western epistemology. In "Notes on the Decoloniality of Power," Quijano argues that while coloniality of power remains active, the idea of race lost much of the legitimacy that it had up to World War II, although it remains active in everyday life and on people/our subjectivities. And he adds, "*This is why the coloniality of power must be called into question, its bases called into question, the very idea of race called into question, the idea of gender and of ethnicity*. It isn't an idle question. The answer to it isn't just academic; it is political and vital. *That is, it doesn't refer to official politics via the state but instead to the politics of daily life*."[47]

III. The Need of Quijano's Coloniality of Power in English

As mentioned above, Aníbal Quijano's proposition to see history and society from what he has called the "perspective of the coloniality of power" has crossed the North-South geopolitical border in the opposite direction—from South to North—when this border normally regulates the traffic of theoretical models and other "patents" in only one direction. Quijano's vocabulary and his approach have traveled. The terms he used can be heard at conferences and in seminars and classrooms. However, as he often pointed out with righteous anger, more often than not they have circulated like coins of an academic market or even as clichés of an intellectual fashion. Quijano became upset with this for two reasons: his vocabulary had been used in a superficial manner, and he knew that such use would inevitably lead to obsolescence.

One might assert that the reason for this triviality is related to the disrespect for the "parenthood" that gave rise to it. After all, the role of people who work in the humanities and the social sciences is to donate names that will turn evident in a reflexive way what had remained until the moment of nomination as a blind spot in the visual field of an era. Those names that

emerge and transform the consciousness of an era do not have owners, but they do certainly claim some parentage. Authors, in the most radical sense of the word, are name givers. And the names they donate to the world do not belong to them as possessions or property. Nevertheless, they do have with them a filial relationship. This filial relationship is important because it allows for the coordinated use of a composed universe of ideas whereby every category at stake needs to be understood in context and relation to the group to which it belongs. Unfortunately, this has not been the case for Quijano's ideas, despite the extensive circulation of his vocabulary.

Quijano's words instead have been circulating scattered, orphaned, and therefore unconnected. That is what makes this English-language anthology so important. His words have migrated to the epistemic North separated from the original matrix that gave cohesion to their meaning and have lost the deep interconnections they had at their birth. We can recount some examples of this problem. On countless occasions, authors have placed faith in the possibility that changes in state policy could solve the problems pointed to by decolonial critique. Others have mistaken decolonial perspective with postcolonial theory. Quijano rebuffed them, saying "it is impossible, since, as far as I am concerned, the postcolonial does not exist."[48] Finally, thinkers have pretended to use the decolonial perspective by applying the category "subalterns" to describe the inhabitants of the colonized world, a category that Quijano never used. These recurring examples show how the perspective of the coloniality of power is often detached from its original meaning precisely because an adequate representation of Quijano's works has not been available in English.

Anglophone readers will find it useful to hear the way Quijano himself talked about his body of work and ideas. He never referred to his repertoire of categories as a "theory" but instead described it as a "perspective," a way of looking at the world. A theory would be a closed and finished model. Instead, a perspective is given by a set of donated terms, which create a vision that organizes the world differently, reshaping it and making this reorganization of its entities a constant and open work without limits or constraints. The density and imbrication of elements within the perspective of the coloniality of power is conveyed by the image of a labyrinth. In his last years, Quijano described himself as "lost in his labyrinth" of interwoven ideas and lost in a continuous two-way flow of interconnection and constant expansion.

Quijano's theoretical universe should be considered as "organic" rather than "systemic," as it is not a closed and complete system of ideas but in-

stead is a living and constantly moving organism. It heads toward an open "horizon" rather than a preconceived and previously designed "utopia." Quijano's vocabulary stands out for its surgical precision at naming the elements of his perspective. Many authors have elaborated the critique of colonial history and racism and its impacts up to the present, but the tool kit provided by Quijano's vocabulary impresses his crystal clear accuracy for the approach of those topics. Some of these terms and their idiosyncratic definitions, which can be traced back in the texts included in this anthology, are mentioned below.

Quijano's formulation of the perspective of the coloniality of power was gradually developed from the second half of the 1980s onward and followed the end of the Cold War and the fall of the Berlin Wall. The end of this era caused a break in the compulsory ideological loyalties of the bipolar world of capitalism or socialism. It then became possible to imagine and speak of a new critical perspective. While keeping some precepts from Marxism, that perspective took flight in a broader and more inventive way, featuring a worldview based on the Latin American experience. Yet as Quijano emphasized, that view affects and modifies the interpretation and understanding of all reality on a global scale.[49]

The collapse of this bipartite world, with its compulsory adhesions, is the emergence of what Quijano describes as an equally Eurocentric project on both sides of the global political spectrum. The author's courage is striking when, revealing his Mariáteguian lineage, he fearlessly declares that when viewed from the perspective of the peoples, both sides are guilty of the same Eurocentrism because of the technocratic character of their projects and their adherence to the raison d'état.

Another break of Quijano's perspective with the orthodox Left lies in the fact that the core of the coloniality of power dwells on the invention of race, which is considered strictly colonial since conquest and colonization have been ideologically based on the racialization of the bodies, products, and knowledge of the "defeated" peoples. This is how Eurocentrism emerges as the ideological basis of the "coloniality of knowledge." Therefore, despite being a critical and antisystemic perspective, it focuses not on class struggle but rather on denouncing the racialization of bodies, landscapes, knowledge, and products resulting from conquest and colonization.

Quijano's enunciation of the permanence of a coloniality of power, that is, of a colonial structure that continues to shape the world order and also human subjectivity despite the end of the historical stage governed by a colonial and slave-owning legal order, produces an epistemic subversion; that

is, it inflects the view of the world and gives it a twist, a shift in perspective, a decolonial turn.

This shift in perspective reveals that the colonial event reoriginated the world by creating categories that did not exist before. "Indian," "Black," and "white" now classify human beings in a new way that serves as a basis for the exploitation of the modern world-system. National independences never dissolved that classification. Therefore, coloniality has remained, and it proliferates as a pattern for work exploitation, social hierarchies, political administration, and even subjectivity itself. Before the Iberian ships had arrived on the shores of the Caribbean and Abya Yala, there was no Europe, no Spain or Portugal, not even America. Let us not forget the revealing year in which the unification of the Iberian Peninsula took place upon the conquest of the Emirate of Granada: 1492. The "Indian," "Black," and "white" categories for the classification of peoples did not exist either, and once created, they brought together very diverse civilizations: those of large populations with a centralized organization and technological development and those of nonstate populations with rudimentary technology.

The first scene of this epistemic turn was, according to Quijano, later accompanied in his proposal by Immanuel Wallerstein (1992), the reordering of history, since it inverts the order of precedence established in the Western historiographical imagination to state that America precedes and invents Europe. This is so because the "New World" emerges as a new space; the American novelty displaces the European tradition and establishes the spirit of modernity as an orientation to the future. Upon the emergence of "America," the golden age runs from the past to the future. The source of legitimation moves from the past—the "sacred history" that, being interpreted by priests, validated and admitted (or not) scientific breakthroughs and technological inventions—to the future as the source of value. Since then, novelty turns out to be good, and what defines the spirit of modernity appears on the horizon: the act of discovering is discovered as a historical project. That is why in Quijano's discourse "colonial" comes before "modernity." The expression "colonial/modernity" indicates that the colonial process was the indispensable condition and kickoff for modernity. This is so just as conquest and colonization were the precondition for capitalism, since only the minerals of the New World would allow the primitive accumulation of the initial phase of capital: without Potosi, there would be no capitalism.

The emergence of America, its foundation as a continent and a category, reconfigures the world and originates the only vocabulary we have today to narrate such a story. The entire narrative of this process, then, needs a new

lexicon to describe its events, consequently giving rise to a new era with a new repertoire of categories and a new epistemic framework to grasp the world. America becomes the New World in the strictest sense, as it reestablishes or—in Quijano's words—reoriginates the world. America is the epiphany of a new time, and therefore Quijano accepts the position not of "subalternity" but rather that of protagonism.

History is "reoriginated" (a category essential in Quijano's thinking) and will welcome "the return of the future" by freeing itself from its right- and left-wing enclosures and heading to the ancestral paths of the peoples and their own historical, communal, and cosmology-centered projects. To understand the possibility of this process, it is necessary to perceive the historical/structural heterogeneity of America's social existence. Such heterogeneity is irreducible and permanent. It represents what Quijano called the "Arguedian knot," evoking the novel *Todas las sangres* (All the Bloodlines) by José María Arguedas. In other words, it is an articulation or an interweaving of multiple stories and projects that will have to combine themselves in the production of a new time. For Quijano, capital takes over the heterogeneous forms of work and exploitation. Along with salaries, servile and slave labor relations have not disappeared and are expanding today because of the structural exclusion and permanent marginality resulting from the labor market. At the same time, productive forms based on communal solidarity and reciprocity have not only persisted in Indigenous, rural, traditional, and Black communities but have also been reinvented in forms of popular and solidarity economies. Latin America is heterogeneous not only because it embraces diverse production relations but also because diverse temporalities, histories, and cosmologies coexist there. It is heterogeneous because of the diverse peoples who inhabit it.[50]

The ideological and immediate material efficacy of this perspective is made up of what Quijano calls "the movement of society." Whereas social movements are subject to capture by vanguards that inevitably distance themselves from the people because of their power and control projects, Quijano argued that the movement of society has two fronts that emerge from contemporary politics. The first one involves popular economy with a communal structure, which especially comes up in times of economic catastrophe on a local or national scale and typically arises from unemployed groups or those who were expelled from their territories. The second includes the movements of Indigenous people, Indigenous-peasant organizations, and Black communities. Quijano calls this flow of great political force that bursts onto the present "the return of the future."

To properly understand the perspective of the coloniality of power, it is essential to consider three representations of time in Quijano's work: "reorigination," "open horizon as destiny," and "the return of the future." The last one is an original and sophisticated concept with Andean roots, which Quijano uses to introduce another form of temporality that affects political conception.

The historiographical perspective and the construction of temporality that Quijano proposes firmly differ from dogmatic historicism in order to support the idea of a time that remains behind a series of "historical events" that are typical of linear time. Coloniality is nothing more than a time that remains. It is a line of force that is in the background and remains there despite particular events. This is a broader perspective that defies the linearity of historical exceptionalism and dogmatic historicism and considers the existence of long periods. And it does so by identifying foundational events, which bring about enduring structures and mentalities that cross over the historical time of such events. Ideas such as the coloniality of power exactly highlight the permanence and long duration of subjectivities. In contrast, historicism severs the necessary connection between events by focusing on unconnected historical episodes. The option for partial unrepeatable events not only blocks the perception and understanding of continuities but also presupposes an empty and free time that is not affected by often hidden and unnamed lines of force that cross it.[51]

In this perspective, the reorigination or epistemic shift is essential because it indicates the mutation of subjectivity since the event of conquest and colonization. The decolonial shift takes place when we realize that it is impossible to narrate the process of conquest and colonization without using a vocabulary following the event. When we narrate this process, we are already located in a reoriginated world, a new world in which we can only speak the categories that did not exist before. For example, we say that "Spain discovered America," but this is an untenable statement, since "Spain" did not exist before "America." If we analyze the chronology of events, we will be shocked to see that the Kingdom of Castile reaches the southern tip of the Iberian Peninsula to finish the conquest and begins the unification of what will become the Spanish nation precisely in 1492. This means that the process of annexation reaches the southern coast of the Iberian Peninsula and goes on overseas without breaking its continuity. It is therefore the same historical process: the conquest and colonization on both coasts are part of a continuous, uninterrupted process. However, the reorigination of the world based on a new lexical or categorical framework, through which we see and

classify the entities of our planet and narrate past events, prevents us from envisaging the ongoing conformation of Spain. Similarly, we often and inevitably repeat the word "discovery," even though we know very well that the continent was already inhabited. This slip reveals that we are naming something else: the novelty of discovering as a value.

The second concept is that of the open horizon as destiny. Quijano had written about utopia in different essays, but more recently he took on the image of "horizon": a horizon of destiny, that is, an open path led by some ideas and aspirations but neither predefined nor fenced in by preconception. The idea of horizon is that of life and history in motion, not governed by the ideal of a compulsory future, of an imperative future, a motion that is not seized by its end. It is like the winds of history passing through the scene in an always uncertain way. Uncertainty is utopia itself, as with the instability of tectonic plates. History is motion. Life is motion: true and mere "historical faith" about an always uncertain future that cannot be imprisoned. This is the notion of horizon that Quijano sets out and that little by little modifies and replaces the usual notion of utopia as a must-be of the future. We only know about the present, and we can act in the present. The future is open.

The third central idea in this perspective is the "return of the future," meaning a horizon that reopens to the path of peoples' history after the defeat by the capitalist liberal state and the bureaucratic despotism of "real socialism" as well. The hegemony of Eurocentrism has governed both projects. The collapse of the strict loyalties, either to the Left or to the Right, prevented us from thinking freely. It has permitted the reemergence of peoples holding communal structures—such as Indigenous peoples, Indigenous-peasant groups, and Black communities—in politics, that is, in another kind of politics. In the post–Cold War period, encouraged by the apparent benevolence of the multicultural era, diverse peoples who were thought to be extinct reappeared on the scene, showing themselves still alive. The contemporary reemergence of an Indigenous historical subject or the acknowledgment in Latin America that some peasant communities were in fact Indigenous peoples as well as the deconstruction of *mestizaje* indicate that the matrix (*patrón*) of coloniality is coming apart. There is an ongoing reidentification of peasants as Indigenous peoples, of mestizos as Indigenous and Black people, and more people are retracing their nonwhite ancestry.[52]

That is why the category of the return of the future is so important. In the Quechua and Aymara understanding of time, the past is in the future, and Quijano's essay title "The Return of the Future" is a clear reference to this Andean construction of time.[53] We could say, then, from the point of view of

the critique of coloniality that only in the future will we be able to find the path and flux of a lost, interdicted past. It is thus clear that the continuity of community solutions for everyday life, which has been interrupted and blocked, is making its own way in the present after the crisis of the political paradigms of the 1970s. This makes possible a connection between archaic forms of life and current historical projects that find their roots in the former. Yet, we are speaking of not a restoration or of nostalgia but rather the liberation of diverse peoples' historical projects that had been interfered with and withheld by the matrix of coloniality. The return of the future becomes possible, a future that could not have been possible but now is. We are not speaking of the nostalgia for a static golden age that is stuck in a remote past or of a loss, much less the confinement of traditions. It is not about the "noble savage" of a pristine origin or about culturalism (a variant of fundamentalism) but instead is about a reclaimed historical path that now has the floodgates open to smooth its continuity in the present. It is the recovery of a historical flow that has been blocked by conquest, colonization, and coloniality and is now reinstalled as the historical project of peoples' continuity. That is why Aníbal Quijano rarely speaks in terms of "decolonizing" in order to avoid an idea of recoverable origin. Time was always in motion for all peoples. All peoples are in history all the time. This is the point in which the perspective of the coloniality of power approximates poststructuralism, since it designs a struggle for a horizon Other by tearing apart the fabrics of discourse and, through its ruptures, making way for the histories withheld by the warlike and ideological intervention of conquest and colonization.

Notes

Each of the three sections of this introduction was written by one of us, respecting the personal relation and intellectual debts that we individually and collectively owe to Aníbal Quijano.

1 Aníbal Quijano was born in Yanama, Peru, in 1928. At a young age he became involved in Marxist-socialist revolutionary politics. He was incarcerated several times for his political thought, and on numerous occasions his writings were confiscated. Quijano was an active part in the 1960s and 1970s of the conceptualization of dependence theory—introducing his concept of structural heterogeneity—and of the shaping of Latin American critical thought. His intellectual militancy of these years is documented in the well-known Latin American journal

Sociedad y política. Trained as a sociologist and being an invited professor in many universities in the Americas and throughout the globe, Quijano refused the identification of full-time academic. His intellectual interest, energy, and contribution were, until his passing in 2018, always militant in scope: a perspective for analyzing and rereading the world from Latin America, from the complex weave of race and capital that is the coloniality of power, the focus of this book.

2 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," *Nepantla: Views from the South* 1, no. 3 (2000): 533, in this volume.

3 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," 534.

4 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," 548.

5 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," 550.

6 Quijano, "The 'Indigenous Movement' and Unresolved Questions in Latin America," in this volume.

7 Quijano, "Estado-Nación y 'movimientos indígenas' en la región andina: Cuestiones abiertas," *Observatorio Social de América Latina* (Buenos Aires) 7, no. 19 (2006): 3. See also Catherine E. Walsh, "Undoing Nation-State," in *Rising Up, Living On: Re-existences, Sowings, and Decolonial Cracks*, 180–229 (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2023).

8 Quijano, "The 'Indigenous Movement.'"

9 For a discussion of affirmative refusal, see Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, *As We Have Always Done: Indigenous Freedom through Radical Resistance* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota, 2017). Recalled as well are the practices of marronage among Black ancestral communities.

10 One example is the reframing of indigeneity as a historical and transhemispheric category and collective Indigenous proposal that originates from the experiences that unite Native peoples and that "interpellate a collectivity of Indigenous nations, as well as non-Indigenous allies that struggle to transcend the conditions of internal/external colonialisms and their logics of elimination." See Emil Keme, "For Abiayala to Live, the Americas Must Die: Toward a Transhemispheric Indigeneity," *Native American and Indigenous Studies* 5, no. 1 (Spring 2018): 46.

11 See Quijano, "Coloniality of Power and Social Classification," in this volume.

12 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power and Social Classification."

13 María Lugones, "The Coloniality of Gender," *Worlds and Knowledges Otherwise* 2 (Spring 2008): 4, https://globalstudies.trinity.duke.edu/sites/globalstudies.trinity.duke.edu/files/file-attachments/v2d2_Lugones.pdf.

14 See, for example, in this volume, "Coloniality of Power and De/Coloniality of Power," "Notes on the Decoloniality of Power," and "Latin America: Toward a New Historical Meaning."

15 Aníbal Quijano, "Lo público y lo privado: Un enfoque latinoamericano," in *Por la Imaginación Política: De la socialización a la descolonialidad del poder*, comp. Danilo Assis Clímaco (Lima: Red de Descolonialidad y Autogobierno Social/Programa Democracia y Transformación Social, 2000), 236. Translation by Catherine Walsh. Both public and private neoliberalism were, in Quijano's mind, part of the same instrumental rationality.

16 Here it seems relevant to note that "decoloniality" was not a central component of Quijano's early work on the coloniality of power. This only began to emerge after the first half of 2000, largely the result of collective discussions and reflections of what has been referred to as the modernity/(de)coloniality group, organized around Quijano's thought and in which he played a central part.

17 Walter D. Mignolo and Catherine E. Walsh, *On Decoloniality: Concepts, Analytics, Praxis* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2018), 4–5.

18 See Quijano, "Latin America: Toward a New Historical Meaning," in this volume.

19 See Quijano, "Latin America."

20 See Aníbal Quijano, "Otro horizonte de sentido," *América Latina en Movimiento,* 441 (July 2, 2014): 2–5.

21 Quijano was a faculty member of the Universidad de San Marcos in Lima; a visiting professor at the State University of New York at Binghamton; a scholar of the Fernand Braudel Center for the Study of Economies, Historical Systems, and Civilizations; and an invited professor and speaker at various universities throughout the Latin American region and Europe.

22 Rita Segato, *The Critique of Coloniality: Eight Essays* (London: Routledge, 2022).

23 For more details, see Walter D. Mignolo, "Colonialidad Global, Capitalismo y Hegemonía Epistémica," in *Indisciplinar las Ciencias Sociales: Geopoliticas del conocimiento y colonialidad del poder; Perspectivas desde lo Andino*, ed. Catherine Walsh, Freya Schiwy, and Santiago Castro-Gomez, 215–44 (Quito: Abya Yala, 2002).

24 Vincent Ferraro, "Dependency Theory: An Introduction," in *The Development Economics Reader*, ed. Giorgio Secondi, 58–64 (London: Routledge, 2008).

25 Quijano's original text was published with the title "Colonialidad del poder, eurocentrismo y América Latina" in *La colonialidad del saber: Eurocentrismo y ciencias sociales: Perspectivas latinoamericanas*, ed. Edgardo Lander (Buenos Aires: CLACSO, 2000), and reprinted as "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America" in *Coloniality at Large: Latin America and the Postcolonial Debate*, ed. Mabel Moraña, Enrique Dussel,

and Carlos A. Jáuregui (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2008), included in this volume.

26 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," in this volume (emphasis added). See also his distinction between "capital" and "capitalism" in "Notes on the Decoloniality of Power," in this volume.

27 See Quijano, "Prólogo: José Carlos Mariátegui."

28 Aníbal Quijano, "José Carlos Mariátegui: Encuentros y debates," in José Carlos Mariátegui, *7 ensayos de interpretación de la realidad peruana* (1928) (Caracas, Venezuela: Biblioteca Ayacucho, 1979), ix–xc. The year before, the Argentina intellectual José María Aricó, one of the leaders of the Gramscian Left in Argentina and Brazil in the 1960s, published the booklet *Mariategui y los origenes del Marxismo Latinoamericano* (Buenos Aires: Cuadernos de Pasado y Presente, 1978). The two texts, read side by side, illustrate the two readings of Mariategui's work: the foundation of decolonial thinking, in Quijano, and the origin of Latin American Marxism. See, in addition, Walter D. Mignolo, "Mariategui and Gramsci in 'Latin' America," *The Politics of Decolonial Investigations*, 387–420 (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2021); and Catherine E. Walsh, "Thinking Andean Abya Yala with and against Gramsci: Notes on State, Nature, and *Buen Vivir*," in *Gramsci in the World*, ed. Roberto M. Dainotto and Fredric Jameson, 190–203 (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2020).

29 Lugones, "The Coloniality of Gender."

30 Translated by Marjori Urquidi. Jose Carlos Mariategui, "The Problem of the Indian," in *Seven Interpretative Essays on Peruvian Reality* (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1971), https://www.marxists.org/archive/mariateg/works/7-interpretive-essays/essay02.htm.

31 An annual workshop was held at Binghamton in the late 1990s and was organized by the Puerto Rican sociologist Kelvin A. Santiago, with the presence of Aníbal Quijano. In one of those meetings, Sylvia Wynter was a special participant. She later published an extensive essay connecting her own Caribbean and Fanonian perspective with Quijano's coloniality of power. See Wynter, "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom."

32 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America," 182. See also in this line of thought Walter D. Mignolo, "Racism as We Sense It Today," in *The Politics of Decolonial Investigations*, 85–99.

33 Historian David A. Hollinger has been credited for coining the felicitous term "ethnoracial pentagon." See Jill Goetz, "UC–Berkeley Historian David Hollinger to Discuss Racial, Ethnic Classifications and Their Relation to Culture in Cornell Lecture April 28," Cornell University, April 21, 1997, https://news.cornell.edu/stories/1997

/04/uc-berkeley-historian-david-hollinger-discuss-racial-ethnic-classifications-and.

34 María Lugones and Rita Segato have made substantial contributions to the intersections of sex/gender/race, grounding their argument in Quijano's coloniality of power. See, for example, Lugones, "The Coloniality of Gender"; and Rita Segato, "A Manifesto in Four Themes," *Critical Times. Interventions in Global Theory* 1, no. 1 (2018): 198–211, https://read.dukeupress.edu/critical-times/article/1/1/198/139314/A-Manifesto-in-Four-Themes. The spread of Quijano's conceptual framework should be noticed in that while Lugones's work operates in the context of US "women of color," Segato's work is grounded in the history and culture of Latin America.

35 Wynter, "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom."

36 The vocabulary to name actors and social roles was Spanish, from neither Pueblos Originarios' own languages nor the diversity of African languages spoken by the enslaved population. Coloniality of knowing and sensing is a semiotic phenomenon; it operates through the sign system spectrum (orality and literacy, images, sounds, and tastes in foods and cultural expressions).

37 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power and Subjectivity in Latin America," in this volume.

38 Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze, "The Color of Reason: The Idea of 'Race' in Kant's Anthropology," in *Postcolonial African Philosophy: A Critical. Reader*, ed. Emmanuel Chukwudi Eze, 103–40 (London: Blackwell, 1997).

39 Quijano, "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism and Latin America," in this volume (emphasis added).

40 On the word "patron" in Spanish and its English translation into "matrix," see Quijano, "The 'Indigenous Movement' and Unresolved Questions in Latin America," in this volume.

41 "Estado-Nación, ciudadanía y democracia" [1997], in Aníbal Quijano, *Cuestiones y horizontes: De la dependencia histórico-estructural a la colonialidad/descolonialidad del poder*," ed. Danilo Assis Clímaco (Buenos Aires: CLACSO, 2014), 611.

42 Quijano, "Coloniality and Modernity/Rationality," in this volume (emphasis added).

43 For an expansion on this idea, see Walter D. Mignolo, "Introduction," in *The Politics of Decolonial Investigations*, 1–84 (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2021).

44 Michel-Rolph Trouillot, "North Atlantic Universals: Analytical Fictions, 2492–1945," *South Atlantic Quarterly* 101, no. 4 (2002): 839–58. Trouillot's felicitous expression reinforces his shifting and unveiling of the abstract universal of Western modernity.

45 "The old imperialism—exploitation for foreign profit—has no place in our plans. What we envisage is a program of development based on the

concepts of democratic fair-dealing." Harry S. Truman's, "Inaugural Address," Harry S. Truman Library & Museum, January 20, 1949, https://www.trumanlibrary.gov/library/public-papers/19/inaugural-address.

46 Quijano, "Notes on the Decoloniality of Power," in this volume (emphasis added).

47 Quijano, "Notes on the Decoloniality of Power" (emphasis added).

48 Aníbal Quijano, personal communication to the author.

49 See Segato, "Aníbal Quijano and the Coloniality of Power."

50 See Segato, "Anibal Quijano and the Coloniality of Power."

51 See Mario Rufer, "El perpetuo conjuro: tiempo, soberanía y una mirada poscolonial sobre la escritura de la historia," *Revista Historia y Memoria*, Dossier Miradas de la Historia, Bogotá, 2020.

52 See Rita Segato, "The Deep Rivers of the Latin American Race: A Rereading of Mestizaje," in *The Critique of Coloniality: Eight Essays*, 159–84 (London: Routledge, 2022).

53 The expression of "the return of the future" as a past in motion is rooted in Aymara thought and language: *qhip nayra uñtasis sarnaqapxañani* means "the past lies ahead, the future lies behind." In Quechua as well, there is the same relational cyclic structure. Hurtado de Mendoza states that it is "natural for Quechua speakers to state that the past lies ahead and the future lies behind. Also, "*pachakuti* are not a return to previous stages, instances or states just to repeat them, but to reorder, reform or transform them upon new principles, following new paradigms." William Hurtado de Mendoza Santander, *Pragmática de la cultura y lengua Quecha* (Cusco: Centro de Estudios Regionales Andinos Bartolomé de las Casas, 2001), 77–78 and 73. From a different interpretive model, Martina Faller and Mario Cuéllar explain that in Quechua, "returning from a temporal unit does not mean that we are returning to the same point in time. Instead, we suppose that these units are conceptualized as abstract containers that are filled with different events in every return." Martina Faller y Mario Cuéllar, "Metáforas del tiempo en el quechua," University of Manchester, 2003, https://personalpages.manchester.ac.uk/staff/martina.t.faller/documents/Faller-Cuellar.pdf.

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PARADOXES OF MODERNITY IN LATIN AMERICA

The world crisis of capital has intensified the debate over contemporary society and culture. It is not only the economy that has been called into question; indeed, the entire framework of knowledge, the presuppositions of rationality in the relationships between peoples themselves and with the world around them, the projects of historical meaning, the balance of fundamental human experiences, such as capitalism and socialism as it actually exists—all perspectives and all alternatives are open to critical appraisal once more.

The position and significance of Latin America in this debate are fundamental. This is the case not only because Latin America has been a victim of the most perverse effects of the crisis, but, more significantly, because of the weight of its historical presence in the construction of the culture of our time, because of the fecundity it possesses for the reconstitution of that culture.

This surely explains the intensification of the Latin American debate itself, although this may be denied by certain groups in certain places whose exclusive concern is that of access to one or another rungs of presently established power. Behind this facade, nevertheless, genuine and critical questions are being posed whose intellectual or pragmatic exploration surely will affect not only Latin America. One of these questions—in one sense the most decisive and central one—is the relationship between the

private and the public, because within this relationship virtually every area of contemporary social existence is implicated. Beyond the circumstantial disputes on the Peruvian scene, the debate in question does in fact encompass all the meaning and all the legitimacy of the principal historical projects now available.

Modernity and "Modernization" in Latin America

The pressure to "modernize" has been exerted on Latin America during the greater part of this century, but especially, and in a very distinctive manner, since the end of World War II. In the first place, this pressure was exerted to a large degree by the actions and interests of agencies who were not Latin American, who were, as it were, external. In the second place, such pressure appeared formally as an invitation to accept fully the methods of production, the styles of consumption, and the culture and social and political organization of developed capitalist countries, considered as paradigms of a successful "modernization." In practice, this amounted to the requirement of changes and adaptations in the region to the needs of capital in its phase of inter- or transnational maturity.

By the end of the war the nucleus of historical rationality of modernity had been weakened, and modernity itself had entered into a period of crisis in the face of violent attacks by dark political forces that appealed to the irrationalities of the species, to prejudice and to the myths founded upon it, in opposition to the initial achievements of modernity, seeking to convert the people to the cult of violence and offering naked power as its most attractive legitimating principle. Of course, such forces, like Nazism, had been defeated in the war. However, after this experience, after Auschwitz, the promises of modernity would not again be "vivified with the enthusiasm and hopes of yesteryear," as Jose Medina Echevarria pointed out at the beginning of the Latin American debates of the 1960s. Even worse, there is no doubt that it was in this context that the dark reign of instrumental reason was consolidated, claiming for itself alone, and against historical reason, the prestige and luster of the name of modernity. It is still worth noting that it was not clear to many—and was not admitted by others—that this reign not only blanketed the Western world but also consolidated itself under Stalinism.

It seems necessary at this point to raise questions concerning two of the consequences of this process in respect to Latin America. First, since "modernization" arrived late in these lands, from the outside, already constituted

and already in practice, an idea took shape to which many are still prisoners: the idea that Latin America has always been only a passive and late recipient of modernity. Second, and by implication, there is the question of the confusion between modernity and "modernization." Because of this confusion (although intellectual snobbery plays an important role here), today it is not difficult to find in Latin America political and intellectual groups who once again enter the temples of the same gods who rely on the irrationalities of the species to win converts to the cult of naked power.

Modernity as a category was certainly molded in Europe, particularly from the eighteenth century onward. It was, however, a result of a complex of changes that occurred throughout the totality of the world that was subjected to European domination beginning at the end of the fifteenth century. If the intellectual elaboration of these changes had Europe as its principle center, this corresponded to the centrality of Europe's position in this totality, to its position of dominance.

This new historical totality, in whose context modernity was produced, was constituted at the beginning of the conquest and was the incorporation of what was to become Latin America into the world of Europe. The process of production of modernity had a direct and inextricable relationship to the historical creation of Latin America. In respect to this relationship, I not only refer to the well-known fact that Latin American production, primarily of precious metals, was at the base of the original accumulation of capital. Nor do I refer only to the fact that the conquest of America was the first moment of the formation of the world market as the real context within which capitalism and its world-logic could emerge as the material foundation of the production of European modernity.

For Europe, the conquest of America was also a discovery. It was a discovery in the plain geographical sense but most of all a discovery of experiences and of original and different historical meanings that revealed, to the astonishment of Europe (well beyond the appeal of exoticism), distinct historical crystallizations of certain ancient aspirations that until then had no existence other than in myths attributed to an unknown past. It is of no importance that this European vision of the American experience exaggerated reality, exalted by an imagination whose boundaries had been dissolved by the wonder of discovery. It is not important, because this stretching of the frontiers of the European imagination was precisely the consequence of America. And from our perspective, we cannot overlook the fact that exaggerated or not, many of the forms of social existence

that the Europeans sought were in fact indigenous to the reality of the American experience, especially the Andean experience: the joy of a social solidarity devoid of violent injustice, the legitimacy of a diversity of solidarities, and reciprocity in the relationship to property and the surrounding world, so completely different from the conditions of European society at that time.

I suggest therefore that this discovery of America produced a profound revolution in the European imagination and, consequently, in the imagination of the Europeanized world of domination: *it produced a replacement of the past as the site of a forever-lost golden age with the future as a golden age to achieve or to construct*.

Without America, how could we imagine the emergence of the peculiar European utopia of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, a utopia in which the first signs of a new rationality are already discernible, a rationality that installed the future as the realm of hope and of rationalization in place of the omnipresent past that until then had been the exclusive reference point for all legitimacies, for all explanations, for all the dreams and nostalgias of humanity?

This seems to me to be the central meaning of the utopias that were created in Europe after the discovery of America. And the rise of these specific utopias should be recognized as the first moment of the process of the creation of modernity. Without the new place of the future in the imagination of humanity, the very idea of modernity would be unthinkable.

For Europe at that time, still not having overcome the crisis of feudal society, the utopia of a society without ominous hierarchies, injustice, or obscurantism was the ideology for a long struggle against feudalism, the despotism of absolute monarchies, the power of a church that controlled and blocked the development of knowledge, the supremacy of private interest that grew with mercantilism. In other words, the promise of modernity originated from the struggle for a rational society. At this first moment of the process of the creation of modernity, America occupied a fundamental place.

I would also suggest that there was a close association between America during the crystallization stage of modernity, the seventeenth century, and the movement called the Enlightenment, or Illuminism. During that period, America was not only a recipient but also a part of the universe in which that movement was created and in which it developed, because it developed simultaneously in Europe and in colonial Latin America.

That the Enlightenment movement occurred simultaneously in Europe and America throughout the seventeenth century can be seen first of all by the fact that the institutions, research, concepts, and knowledge that emerged as the Enlightenment were simultaneously formed and diffused in both Europe and America. The Societies of the Friends of the Country (Las Sociedades de Amigos del País) were formed in both places and also at the same time. The same questions for research and the same topics of discussion and investigation were circulated. The same spirit of interest in the exploration of nature using the same instruments of knowledge were disseminated. And everywhere the urge to reform society and its institutions was affirmed to clear the path for political liberty and freedom of conscience and the critique of inequalities and abuses in the relationships between peoples.

When Humboldt came to America, he could not restrain his surprise that the circles of American intellectuals and scholars in each of the principal centers he visited knew the same things and studied the same things as their European counterparts, not only because they read the same materials but most of all because they posed the same questions and attempted to explore these questions with the same passionate eagerness, even if under less propitious conditions. Thus, the spirit of modernity and its promises and demands began to develop with equal intensity in Europe and America.

Many Latin American intellectuals and politicians were direct participants in the debates and the political experiences of the European Enlightenment. For instance, it should not be considered a mere anecdotal fact that the Peruvian Pablo de Olavide was celebrated in the Enlightenment circles of Europe, that he was a friend of Voltaire, and that he participated in the inner circles of the French Encyclopedists and in the political experiences of the Spanish Enlightenment. When de Olavide became a victim of persecution by the Inquisition, his first bio-bibliography was published by Diderot himself, initiating a vast movement in solidarity with the Peruvian in all the circles of European Enlightenment. It is not surprising, then, that at the beginning of the following century, when the Cadiz parliament (Cortes de Cadiz) met in 1810, the Latin American deputies were among the most coherent bearers of the spirit of modernity, the most advanced defenders of radical liberalism. As such, they played an outstanding role in the writing of the liberal constitution in a commission presided over by one of their own, the Peruvian Morales Duárez, who was later elevated to the presidency of parliament.

The Paradox of Modernity in Latin America

It is clear, then, that the movement for modernity occurred in the seventeenth century in Latin America at the same time as in Europe. Here, nevertheless, we discover a surprising and paradoxical fact.

While in Europe modernity spread and flourished—nourished by the development of capitalism with all that it implied for the production of material goods and the relationships between peoples—in Latin America, especially from the last third of the eighteenth century onward, a noticeable contradiction developed between, on the one hand, the ideological and social requirements of modernity and, on the other, the stagnation and disarticulation of the mercantile economy and even its retrogression in certain areas of the Andes. As a consequence, those who rose to the top of society and power were those most allied with inequality and injustice, with despotism and obscurantism. With the well-known exceptions of those areas most immediately linked to European capitalist development, most of what emerged as Latin American was characterized by this contradiction.

In Europe, modernity took shape along definite lines as part of daily experience as well as social practice and legitimating ideology. In Latin America, on the contrary, until well into the twentieth century, a profound and extended breach persisted between the ideology of modernity and social practice, not infrequently within the same social and political institutions. In particular, modernity became a form of legitimating ideology for political practices that clearly were in opposition to its discourse, while modern social practices were repressed because they could not be legitimated by any application of the dominant ideologies.

The use of modernity as a "legitimating" ideology of antagonistic social practices allows us to appreciate the ideological weight of modernity in Latin America, in spite of its imprisonment in a social universe of the opposite sign. Modernity allows us to explain, for example, the curious relationship between nominally liberal institutions and the conservative power that was established with independence. This cannot be explained in turn without recalling that modernity, as a movement of consciousness, was not simply an imported foreign product but a product of Latin American soil itself, when that soil was still a fertile and rich territory for mercantilism even though under colonial domination.

In sum, modernity in Latin America, especially since the nineteenth century, learned how to live as intellectual consciousness but not as daily social experience. Perhaps this explains the trap fallen into by Latin American

liberalism in this century: being compelled to cultivate the chimera of modernity without revolution. It has still not worked its way free from this trap.

Power and Modernity in Europe

At the same time, while the Latin American history of modernity is certainly paradoxical, its European avatar not only did not itself form modernity from contradiction but rendered it a victim of the Procrustean demands of the very power to which it owed its existence: bourgeois reason.

During the process of the creation of modernity, the idea of rationality inherent within it did not mean the same thing in each of the centers that created it and disseminated it in Europe. In simplistic terms, within the limits of the present discussion, it should be noted that in the northern or Saxon countries, the predominant idea of rationality was, from the beginning, fundamentally linked to what, since Horkheimer, has been known as "instrumental reason." Above all, this is a relationship between ends and means. The rational is the useful. And utility acquires its meaning from the dominant perspective (i.e., that of power).

On the other hand, in the countries of the South, the predominant idea of rationality was formed, especially in the debate concerning society, primarily in relation to the definition of ends. These ends were those of the liberation of society from all inequality, injustice, despotism, and obscurantism. In other words, these ends were defined against the existing arrangements of power. There, modernity was conceived as a promise of rational social existence as well as a promise of freedom, of equity, of solidarity, of the continuous improvement of the material conditions of *these* forms of social existence, not of any other. This is what came to be recognized from that time forward as "historical reason."

I stress the fact that I am engaging in deliberate oversimplification, given the limits of space, in drawing this distinction between northern and southern Europe in respect to conceptions of rationality and modernity. Nevertheless, this does not imply arbitrariness on my part. It is no happenstance that the leaders of the antimodernist movement of the North American neoconservatives, such as Irving Kristol, for example, insist on their rejection of "French-Continental Enlightenment" and their adherence to the "Anglo-Scottish Enlightenment"—that of Locke, Hume, Smith—in order to justify the privileges of some in respect to others in society. Nor is it coincidental that one of the most strident spokespersons of the neoconservatism addicted to Reaganism, Jeanne Kirkpatrick, does not hesi-

tate to affirm that without the defense of authority and order—including inequality, despotism, and injustice—modernism is but a mere utopia in the pejorative sense of the word.

This difference became a crucial question for the fate of modernity and its promises as hegemony in the power of capital and the relationships of power between the bourgeoisies of Europe moved, at the beginning of the eighteenth century and especially throughout the century, under the control of the British bourgeoisie. In this way, the "Anglo-Scottish" wing of the Enlightenment and of modernity imposed itself on the entirety of bourgeois reason, not only in Europe but also on a world scale because of the imperial power achieved by the British bourgeoisie. Instrumental reason imposed itself upon historical reason.

The world dominance of the "Anglo-Scottish" version of modernity, that of instrumental reason, was strengthened and extended when British imperial hegemony gave way to North American hegemony at the end of World War II. The Pax Americana established after the defeat of Nazism and the further weakening of historical reason during that period exacerbated both the characteristics and the consequences of the domination of instrumental reason.

It is under the domination of the Pax Americana and its extreme version of instrumental reason that after World War II, pressure was exerted on Latin America to "modernize" (i.e., to accept a rationality shorn of all connections with the original promises of modernity, a rationality now totally and solely possessed by the demands of capital and productivity, by the efficiency of the means to secure the ends imposed by capital, and by empire, in the last analysis, reason as the mere instrument of power). This reinforced in wide sectors of Latin America the delusive chimera of modernity without revolution. The consequences are still with us. We have not yet escaped the dark tunnel of militarism and authoritarianism.

Perhaps the most complete example of what is implied by successful "modernization" in Latin America is provided by the transition from the oligarchic state to the modernized state. In all these countries, states have "modernized"; their institutional apparatuses have grown and have even become professionalized to a certain degree, most of all their institutions of repression. The state is less of a prisoner of society and is in a certain sense (i.e., in respect to the scope of its activities) more national. None of this, however, has made it more democratic, more equipped to satisfy the needs of its population, or more legitimately representative or even, it would seem, more stable.

The present hegemony has, however, affected more than bourgeois reason. For even that which originated as an alternative to bourgeois reason, the most direct and legitimate bearer of the liberationist promises of modernity over a long period of time yielded to the seductions of instrumental reason. Socialism could not establish itself except as "socialism as it actually exists," as Stalinism.

This is the modernity that has burst into a crisis proclaimed by new prophets, almost all of them apostates of their previous faith—socialism—or, at the very least, of radical liberalism. However, these prophets of "postmodernity"—on both sides of the Atlantic—also want to persuade us that the liberationist promises of modernity not only are now but have always been impossible, that no one can still believe in them after Nazism and Stalinism, and that the only thing real is power, its technology, its discourse.

The crisis of modernity as redefined by the complete dominance of instrumental reason follows the same course as the crisis of capitalist society, particularly as each of these crises has developed since the end of the 1960s. This form of modernity, of course, deserves no defense, nor should it be the object of any form of nostalgia, especially in Latin America. It was under its dominion that the task of satisfying the worst imperatives of capital were imposed upon us for the benefit of the bourgeoisie of Europe and the United States, beginning at the very moment in independence when the hegemony of historical reason over the consciousness of the Latin Americans was displaced, although without any loss of the prestige of the label of modernity.

The problem, moreover, is that the prophets of postmodernity and of antimodernity not only invite us to celebrate the funeral of the liberationist promises of historical reason and its specific form of modernity but, even more importantly, never again to pose the questions implied by that modernity, never again to struggle against existing power for the liberation of society, to accept from now on only the logic of technology and the discourse of power. Behind the smoke screen of this debate, it is impossible not to perceive the familiar spirit of those same forces that, after the crisis that led to World War I, organized themselves to attack and to attempt to destroy the very seeds of all utopias of equality, solidarity, and liberty. They were, of course, not totally successful. But historical reason was debilitated in the face of their onslaught. Today, these same forces seem to be emerging once again in search of final victory. On the other hand, the conjunction of both crises has had the effect that certain crossroads of debate concerning society have been turned into what appear to be genuine cul-de-sacs. This is

particularly serious in respect to the debate concerning the problems of the dependent societies, societies constructed on the basis of extreme inequalities, societies that in no sense have succeeded in achieving a definitive eradication of the arbitrary and despotic exercise of power, not even in the limited sense that this has taken place in the advanced capitalist societies. Upon the dependent societies, such as those of Latin America, descends the weight of all the problems of the extreme concentration of power and, at the same time, those generated by the styles and levels of life characteristic of the capitalist development of Europe and the United States.

In Latin America, however, modernity has a more complex history than that which characterizes it as linked to the history of Euro–North America. Within this history there not only remain the elements of a proposal for an alternative rationality, but, even more importantly, these elements are again beginning to reconstitute themselves. This is true, among other reasons, because the logics of capital and instrumental reason have not been able, precisely because of the weakness of their development, to extinguish or to negate definitively those same historical meanings that, when revealed to the wonder of Europe at the beginning of the fifteenth century, engendered the onset of a new rationality. These meanings have been bruised and wounded but are by no means buried.

The Tension of Subjectivity in Latin America

In the 1960s, we Latin Americans discussed the problems of social reality and change in this reality. Now, however, we are desperate to establish our identity. What is behind this search for identity is that the formative elements of our reality have not abandoned their strained relationships among themselves: they are slowing down and rendering more difficult the historical sedimentation that could have compacted and made firm the foundation of our social existence and made less urgent, and perhaps less recurrent, the necessity of journeying, always, in pursuit of identity.

The present intersubjective universe of Latin America could hardly be presented as a culture constructed around defined nuclei of articulation or one composed out of materials that have completely fused. But this is due only in part to its past; in larger part it is due to the uninterrupted reproduction of its dependency, its position under Euro–North American domination. This is not only a question of subordination but, above all, a recognition that the very construction of this universe takes place as a function of this dependency.

One of the most insistent expressions of the internal tensions of Latin American intersubjectivity is the permanent note of duality in intellectual style, in sensibility, in imagination. This duality cannot be attributed simplistically to the opposition between the modern and the nonmodern, as the apologists of "modernization" have continually claimed. Rather, it relates to the rich, varied, and dense condition of the elements that nurture this culture but whose oppositions have not been completely fused into new meanings and consistencies that can be articulated autonomously within a new and distinctive structure of intersubjective relationships.

The plentitude and perhaps the precariousness of this process of the production of a new and autonomous cultural universe are related to the same factors that reproduce imperial domination and the hegemony of instrumental reason, factors that have been strengthened under the forces of "modernization."

Perhaps the best exemplar of the presence of this tension and this note of duality in the Latin American intelligentsia is Mariátegui.[1] A Marxist, today considered the greatest of Latin American Marxists, Mariátegui was also not a Marxist. He believed in God, explicitly. He proclaimed that it is not possible to live without a metaphysical conception of existence. And he always felt himself close to Nietzsche. Mariátegui's discoveries concerning the specificity of the social reality of Latin America cannot be understood outside of this tension in his thought and his entire orientation toward life, because outside of this tension these discoveries would perhaps never have been made. At the very least, all those who at the same time analyzed the same reality but whose sole attachment was to European rationalism accomplished nothing more than the search of our land for the reproduction of Europe.

The same tension permeates everything and everyone—or almost everyone—in Latin America. But this is not only a result of our reading European books while living in a completely different world. If it were only this, we would only be "Europeans exiled in these savage pampas"—as many have urged—or we could have as our only aspiration to be accepted as Europeans or, better yet, Yankees, as undoubtedly is the dream of many. We could not, consequently, cease to be all that we have never been and never will be.

It is a matter of the specificity or, if you wish, one of the meanings that are forming the Latin American identity: the relationship between history and time is here completely different than that which appears in Europe and the United States. In Latin America, what in these other histories is

sequence is a simultaneity. It does not cease being a sequence. But it is preeminently a simultaneity. Thus, for example, what in Europe were stages of the history of capital, here form the layers of capital. In Latin America, the stages of capital coexist as layers: operative here is "original accumulation," competitive accumulation, monopolistic inter- and transnational accumulation. We cannot say that they are only stages in a sequence, for they function within a pyramidal structure of layers of domination. But neither can we completely deny them their condition as stages. Time in this history is simultaneity and sequence, simultaneously.

We have to deal with a different history of time and a different time of history. This is what a lineal or, even worse, unilineal perception of time, a unidirectional perception of history—such as that which characterizes the dominant version of Euro–North American rationalism under the hegemony of instrumental reason—cannot, in its own cognitive matrix, incorporate into its own modes of producing or rendering rationally meaningful its own perspectives. And it is also this which we ourselves, although forever anguished by the intimation of its presence, have also not been able fully to identify or to appropriate as our own historical meaning, our identity, as a cognitive matrix, because we were not able to free ourselves in time from that same rationalism.

Nevertheless, at least for many of us, this was the most genuine meaning of our searchings and perplexities during the period of the agitated debates over dependency. However, it is undoubtedly true that we were only able to glimpse it here and there. It is not therefore by any means accidental that it was not a sociologist but rather a novelist such as Gabriel García Márquez who, by good fortune or through awareness, discovered the path to this revelation, because of which, indeed, he merited the Nobel Prize. Thus, in what other way than the mythical-aesthetic could we become aware of this simultaneity of every historical time in the same Time? What other way than by converting all times into one Time? And what, other than mythical, could this Time of all times be? Paradoxically, this strange manner of revealing the nontransferable identity of a history turns out to be a rationality, for it renders the universe intelligible and renders intelligible the specificity of that universe. This, in my judgment, is what García Márquez essentially did or achieved in *One Hundred Years of Solitude*.

This relationship between history and time in Latin America exercises itself in other dimensions. The past runs through the present in a manner distinct from the way it existed in the European imagination before modernity. It is not the nostalgia of a golden age because of being, or having been,

the continent of innocence. Among us, the past is or can be an experience of the present, not its nostalgia. It is not lost innocence but rather integrated wisdom, the union of the tree of knowledge with the tree of life that the past defends within us against instrumental rationalism as the form of an alternative proposal of rationality. Reality is seen, makes itself seen, as a totality, with all its magic. Rationality here is not a disenchantment of the world but rather the intelligibility of its totality. The real is not the rational except insofar as it does not exclude its magic. Juan Rulfo and José María Arguedas narrated this rationality from the privileged seats of our inheritance of the original rationality in Latin America.[2] But the title that gave it a name for universal communication, "magical realism"—entirely a *contradictio in termini* for European rationalism, the disenchanter of the world—came, perhaps not totally by chance, from Alejo Carpentier,[3] the most intellectual or, if you prefer, the most "European" of the Latin American narrators who had the audacity and the good fortune to make the "journey to the seed." Perhaps this is because there were few such as he in whom European intellectual formation could be carried to the boundary of all its tensions and reconstituted by the recognition of a "real miracle."

This relationship of tension between the past and the present, the simultaneity and the sequence of the Time of history, the note of duality in our sensibility, cannot be explained outside of the relations of domination between Europe and Latin America, the copresence of Latin America in the production of the original modernity, the excision of rationality and the hegemony of instrumental reason, in short, the stamping feet of modernization in Latin America.

It is because of this specific history, because of the noninterrupted production of our dependency in this history, that each time there is a crisis in European rationality and, consequently, in the intersubjective relations between the European and the Latin American, the process of sedimentation of our very subjectivity also enters into crisis, and we once again set forth in pursuit of our elusive identity. Today the reason that this quest is more urgent than at other times is surely that the criollo—the oligarchic culture that arose after the metamorphosis of modernity in Latin America—has lost, irrevocably, the social bases for its reproduction and is in advanced bankruptcy without it yet being clear what will replace its hegemony. For this reason, there is no doubt that this anguished demand for identity is stronger in all those countries and among those groups where the pressures of the transnational to form a new "criollo-oligarchic" culture, a new colonialism, have not succeeded in vanquishing what was created

from the Indian and the Black, from all that is natively constituted in our intersubjective relations: have not yet succeeded in subordinating these cultural creations and leaving them once again chained in the shadows of domination.

That which is native in our culture is an unfinished product of the way in which the elements that emerge from the relationship of domination and conflict have been reorganized and rechanneled when the bases and the institutions of power were eaten away and partially demolished by the eruption of the dominated toward the front stage of history, in other words, when the basic elements of our subjective universe once again became original. With these elements a new utopia is being constituted, a new historical meaning, a proposal for an alternative rationality.

THE BASIS OF ANOTHER MODERNITY: THE OTHER PRIVATE AND THE OTHER PUBLIC

Undoubtedly, the most notable of the cul-de-sacs that have been made apparent by the current crises of instrumental reason and capitalist society is that which encloses the conflict between private property and state property in the means of production to such an extent that even the most general discussion of the relationships between state and society eventually comes to be structured around this dispute.

Of course, posed in these terms, the debate between the public and the private in the economy and the society cannot escape from its current entrapment. Both sides of the debate and of the conflict display, fundamentally, the same assumptions and categories of thought. The private is seen as the private sphere molded by capitalistic interest. That which is the state or the public is the state-public of the private sphere viewed in this manner, its rival perhaps but not its antagonist. In both perspectives, it is the same instrumental reason that bites its own tail. Although this cul-de-sac in the current debates is not confined to Latin America or even to the totality of the so-called Third World, we will here restrict our discussion to Latin America.

Two extreme positions compete for dominance in the economic orientation of present-day society. One is "really existing socialism," which we now know as that which was organized under Stalinism and for which the proposed total nationalization of the means of production, the mechanisms of distribution, and the decisions concerning the direction of the total operations of the economy are at its center. As received in Latin America, this

idea has been influential not only in those proposals defined as socialist but also in the various shades of populism-nationalism-developmentalism. Seventy years later, we can be reasonably assured that we can proceed no further along this path as an attempt to attain a rational society from the point of view of the promises of socialism. The economy can only be developed until it reaches the limit where bureaucratic asphyxia becomes extreme. Neither equity, social solidarity, freedom, nor a producer's democracy can take root or be developed along this path.

The other extreme is the proposal of "neoliberalism," for which private capitalist property in the means of production and the "invisible hand" of the market—ideally free from any limitations, control, or orientation on the part of the state—are the sine qua non for the creation and generalized distribution of wealth and full political democracy. But this proposal—and certainly for a longer time than the seventy years of "actually existing socialism"—has proven, beyond any doubt and particularly in the experience of the immense majority of Latin Americans, that it also does not lead to equality, social solidarity, or political democracy.

In the historical experience that we currently live in and observe, this form of the private leads to the verticalism of the big business corporations, a likely equivalent of the "modernized" verticalism, of the bureaucracies of "really existent socialism" (i.e., liberalized through the reintroduction of greater market relations). And it is in the name of these proposals and of these interests that the freedom and democracy of society and of the state fail to be consolidated in Latin America, and their limited existence in the developed capitalist countries are once again threatened.

The current liberalization of the economy and of the state in the major countries of "really existing socialism" appears in the mass media not as what it actually is, the unveiling of the specific historical character of that experience, but rather as the definitive eclipse of the very idea of socialism. "Neoliberalism" can thus present itself as the only option effectively equipped to establish or to continue the course toward the development of wealth and democracy in contemporary society.

In Latin America today, few besides the immediate defenders of the domination of capital and its empires can with confidence believe in the songs of the siren of "neoliberalism." But at the same time, after the recent experiences of "really existing socialism," it is unlikely that the partisans of the nationalization of the economy by the state can be as numerous as they once were. Perhaps it is this and no other thing that is being expressed in the virtual paralysis of economic activity in our countries. All of them

without exception are marking time, frequently for the short term, without the advancement of long-range projects or even many proposals in that direction. In fact, the debate between neoliberalism and the type of "neodevelopmentalism" that it opposes ("neo" because its themes and proposals, although the same as the old developmentalism, are now weak and barely audible) has been turned into a trap, a dead end from which there appears to be no exit.

It does not seem to me difficult to discover the source of entrapment of this debate, the fact that in opposition are the private capitalist sphere and the state capitalist sphere (i.e., two faces of the same instrumental reason), each masking its social agents that now compete for the center of control of capital and power: the private bourgeoisie and the bureaucracy (for some, the state bureaucracy). In the last analysis, in neither of them resides a solution to the urgent problems of our societies, much less the liberationist promises of historical reason.

Private capitalism or, more generally, private mercantilism implies an interest opposed to society as a whole; hence, it cannot be compatible with equity, with solidarity, with freedom, or with a democracy that is constituted by these factors except within the limits set by private interest. That which is the state or that which is the public of this private sphere is the exact expression of this limited compatibility: this accommodation emerges and imposes itself precisely when the ultimate logic of domination is in danger. And it only expresses itself in its limited forms under the pressure of the dominated. State capitalism, "really existing socialism," and the "welfare state" belong to the same family but perform within different contexts and fulfill different needs. Although the complete nationalization of the economy and the dominance of the state over society are presented as instruments of the global interest against the private, since domination and inequality are not extinguished or even approach extinction, the private is in fact being reestablished in these economies. Thus, the private bears the advantage of appearing as the necessary option when the bureaucratic asphyxia caused by the advance of the state smothers the dynamisms of production.

The private sphere seems, then, to be working. But the historical experience of Latin America permits the suggestion that the capitalist or mercantilist form of the private is not the only form possible, nor is the public, in the specific form of the state, the only other face for the private or for everything private. In fact, although this point is not usually formally made in the debate over these questions, there is another private and another public that not only formed a part of the previous history of Latin America but also

continue to be active and are beginning to emerge within larger and more complex spheres of action.

By way of making this point more graphic, and not because I propose it as a desirable or effective option, I would offer at this point the example of the ancient Andean community and broach the question of its characteristics: Is it private or state-public? The answer is private. It functioned and continues to function. It functioned before imperial and colonial domination, and it functioned during the colony as the only sphere of reciprocity, solidarity, democracy, and freedom, as a refuge for the joy of solidarity under domination. It functioned later in the face of the onslaught of a liberalism already won over to instrumental reason, in the face of *gamonalismo*.[4] And it still functions in the face of capital. And it is private.

What I mean to suggest with this example is that there is another private, a private that is not capitalist, not mercantile. There is not only one sphere of the private. And this private functions effectively. How are we to name this sphere of the private? For the moment, conscious of the provisionality of the term, I propose naming it the "social-private" to differentiate it from the "egoist private."

I must reaffirm, however, that I am not in any manner proposing a return to an agrarian communitarianism such as that present in precolonial Andean history or even that existing today. Today's society, its needs and possibilities, are undoubtedly too complex to be enclosed and fulfilled within an institution such as this. At the same time, neither does this imply that such an institution can or cannot be a base, or one of the bases, for the construction of another rationality. After all, was it not under its impact on the European imagination that the history of European modernity and the powerful utopia of a rational society began?

By the same token, it should be clear that if I allude to the reconstitution of a private equivalent to Andean social community in Latin America, it is because in its present historical experience in the context of a complex and tremendously diversified society, it is possible to discern and observe this private sphere's mode of operation: communitarian and collective organization, democratically constituted and relying on reciprocity as the foundation of solidarity and democracy. Today it in fact constitutes one of the most widespread forms of organizing the daily life and experience of vast populations of Latin America in their dramatic search to organize themselves for survival and to resist the crisis and the logic of underdeveloped capitalism.

These forms of social experience cannot in any way be considered as simply conjunctural or transitory. Their institutionalization has already taken on sufficient weight that it can be recognized as consolidated social practice for a great many sectors of the population, especially those who inhabit the universe of the poor of the cities. And these are in many cases the large majority of the population. For example, in Peru, what is known as the *barriada*,[5] slums and shanty towns, constitutes about 70 percent of the urban population, which in turn is 70 percent of the national population. Not only because of the social existence of this majority but also because of its preponderance in the nation's populace as a whole, it would be no exaggeration to affirm that the *barriada* is today, particularly in respect to the constitution of a new intersubjectivity, the fundamental social and cultural experience of Peru in the last thirty years. And the new forms of the social-private are a central aspect of this experience.

Andean reciprocity has, then, given rise to present-day reciprocity among the most oppressed layers of the urban "modernized" society of dependent capitalism and underdevelopment in Latin America. And on its soil a new social-private has been constructed, an alternative to the dominant capitalist sphere of the private.

Two issues must be clarified at this point. First, there is no doubt that the capitalist sphere of the private is widely dominant in the country as a whole as well as in the overall urban population of the *barriada* and the layers of the poor among this population. Its logic, moreover, not only coexists but also undoubtedly penetrates and modifies the reality that emerges from solidarity and democracy. The institutions that have been formed on the basis of reciprocity, equality, and solidarity are islands in a sea dominated by capital in the urban world. They are part of this sea, and in turn they modify and exercise some control over the logic of capital. Second, these institutions do not exist dispersed and unconnected with one another. On the contrary, especially in recent decades, they have tended to articulate with one another to form vast networks that frequently cover the entire space of the nation. These institutions, in other words, are coming together to form—as did (or still do) traditional labor unions—specific sectors or national organizations. But in the case of the new organizations of the social-private, the linkages among sectors and the totality of sectors form an urban chain in a manner that does not necessarily imply a separate organization. In other words, the institutionalized sphere of the social-private tends to generate its own institutionalized public sphere that, nevertheless, does not necessarily have the character of a state. It does

not convert itself into an institutional apparatus that is separate from the social practices and institutions of everyday life or society as a whole but instead is superimposed on top of these practices and institutions. The institutional sphere that articulates globally or sectorally the social-private has a public character, but it is not constituted by state power. Instead, it is constituted as a power in society.

Once these social-private institutions and their public sphere are established within the dominant context of the individual—private and its state—they cannot help but be affected by the latter or by the dominant logic of capital. Manipulation, bureaucratization, and the exploitation of power are evidence of the penetration and the performance of the individual-private, the logics of capital and its state. In spite of this, reciprocity, solidarity, and democracy resist. Nevertheless, they may be defeated and change their essence or disintegrate. This does happen and not infrequently. What is surprising, however, is that even under these conditions, the practices and institutions of the new private-social and the practices of its nonstate public institutions continue to persist, to reproduce themselves, to expand in number and kind, and to convert themselves into a new and vast network of organization of a new "civil society."

The fact that this process has spread and tends to reproduce itself in Peru is no doubt due to the violence of the crisis of that society, and, obviously, it is part of the crisis itself. An important part of the population has been driven by necessity in the face of the economic hardship to rediscover and reconstruct in a new and more complex historical context one of the deepest and most characteristic heritages of the rich and extensive Andean cultural experience.

This new social-private and its nonstate public articulation are viable. They are so viable and possess such a capacity for survival that they function under the most adverse and extreme conditions. It is of supreme importance to point out that it is precisely against these very conditions that the organizations of the social-private and the nonstate public allow for the satisfaction of the necessities of human survival. In other words, insofar as a social practice is based on solidarity, equality, freedom, and democracy, it is capable of allowing its bearers to survive in spite of and in resistance to the logics of the present power of capital and of instrumental reason. It is therefore neither arbitrary nor adventuresome to suggest that under favorable conditions, if they were not as today under the constant assault of an enemy who is the owner of power, these new social practices and their attendant public institutional networks would be able to not only

allow for survival but also serve as a framework and a foundation of a truly democratic integration of society and, at the same time, open the possibility to achieve a full and differentiated realization of individual potentials (i.e., to realize the liberationist promises of a rational, modern society in the genuine meaning of these terms).

Latin America: An Option for Another Rationality

What is today spreading through and dominating the crisis of modernity in Latin America is not only the final dislodgement of historical reason, to the advantage of instrumental reason, but is also a species of culturalism whose central claim is the rejection of all modernity, including, of course, liberationist rationality itself, and the return to the particular characteristics of specific cultures as the sole legitimating criteria of social practices and their institutions.

Both of these sources of pressure on contemporary society converge in their interests. Together, in fact, they are the foundation of all the fundamentalisms that currently prosper in every latitude and in every doctrine. Both seek the sovereignty of prejudice and myth as principles of orientation for social practice, because it is only upon these that a defense can be made of all inequalities and all hierarchies, of all racisms, all chauvinisms, all xenophobia. In this respect, there are no major differences between North American fundamentalism and that of Le Pen in France, the racists of South Africa, the followers of Sun Yung Moon, the Islamic fundamentalists, and the Stalinists. This is because there exists no real incompatibility between the ideological hegemony of fundamentalism in the orientation of social practice and that of instrumental reason as a basis of domination. If this were not the case, one could not, for example, understand the peculiar doctrine of Jeanne Kirkpatrick concerning "traditional" autocracies.

Since Euro–North American rationality—one has to insist on its instrumental rationality—has been a part of colonialism and imperialism, which have not only exploited the labor of the world's peoples but also despised and destroyed, when they were able to, their cultures, the idea of a simplistic rejection of all modernity and rationality that has its attractions in many quarters. This is understandable, but we must not blind ourselves to the potential and actual contraband that under this attractive mantle dominant groups everywhere attempt to smuggle in to preserve their power against the growing pressures for the liberation of society.

It is necessary to point out that as the current crisis of capitalist society has become more visible and prolonged, faith in instrumental reason has been deteriorating in widening sectors of our societies, and correspondingly, the need for a different sense of historical meaning has been gaining in intensity and urgency; this is taking place on a universal scale. Paradoxically, particularly among the dominated peoples in our societies, this is what has engendered the demand for a break with European modernity, with Euro–North American rationality, and has resulted in a turn toward a purely culturalist particularism. But it has engendered equally the search for new foundations for a liberationist rationality in the heritages of those very cultures that Eurocentrism, once all-powerful, attempted to convince itself and others were alien to all rationality or had been totally sterilized by domination.

In the case of Latin America, it is a well-known fact that the rediscovery of the specific rationality of the dominated cultures has also involved the rediscovery of the same principles that were revealed to the European imagination at the end of the fifteenth century and that gave rise to the utopia of a liberationist modernity. The documentation of this fact is both vast and convincing.

It is not, then, as part of an artificial culturalism that the debate concerning the relationships between its own cultural heritage and the need for a new historical rationality has returned to front stage in Latin America. Most of all, I would suggest, it is because of the social experiences of vast collectivities that the principles of this cultural heritage can be recognized as bearers of a historical meaning opposed equally to the empire of instrumental reason and to an obscurantist culturalism. The social practices constructed from the warp and woof of reciprocity, equity, solidarity, individual freedom, and everyday democracy have proven their capacity in extremely adverse circumstances to be part of the new fabric of a liberationist ideology.

Here, it is necessary to add some precision to our argument. In the first place, it must be remembered that at the moment in which America created modernity simultaneously with Europe, its protagonists were those who wielded domination, the descendants of Europe. Their very condition as rulers prevented them from seeing that in the culture of the dominated, the "Indians," were to be found many of the elements from which European rationality had from the beginning been fashioned. When this relationship was obscured and banished by the ascendancy of the relationship between

domination and instrumental reason, the obstructed vision of the dominators became even more acute.

The oligarchic-criollo culture that was the privileged product of this encounter is today in Latin America ending its time of domination. Undermined and—in the majority of countries—its social foundations and its sources of sustaining power in disintegration, this culture has ceased to reproduce itself. Its passage left the imminent threat open to the final enthronement of "modernization" within culture (i.e., the reign of instrumental reason). This might perhaps have happened if the period of the expansion of international capital that impelled "modernization" had not met with its present limits and entered into a deep and prolonged crisis along with the entire apparatus of power in these countries. Nevertheless, it is in this context of crisis that social, ethnic, and cultural diversity has been strengthened. Consequently, we are not living through a unilineal and unidirectional transition between "tradition" and "modernization," as so many ideologues of "modernization" insist. On the contrary, it is a time of conflict and of crisis in society and in culture. The more underdeveloped the regime of capital, the wider the cracks through which the global cultural heritage that is foreign to capitalism reemerges. And to be sure, all this has occurred with the emergence of the dominated to the front stage of this conflict.

We do not have to infer from all this that the global, cultural heritage of Latin America, or the culture that is being produced and inhabited by the dominated, comes only from precolonial ancestral sources. Nothing of the kind. It is fed from the wellsprings of ancient achievements of rationality in these lands, achievements that produced reciprocity, solidarity, and the joy of collective labor. These sources conjoin with those that emanate from the African experience, and together they preserve the integrity of the tree of life—split, in other cultures, into the tree of life and the tree of knowledge—preventing rationality from being distorted into a thin and superficial rationalism. The flows from these sources merge with the currents of European and Euro–North American culture that do not cease to influence us but that our previous heritage seeks constantly to separate from, indeed to liberate from, the clogging sands of the "mere reason" of power. More recently, cultural sources from Asia continue to contribute to the enrichment of our multiple heritage, making it more complex, diverse, heterogeneous, and abundant. This heritage, then, is neither debilitated nor susceptible to being entirely absorbed by instrumental reason. The

peculiar tension of Latin American thought is constructed from the totality of this complex heritage.

There is no need therefore to confuse the rejection of Eurocentrism in the culture and instrumental logic of capital and North American and other imperialisms with some obscurantist demand to reject or abandon the original liberationist promises of modernity: most of all, *the desacralization of authority in thought and in society; liberation from social hierarchy, prejudice, and the myths founded upon prejudice; the freedom to think and to know; to doubt and to question; to express and to communicate; individual liberty freed from individualism; the idea of the equality and fraternity of all humanity and the dignity of every person*. Not all this originated in Europe. Neither was all of it fulfilled or even respected there. But it was with Europe that all this sailed to America.

Hence, the proposal of the social-private and its institutions of articulation in the nonstate public, as an alternative to the cul-de-sac into which we have been carried by the statists and privatists of capital and its power, is a Latin American proposal rooted in the perspective that Latin America is, as is no other existing historical territory, the most ancient and consistent provider of a historical rationality constituted by the confluence of the rational achievements of every culture. The utopia of a liberationist rationality of society in Latin America is not today only an illuminationist vision. Part of our daily life has become intertwined with it. It can be repressed, perhaps defeated. What it cannot be is ignored.

The Issues and the Risks

The issues that open at this point are large and many. I cannot attempt to approach or pose even the most important ones, much less discuss them in depth, within the limits of this discussion. But some of them must be stated.

In the first place, we are in the presence of a clear necessity to reformulate the problematic of the public and the private and not only within the debate in Latin America. Inasmuch as it seems to me somewhat easier to grasp the idea and the image of another sphere of the private, distinct from and ultimately opposed to the sphere of that private derived from and linked to private property and the apparatus of power that accompanies it, I believe that it is necessary to explore further the problem of the nonstate public (i.e., that public distinct from and also opposed to the state and to the public linked to it).

A primary aspect of this question of the public and the private is that in the relationship that is established between both these terms within capital and generally within every power that includes the state, the private appears as an autonomous sphere of practices and institutions that are defended and, at the same time, are articulated and expressed by the state. The dominant problem is that of the autonomy of the private sphere in relation to the state as well as the autonomy of the state to impose itself on society. It is probably because of this that in this contradictory relationship, the public institutions that link together diverse practices of civil society are not as visible as are the public institutions of the state. This is especially the case because the state is, by its very nature, a sphere of practice and institutions placed on top of and outside of the everyday life of civil society. On the other hand, in the emergent relationship between the social-private and the nonstate public, there does not exist—and there is no need to raise the question of—opposition and conflict, since here the public only exists as an aspect of the articulation of the prevailing social-private and could not exist in any other way except by altering its very nature and changing itself into a state. In contrast, every state can exist and generate and reproduce its specific institutions not only outside of but often in opposition to the characteristic institutions of civil society. Latin America has displayed throughout its entire history this peculiar disjuncture. And there is no doubt that in the debate over the state and civil society in Latin America, this is the question that poses the greatest confusion precisely because the conventional analysis begins with the presupposition of the correspondence between the institutions of the state and the character of civil society. As such, the conventional analysis precludes the questioning of the representativeness of the state even though all our historical experience weighs against this presupposition. And now under the crisis, this disjunction between society and the state reveals that representation has been for a long time in question.

This problematic raises the issue of freedom and democracy in relation to the public and the private that is critical in the current debate inside and outside of Latin America. As everyone knows, a school of thought of "Scottish–Anglo–North American" origins, dominant today in political theory, deals with the problem of individual freedoms as if they were the domain of the private and in need of defense against the penetration of the state-public. On the other hand, this affirms the necessity of order and authority whose exercise and defense requires the action of the state. Thus, a contradictory relationship is affirmed between freedom and order and

authority, which in the last analysis is the same relationship that exists between the state and civil society.

From this perspective, the problem has no basis for a solution other than an empirical one. This is evident in the less than enviable history of the relationships between order and freedom, especially in Latin America. But our experience in this regard is hardly less propitious than some of the historical experiences of Europe.

I would suggest therefore that it is no surprise that it is not historical reason, liberationist reason, that governs practice as well as theory in the relations between freedom and order but that other reason, instrumental reason, even though the idea of political freedom itself was one of the achievements of modernity. This allows us to underscore the fact that the relationships between personal freedom and the needs of the global society or "order" appear in a radically different way in the context of the relationships between the social-private and the nonstate public, to the precise degree that the needs of the global society that the nonstate public expresses are not and cannot be anything other than the articulation of the needs of collective solidarity, of reciprocity, and of democracy with differentiated individual fulfillment. At the very least, this potentiality is constitutive of this relationship, in contrast to that which is contained in the relationship of mutual exteriority that obtains between the state and society and their respective public and private.

The defense of personal freedom and even of equality, given certain conditions, may not be all that difficult to achieve in the area of the private. The historical problematic has always been to constitute and assert them in the sphere of the public, for it is there that they are at risk. To assert personal freedom in the experience of the relationships between the private and the state has until now ultimately only been possible for some at the cost of others. There have always been not only those "more equal" than others but also those more free. In the alternate context, "order" could only be the realization of the personal freedom of everyone. But this is exactly what order does not achieve and cannot achieve in the relations between state and society. Order always serves the freedom of some over that of others. One can see that this relationship between the social-private and the nonstate public that is emerging in Latin America forces us to reformulate the problem of human freedom and democracy in a different light and from a different perspective. But let us return for a moment to the social-private as such, because this allows us to look in the direction of the problem of production and distribution and to consider their ramifications and bases in this

new context. In particular, it is necessary to pose the problem of reciprocity, which I previously introduced as the basic principal sine qua non of the other private. Although the breaking down of reciprocity and its replacement by the market is fundamental to the mercantile or capitalist sphere of the private, in the social-private the market cannot occupy the same position and cannot have the same character.

Although the concept of the market in the current debate has been almost transformed into a mystical category, it is surely obvious to everyone that it represents a correlation of forces and nothing else. That is to say, it implies a relationship of power, a structure of power or a phase or moment of power. The rationality of the market therefore does not have to admit of any content, save that of the most instrumental reason. By its very nature, the market excludes reciprocity or can only accept it under exceptional circumstances as one of its means to achieve its own ends. Why? Because reciprocity is a special type of exchange: it is not necessarily based on exchange value and usually tends to be based on use value. It is not abstract equivalence, what things have in common, that counts, but precisely their diversity. In one sense it is an exchange of services that may assume the form of an exchange of objects, but not always and never necessarily. We find therefore that it is extremely viable to articulate reciprocity with equality and solidarity, an articulation that is the basis of the social practices that are now our object of exploration. Reciprocity is not a univocal category, nor is it a single form of practice, at least as it appears in the anthropological literature. Nevertheless, while the market implies fragmentation and a differentiation of interests in society and is attached to an atomistic vision of the world, reciprocity implies the articulation of the interests of society; it is part of a globalizing concept of the world.

For example, in Andean history reciprocity did not prevent the existence of either power or domination. It operated at two levels. It functioned at the base and at the apex of the structure of domination as a mechanism of solidarity, an exchange among equals. At the same time, it operated between the rulers and the dominated as a mechanism of articulation and solidarity among unequals. This indicates that reciprocity does not necessarily require equality. But in contrast to the market, it requires solidarity. In the market, persons function as exchanges of equivalent objects. In reciprocity, objects are all but symbols of the persons themselves. The market is impersonal, by nature. Reciprocity is personal.

In the current process of the constitution of the social practices we are discussing, reciprocity appears as linked to equality, to freedom and to

democracy, not only to solidarity. This makes us visibly aware of the confluence between the rationality of Andean origins and that which came from modern European modernity. If it is not for this fact completely free of the grip of domination, it still deserves to be studied in this new context as a principle of a new rationality, a product, in fact, of a history nourished by multiple and diverse histories. But it requires also to be perceived as part of a structure of power, not as a form of dissolution of all power. The articulated diversity involved in reciprocity—the social solidarity, the social equality, the personal liberty, as constituent elements of a new structure of democracy—does not imply the dissolution of all power. However *demos* it may be, it does not cease also to be *kratos*. This, furthermore, is what is involved in the formation of a public sphere for this new private. But it also implies a structure of power of a different nature than that in which the capitalist sphere of the private and the state are articulated: it is a power returned to the social. This surely must be what is being sought in the enormous pressure that can be observed being exerted everywhere today, the demand of the social to be politically expressed in a direct fashion but not necessarily in the state.

This is an issue too important to be omitted from the problematic under discussion. It is utterly necessary to make it clear that this new sphere of the private and new sphere of the public cannot achieve hegemony within social practice except to the degree that they are able to emerge as an alternative power to that which currently is in place. The present sphere of the private and its state will not fail to attempt to block, fragment, distort it or liquidate this emergence. There is no way that these new institutions can develop and consolidate except as a power capable of defending itself against the present power by ultimately triumphing over that power. But in contrast to other alternatives, this alternative of power is not only a goal but a path. And the path is being traveled.

It would not be appropriate to attempt to go beyond the limits of this discussion to open questions whose exploration would take us even further afield. The issues I have raised, I believe, are sufficiently important to initiate the debate. It is still necessary, however, to note certain qualifications and a few clarifications.

Some may ask if the institutions of the social-private and the nonstate public—given that they are based on reciprocity and solidarity, although they now also incorporate equality, freedom, and democracy—are restricted to certain cultural areas, perhaps even ethnic areas where reciprocity is a central part of cultural history (as, for example, the case of

Andean culture), for it is not surprising that such practices and social institutions are present in Peru and other countries of the Andean world. But what have these practices to do with other areas of Latin America and especially with those of the Southern Cone?

There is no doubt that the new social practices that are establishing themselves as possible carriers of a new historical rationality find a more receptive and fertile soil where they intertwine their roots with previous historical heritages. This is surely the case with the populations of Andean origin. Nevertheless, abundant evidence exists of the presence of similar practices in virtually every sector of impoverished urban populations living under the prolonged crisis now in course in every, or almost every, Latin American country. As testimony to this, we need only to allude to the history of urban land invasions for the establishment of settlements, to their forms of organization, mobilization, and support. We are not that far distant, for instance, from the unfolding of that history in Chile as well as its subsequent repression there. On the other hand, while on the subject of Chile, recent investigations on the effects of the agrarian counterreform since 1973 have pointed out the formation of peasant communities in areas where before there only existed sharecroppers or tenants: groups of peasants have discovered that by joining their smallholdings and their scant resources, they could survive; individually, they could not. This discovery of reciprocity and of solidarity among equals as the very condition of survival is not, then, necessarily occurring only as a prolongation of particular ancient cultures, although in Latin America it would be difficult to deny the force of strong cultural contradiction. Equivalent social practices are in fact documented in almost all these countries. And this is not always a result produced by a limited need, such as survival, but rather of the need to find a collective historical meaning to persevere in the face of the collapse of those meanings that until now were dominant or effectively stable. The wide network of organizations in which the Christians of liberation theology, the poor, the persecuted, and nuclei of intellectuals and professionals have joined together in resistance in all of our countries is ample demonstration of this possibility.

In the recent experience of some countries, Peru, for example, certain names such as "self-management" (*autogestión*), "associative enterprises" (*empresas asociativas*, etc.) have been used as denominations of institutions, whose character has always been essentially bureaucratic, in order to present those institutions—indeed with much propagandistic success, especially outside Peru—as vehicles of direct democracy. What is

most notable about this is that these were the work of political regimes, undoubtedly reformist, who sought to construct an institutional structure to affirm what in their view was a community of interests between entrepreneurs and workers or in general between all the social interests of the nation itself, while at the same time being clearly involved in the "modernization" of the apparatus of the state, especially its military and police sectors. This "modernization" of the state was almost solely responsible, according to all available information, for the raising of the foreign debt of Peru from some $800 million to about $10 billion in twelve years. This "modernization" of the state apparatus included the assemblage of a large sector of state capital whose management enormously increased the technobureaucratic stratum of society that, in turn, sought an alliance with international financial capital. The social groups linked to the entities called "self-managing" were viewed as a basis of the corporatist reorganization of the state, as a means of overcoming an extremely prolonged crisis of representation. The regime fell apart, principally a victim of its own contradictions, without achieving any of its objectives. And the crisis has reinforced for many the recurrent stereotype that any time in the past was better. In Latin America in recent decades, the experience of so many people has been so disastrous that they have come to believe that there will always be something worse waiting for them in the future. This may be the reason there has arisen the suspicion that the new social practices that characterize the social-private and the nonstate public will always be at risk of being co-opted, of being redefined or distorted for the social purposes as under Velasquismo.[6] Without doubt this risk is real, as is that of more open repression directed at the destruction of these practices and not only at their distortion. But what is of most concern in the present discussion is the insistence on the different nature and the different historical meaning of these current practices of the new private and the nonstate public compared to those of Velasquismo. I think that these, after all is said and done, are not difficult to discern.

It may be necessary to make a similar clarification in respect to all the political and ideological derivations associated with the category of "informality" that is put to so many uses today in Latin America. Here, it will be sufficient to underscore something that I have already touched on. In the world of the Latin American *barriada* (or *callamperias*), or of *favelas* (or *ciudades perdidas, rancherios*, etc.), the normative structures of the capitalist market and those of reciprocity and solidarity exist side by side, oppose one another, and make use of one another. A good part of the population moves

flexibly between both normative universes according to their needs, an indication that their total adhesion and definitive loyalty to either universe does not yet exist. In this sense, not only social-psychologically but also structurally, this population continues to be marginal and forms a part of the great social diversity that today characterizes the structure of Latin American society. The "informal" economy is inhabited, in large measure, by this population, although another part of it corresponds to persons definitely won over by the logic and norms of capital and its interests. Indeed, it is this conflict between the perspectives belonging to the logic and the interests of capital and those belonging to reciprocity and solidarity that certain political initiatives seek to resolve in favor of the former.

Obviously, for neoliberalism, nothing could be more plausible than the economy called "informal." In that world, the roles of the market can operate with the maximum of possible freedom; the quality and price of what is produced (goods or services) are not subject to any controls; wages are not regulated by any legal structure; there is no social security, there are no vacations, compensations, or rights to unionize. No one pays any direct taxes, although everyone demands services from the state. No organization of the exploited will be tolerated. All of this allows for a complicated meshing of articulation between the large "formal" enterprise and the "informal" market and "informal" labor, the beneficiaries of which are obvious since no "informal" economy is in reality outside the global financial apparatus of capitalism of its respective country. And no one has demonstrated that the channels for the transfer of value and benefits between the "informal" and the "formal" economy have been closed. None of this should inhibit anyone from pointing out the exceptional energy and capacity of initiative that the "informals" put into motion every day in order to be able to not only survive in the severe circumstances of this crisis but also produce, earn, and obtain employment, income, housing, etc. at the margin and at times in resistance to the state. All of this undoubtedly can and must be further stimulated and developed. But can it also be oriented and channeled? And there is the problem. Will it be developed toward the full development of capital or toward solidarity, reciprocity, the direct democracy of producers?

We must be cautious. The choice is not drawn only between statism and controlism on the one side and freedom of the market and profit earnings on the other. The defenders of the latter present such freedom as the only real guarantor of democracy against the threat of statist totalitarianism from the first alternative of this choice. This dilemma is false. Each of these paths assuredly leads to the same place: to the verticalism of corporations

that can and do compete with the state but are always profoundly articulated with the state. The split between the private sphere and the state is nothing other than a difference within the same instrumental rationality whose dominion has resulted in the present secular crisis and disorder.

Statism and capitalist privatism are actually nothing other than the Scylla and Charybdis of the navigators of our present history. We neither have to chose between them or fear them. The ship of the new liberationist rationality sails today with a new hope.

Translated from the Spanish and edited by Larry Carney

Notes

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Translator's Note: The "public" and the "private" of the title and text of this essay generally correspond to the Spanish neuter substantival forms "lo publico" and "lo privado" as used by the author. They are accurately translatable as "the public" and "the private" in the sense of "that which is public" and "that which is private." I have in places used this translation and at other places varied it with the terms "the public (private) sphere" or the "sphere of . . ." in deference to more familiar and less awkward English usage. As specific contexts within the text make clear, these latter terms are not to be understood as confined to the conceptual apparatus of the "public/private split" that informs most conventional political discussions in contemporary capitalist societies. As will be made plain in his subsequent argument, it is this very conceptual apparatus that, among other issues, the author wishes to call into question.

1 José Carlos Mariátegui (1895–1930), Peruvian writer and political activist, is generally regarded as the most original of the first group of Latin Americans to apply historical materialist analysis to the economic, social, and cultural problems of the region. His best-known and most characteristic work is the collection of essays *Seven Interpretive Essays on Peruvian Reality*.

2 Juan Rulfo (1918–1986) pioneered many of the literary techniques of the "magic realism" school of fiction in Latin America. These techniques are most clearly on display in the collection of his short stories of his native Mexico titled *The Burning Plain*. Peruvian writer José María

Arguedas (1911–1969) was a student of Quechua culture and wrote passionately of the tensions of Peruvian society revolving around the domination of the Indians by the Spanish-speaking minority.

3 Cuban writer Alejo Carpentier (1904–1980) dealt with the "tensions" of Latin American culture and social existence most trenchantly in his masterpiece, the novel *The Last Steps*.

4 *Gamonalismo* refers to the power structure based on the domination of the landlords over the Indian serfdom in the Andean countries of Latin America.

5 Although *barriadas* and other similar "marginal" urban settlements surrounding Latin American cities are often described as "slums" and "shantytowns," they typically display a highly heterogeneous assemblage of housing types, levels of living, and lifestyles. They are, however, largely outside the "regulated" or "formal" zones of settlement and provide both opportunity and refuge for masses of the urban poor and the economically straitened working classes.

6 Velasquismo was the ideology and practices of the reformist, corporatist military juntas that ruled Peru from 1968 to 1980. Juan Velasco Alvarado headed the first of these juntas (1968–1975).

2

THE AESTHETIC OF UTOPIA

It is a consistently demonstrated fact that the transformation of the world takes place first as an aesthetic transfiguration.[1] We must therefore admit that there is a fundamental relationship between utopia and aesthetics.

Why is utopia established and housed first in the realm of aesthetics? The question opens up a vast territory, the exploration of which will probably help us greatly to decipher some of the more obscure signs of contemporary passions, especially in a world such as Latin America, one constituted on the conflict over colonial domination. In particular is the knot that imprisons our current debate: the one formed on one side by the question of social liberation and on the other by that of identity (identities?).

Life Is Carved from the Same Wood as Dreams

We must inevitably begin on the path set by the question itself: in some strange way, utopia seems to be built of and to consist of the same material as aesthetics. It doesn't just reside there, like a human embryo in a test tube. There must therefore be a natural relationship between the two, not merely an external or contingent one. In this specific sense, we have to accept utopia as a phenomenon that is aesthetic in nature. That is not the same thing, however, as saying that utopia is nothing more than an aesthetic phenomenon.

If we accept that utopia is not a mere fantasy or arbitrary construct and thus is easily dispensable and even contemptible but instead is a project of reestablishing the historical meaning of a society,[2] the result is not simply that utopia fills the peculiar territory of the intersubjective relationships that we recognize as society's imaginary, where the realm of aesthetics lies. That in itself would be very important. But what's at stake, above all, is that there's an aesthetic sense in every utopia without which the antennas of the social imaginary wouldn't home in on a new historical meaning.

To put it in colloquial terms, we could say that one goes off in search of a new society, a new history, a new meaning (that is, a new rationality), not solely because the ruling order is suffering materially but most of all because it upsets us. Every utopia that subverts power also thereby implies a subversion of aesthetics. It is aesthetic in nature. This fact establishes a radical departure from the expectations of all those who accept or support the full legitimacy of the ruling order, of its particular rationality, even if they are its material victims and their struggle neither entails nor leads to any goal other than that of switching places and roles within the same order. In this sense, it isn't enough to fight the exploiters. Utopia cannot necessarily be located within this framework. For utopia to be present requires a constant struggle against exploitation, against every form of exploitation. The presence of utopia requires a struggle against domination, against every form of domination.

Along this same path, two questions come out to meet us. First, if utopia and aesthetics are made from the same material, shouldn't it also be the case that aesthetics is utopian in nature? Second, what does the material they have in common consist of, and where does it come from?

Both questions lead, or seem to lead, to the same answer. Utopia, any utopia, is born as a search for liberating a society from the present order and its specific perspective on rationality. Utopia projects an alternative for liberation in both dimensions and thus entails a subversion of the world in its materiality as well as in its subjectivity. Any aesthetic rebellion, for its part, likewise entails a subversion of the imaginary of the world, a liberation of that imaginary from the matrices that structure it and at the same time imprison it. Any new aesthetic is consequently utopian in character.

However, while every utopia is aesthetic in character, not all aesthetics are utopian in character. That trait is found only in a subversive aesthetic. Thus, though every utopia is indeed made of aesthetic material and appears

first in the realm of aesthetics, not all aesthetics appear first in the realm of utopia. The relationship between the two is fundamental, no doubt, but this isn't a reciprocal symmetry. Utopia, any utopia, projects the dreams and hopes of the dominated but also of those who are not themselves dominated but figure among the "humiliated and outraged" of this world, in other words, those who find exploitation and domination, whatever form they take, offensive and humiliating for all men and women on Earth. That is why utopia couldn't exist without an aesthetic component. The realm of aesthetics, on the other hand, is a field disputed between a dominant matrix and an alternative of subversion and liberation. Aesthetics forms part of the structure of intersubjective relationships of power. But no subjective aesthetic alternative could help but have a utopian component. Power is, after all, the common enemy. The material that utopia and aesthetics share is rebellion against power, against any sort of power.

In this sense, any aesthetic approach that isn't resigned to commenting on what already exists, that aims to free the creative imagination—that is, the real imaginary, its ways of establishing itself, its forms of expression, and its ways of producing them—subverts the intersubjective universe of power. This is a moment and a part of establishing a new rationality, a new historical meaning for social existence, whether at the individual or the collective level, because it is only within, or in reference to, this process that the liberation of the imaginary really come about. It is precisely in this way that utopia emerges and takes up residence, first, in the realm of aesthetics.

By the same token, a critique of power relations, whether the existing ones or those presented as alternatives, that doesn't restrict itself to denouncing them but instead also tends toward arguing for an alternative rationality will not aim only at the materiality of social relations but also at the intersubjective relations that are interwoven with them. It will depart from and entail an aesthetic. Otherwise, it will expose its technocratic and reductionist character, whatever its name or formal claim on identity might be, its instrumentalism, its essential relationship with power, not with liberation.

It would perhaps not be very hard to accept that in the current historical crisis, this is one of the questions at issue. After all, the idea that "actually existing socialism" was the product of such technocratic reductionism is nothing new, in particular the theory imposed since Stalin of the "superstructure" as a "reflection" of the "base."

What Is New in the World

New utopias and aesthetics don't make their entrance on the world's stage every day, nor are they produced solely through the vision of intellectuals and artists. They emerge in the twilight of a historical period when, as is historically verifiable, the arriving world is again open to options for meaning, for alternative rationalities.

I suggest that this is what's happening today, though the dominant opinion is almost radically hostile. Indeed, we are faced with a peculiar paradox. Most people would agree that a period in history has come to an end. But the overwhelming majority would also agree that any utopia, any possibility for a utopia, has thereby been swept away from history. If that is indeed the case, the end of this period is neither more nor less than the end of history. The historical world will never open up any new options; it cannot become in any way new in the future.

With the fall of the Berlin Wall, the twentieth century can be said to have come to an end historically, even if its chronology still had another decade to run. Everything that was built as a real project of antibourgeois utopias in this period, culturally and politically, lies in ruins.

A historical period is more than a mere chronology. It is, first and foremost, a particular structure of meanings, that is, of rationality, a setting for conflicts among notions of rationality and for the hegemony of some of them. It is the exhaustion of the latter that brings the period to a close. Then, another conflict outlines the horizon of the period that is being established between the discourse of the triumphant order and the new utopia. This century has been the setting for the conflict between two forms of the same rationality, both heirs to the same instrumental version of European modernity: private capitalism and (the capitalism of?) "actually existing socialism." The curtain is going down with the triumph of the former.

Since "actually existing socialism" hid behind its name to take the place of socialist democracy in the imaginary of those facing social alienation, the winners pretend to see in their rivals' collapse nothing less than the death of the hope whose name had been usurped in the recently concluded contest.

Their powerful mass media seek to overwhelm us with the final victory of capital, its power, its technology, its discourse. They have, they tell us, forever dashed the dreams of liberation, of solidarity, of direct control over authority. Those were just tall tales, contemptible fantasies. An unmitigated

pragmatism spreads like a steamrolling ideology, proclaiming the end of every (other) ideology in order to sing the funeral dirge for all hope of subverting this order. In fact, some fools even believe that it isn't just this period but all of History that is coming to an end, as in Fukuyama's *The End of History*,[3] and that the eternal kingdom of capital and the liberal order is beginning. All utopia seems indeed to have died, buried under the rubble of all the walls of "actually existing socialism" or locked inside the Weberian iron cage of instrumental reason.

E pur si muove. The world is already new again, in many senses. And above all, it already contains visible, active options for historical meaning. In other words, the time to come will not just be a prolongation of the past, as capitalist millenarianism now dreams, but rather a historically new time.

Let me point out some of the defining traits of what's new here. To begin with, we are living for the first time in a global world, literally: one that covers the entire globe. The consequences and implications of this on all sorts of phenomena and on all the categories concerning them (nations, states, ethnic groups, races, castes, genders, and so on) that form the vast family of power can barely be glimpsed today, and this is not the place to discuss them. But few, I am sure, would dare expect that the ruling power, that of capital, will manage to make its way unscathed through the time to come.

In the current debate on the crisis of modernity, it isn't just the rationality of the opposing notions of power that's at issue, as most critics of modernity maintain, nor is it certain that the latter can be definitively pushed aside in benefit of the eternal dominance of the elements of modern rationality that can be instrumentalized for the ends of power. More profoundly, the very foundations of the cognitive paradigm that allows for such instrumentalization are at stake. The dichotomous separation of subject and object, the sequential linearity between cause and effect, the exteriority and lack of communication between objects, and the ontological identity of objects—in other words, all that's contained in the image of the separation between the tree of life and the tree of knowledge, where the process of the disenchantment of the world begins—point to some of the central dimensions of the problem. The structures of the intersubjective universe that uphold the Eurocentrist domination in the intellect and in the material relations of power are at issue. This fact certainly raises the risk of a return of every sort of culturalist fundamentalism, even the imposition of the most malicious forms of Eurocentrism. But the doors to (re?) establishing a relationship of communication between society and the universe have also been opened.

We are still in the early days of the "technological revolution." So far it has made possible the globalization of the world and the spread of the dominion of capital over all peoples and the dominion of its beneficiaries, mainly Euro–North Americans, over all other groups in the world. But the technological revolution has also made it possible to question its epistemology, its worldview, its rationality. And we are barely at the threshold of the implications of this for the technological creations of the future, for the potential of technological reappropriation through other rationalities, for reoriginalizing other cultures, and, in the immediate future, for the possibilities of new aesthetic creations that all this opens up by producing new sounds, colors, new images and forms, and new realities.

The globalization of the world perhaps exacerbates the dominators' old fantasy: homogenizing the world. The world has certainly become more interconnected, and this points to a common pool of meanings. But it is, at the same time, more diverse, more heterogeneous. The "West" penetrates, disarticulates, other worlds. But in exchange it produces vast multitudes of migrating people. Migration has almost become a contemporary human condition. And the migrations aren't just of workers but are also cultural universes that penetrate and remake the "centers" of global power. What in Africa is still eroding and disarticulating a mode of social existence (Chinua Achebe, *Things Fall Apart*) turns into a genuine metamorphosis among migrants, producing in England a not-so-underground remaking of everyday life (Salman Rushdie, *The Satanic Verses*). And in Latin America, as in the Black United States, probably because these are the two oldest territories for colonial domination and migration, it sparks a process of cultural reoriginalization, that is, of producing original meanings, not merely subaltern versions of Euro–North American culture (José María Arguedas, *El zorro de arriba y el zorro de abajo*; Toni Morrison, *Song of Solomon*). The "Arguedian knot," that peculiar interweaving of utopia with social liberation and the liberation of identity, turns out to be not exclusive to the Andean world or to Latin America but rather to the whole historical world established by colonial domination. But perhaps it will also end up squeezing the dominators themselves in their own home countries.

Observing the trends through which the next worldwide accumulation arises, not only can we see the productive sectors, the technology, and the possible spatial distribution of control over this structure. The question can also be raised about the limits of commercialization of the labor force, beyond the problem of employment-unemployment-underemployment within capital. And one of the possible options for labor and for workers in

view of these limits is the spread of reciprocal relationships in control over resources, production, and distribution, as is already happening and not just in Latin America. The conflicts within power and against it going forward cannot remain solely within wage-capital relations.

Utopia Time

Given these issues, it isn't too much to suggest that we are also involved in a process of reconstituting the imaginary from new facts that vie to appear, to escape their former prisons, to take shape and become images and systems of images. But all this can only be fully constituted to the degree that social existence as a whole may process, in the same movement, the need, as sentiment and as interest, to search and to struggle for alternative rationalities instead of those of the currently ruling power, its order, and its world. This potential aesthetic can only be established as an aesthetic of utopia.

And that's what it's all about. Though we can't see it through the dust cloud raised by falling walls or hear it through the blaring fanfare of capitalism, a new moment is now upon us in the never-ending struggle and the ever death-defying hope that authority can be replaced by freedom, and the ethics of interest can be replaced by the ethics of solidarity.

This hope is very ancient yet new. At the threshold of the new period, it was remade in the vast revolutionary wave that swept the planet of capital in the 1960s, the epicenter of which was Paris, May 1968. The idea of direct democracy—direct control over authority, solidarity, and individual freedom—could be rediscovered and restored based on that. That was the precise sign that the whole historical period just finished had been exhausted and that a new utopia of struggle against alienation had arrived.

The utopia of the time to come is now among us. The more polished and precise, the more completely the edifice of "actually existing socialism" has collapsed. The more urgent, the more completely private capitalism has won and the more global its dominion has become.

Latin America: Celebrating the Origin

Latin America enters this horizon as the region best suited for the history of the time to come. Perhaps it is no mere coincidence, after all, that the debate over aesthetics and society has now become not just more intense here but, above all, deeper and richer (Juan Acha, Mirko Lauer, and Néstor

García Canclini, among others) than anywhere else. Because the utopia of social liberation and the utopia of identity can only be resolved together in Latin America, not one without the other, an aesthetic of utopia will be required here more than anywhere else in this world.

What the culture of the dominators dishonors, precludes, or hides, especially in cultures of colonial origin, stuck in the labyrinth of an uncertain identity, is almost always what the dominated speak, dream, or love: the ways they relate to forms, to color, to sound, to their bodies, and to the world; everything they do or avoid doing to satisfy themselves or fulfill themselves without appealing to the dominators or asking for permission; the ways they free themselves from the matrices of forgetting or memory, which are imposed on them like a lock on the cage of domination; and, above all, the glory of the celebration against instrumental reason.

Domination imposes imitation on its victims, then shame. Domination pushes them to simulate, then condemns them, and produces hybridity and disgrace. Criollo oligarchy culture was the long-term form that this imposition took in the period preceding capitalist globalism. But the hegemony of that culture lies in ruin. Its final images and its aesthetic of imitation, limitation, simulation, and hybridity are dissipating, while the presence of the dominated grows stronger and more vivid in the remaking of the intersubjective universe in Latin America. The Indian and Black worlds are leading to the re-creation of all the rhythms, all the threads of relationship to the universe, to their own reception of what is coming from globalization and all that's new in the world. There is an effective process of reorginalizing culture in Latin America, because each of the elements that are remaking it is new: Indianness, Blackness, and all the rest in the framework of today's new world. The dominators, however, are new as well. And the birth of this new history, which may bring about the liberation of the imaginary of the dominated and the subversion of the world, is not only unknown to them but in fact makes them actively hostile. Now, they are bent on replacing criollo-oligarchic culture with its colonial-transcolonial equivalent. To modernize is to Europeanize, the non-European is exotic, and we can't go on being exotic, as one of their most famous actors has now proclaimed (Vargas Llosa, *Le Nouvel Observateur*, 1966). But even scraping themselves raw against the jagged edges of Europeanization would only get them as far as a new simulation. Haven't they spent their entire history pretending to be what they never were? And isn't that exactly what engineered the dark labyrinth that forms our identity issue?

In Latin America, the struggle against class domination, against color discrimination, against cultural domination also runs through the road of returning honor to everything that culture dishonors; of granting freedom to that which forces us to hide in the labyrinths of subjectivity; of ceasing to be what we've never been, what we'll never be, what we don't have to be. In order to begin, in short, the process requires reorginalizing culture and employing with it the materials that will return to this celebration its privileged space in existence.

Lima, Summer 1990

Notes

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1 See, for example, Lunn, *Marxism and Modernism*.

2 Quijano, *Modernidad, identidad y utopía en América Latina*.

3 Fukuyama's book is actually a crude and simplistic version of Alexandre Kojève's thesis. See Auffret, *Alexandre Kojève*.

3

COLONIALITY AND MODERNITY/RATIONALITY

The conquest of the societies and the cultures that inhabit what today is called Latin America began the constitution of a new world order, culminating five hundred years later in a global power covering the whole planet. This process implied a violent concentration of the world's resources under the control and for the benefit of a small European minority and above all of its ruling classes. Although occasionally moderated when faced with the revolt of the dominated, this process has continued ever since. But now during the current crisis, such concentration is being realized with a new impetus in a way perhaps even more violent and on a much larger global scale. The "Western" European dominators and their Euro–North American descendants are still the principal beneficiaries, together with the non-European part of the world that is not quite former European colonies, Japan mainly, and mainly their ruling classes. The exploited and the dominated of Latin America and Africa are the main victims.

A relation of direct, political, social, and cultural domination was established by the Europeans over the conquered of all continents. This domination is known as a specific Eurocentered colonialism. In its political, above all formal and explicit, aspect, this colonial domination has been defeated in the large majority of the cases. America was the first stage of that defeat and afterward, since World War II, Asia and Africa. Thus, the Eurocentered colonialism, in the sense of a formal system of political domination by Western European societies over others, seems a question of the past.

Its successor, Western imperialism, is an association of social interests between the dominant groups (social classes and *ethnies*) of countries with unequally articulated power rather than an imposition from the outside.

However, that specific colonial structure of power produced the specific social discriminations that later were codified as "racial," "ethnic," "anthropological," or "national" according to the times, agents, and populations involved. These intersubjective constructions, products of Eurocentered colonial domination, were even assumed to be "objective," "scientific," categories, thus of a historical significance, that is, as natural phenomena not referring to the history of power. This power structure was and still is the framework within which operate the other social relations of classes or estates.

In fact, if we observe the main lines of exploitation and social domination on a global scale, the main lines of world power today, and the distribution of resources and work among the world population, it is very clear that the large majority of the exploited, the dominated, and the discriminated against are precisely the members of the "races," "ethnies," or "nations" into which the colonized populations were categorized in the formative process of that world power, from the conquest of America and onward.

In the same way, in spite of the fact that political colonialism has been eliminated, the relationship between the European—also called "Western"—culture and the others continues to be one of colonial domination. It is not only a matter of the subordination of the other cultures to the European in an external relation; we have also to do with a colonization of the other cultures, albeit in differing intensities and depths. This relationship consists, in the first place, of a colonization of the imagination of the dominated; that is, the relationship acts in the interior of that imagination and, in a sense, is a part of it.

In the beginning colonialism was a product of a systematic repression, not only of the specific beliefs, ideas, images, symbols, or knowledge that were not useful to global colonial domination, while at the same time the colonizers were expropriating from the colonized their knowledge, especially in mining, agriculture, and engineering, as well as their products and work. The repression fell, above all, over the modes of knowing, of producing knowledge, of producing perspectives, images and systems of images, symbols, and modes of signification over the resources, patterns, and instruments of formalized and objectivized expression, intellectual or visual. This was followed by the imposition of the use of the rulers' own patterns of expression

and of their beliefs and images with reference to the supernatural. These beliefs and images served not only to impede the cultural production of the dominated but also as a very efficient means of social and cultural control when the immediate repression ceased to be constant and systematic.

The colonizers also imposed a mystified image of their own patterns of producing knowledge and meaning. At first, they placed these patterns far out of reach of the dominated. Later, they taught them in a partial and selective way in order to co-opt some of the dominated into their own power institutions. Then, European culture was made seductive: it gave access to power. After all, beyond repression, the main instrument of all power is its seduction. Cultural Europeanization was transformed into an aspiration. It was a way of participating and later to reach the same material benefits and the same power as the Europeans: namely, to conquer nature, in short for "development." European culture became a universal cultural model. The imaginary in the non-European cultures could hardly exist today and, above all, reproduce itself outside of these relations.

The forms and the effects of that cultural coloniality have been different as regards times and cases. In Latin America, the cultural repression and the colonization of the imaginary were accompanied by a massive and gigantic extermination of the Natives, mainly by their use as an expendable labor force, in addition to the violence of the conquest and the diseases brought by Europeans. Between the Aztec-Maya-Caribbean and the Tawantinsuyan (or Inca) areas, about sixty-five million inhabitants were exterminated in a period of less than fifty years. The scale of this extermination was so huge that it involved not only a demographic catastrophe but also the destruction of societies and cultures. The cultural repression and the massive genocide together turned the previous high cultures of America into illiterate peasant subcultures condemned to orality, that is, deprived of their own patterns of formalized, objectivized, intellectual, and artistic or visual expression. Henceforth, the survivors would have no other modes of intellectual and artistic or visual formalized and objectivized expressions except through the cultural patterns of the rulers, even if subverting them in certain cases to transmit other needs of expression. Latin America is, without doubt, the most extreme case of cultural colonization by Europe.

In Asia and in the Middle East, the high cultures could never be destroyed with such intensity and profundity. But they were nevertheless placed in a subordinate relation not only in the European view but also in the eyes of their own bearers. Through the political, military, and technological power of its foremost societies, European or Western culture imposed its

paradigmatic image and its principal cognitive elements as the norm of orientation on all cultural development, particularly the intellectual and the artistic. That relationship consequently became a constitutive part of the conditions of reproduction of those societies and cultures that were pushed into Europeanization of everything or in part.

In Africa, cultural destruction was certainly much more intensive than in Asia but less than in America. Nor did the Europeans there succeed in the complete destruction of the patterns of expression, in particular of objectification and visual formalization. What the Europeans did was to deprive Africans of legitimacy and recognition in the global cultural order dominated by European patterns. The former was confined to the category of the "exotic," that is, doubtless what is manifested, for example, in the utilization of the products of African artistic expression as motive, starting point, and source of inspiration for the art of Western or Europeanized African artists but not as a mode of artistic expression of its own, of a rank equivalent to the European norm. And that exactly identifies a colonial view.

Coloniality, then, is still the most general form of domination in the world today, once colonialism as an explicit political order was destroyed. Coloniality doesn't exhaust, obviously, the conditions or the modes of exploitation and domination between peoples. But coloniality hasn't ceased to be, for five hundred years, their main framework. The colonial relations of previous periods probably did not produce the same consequences, and above all, they were not the cornerstone of any global power.

"Race" and Coloniality of Power

Coloniality of power was conceived together with America and Western Europe and with the social category of "race" as the key element of the social classification of colonized and colonizers. Unlike in any other previous experience of colonialism, the old ideas of superiority of the dominant and the inferiority of the dominated under European colonialism were mutated in a relationship of biologically and structurally superior and inferior.[1]

The process of Eurocentrification of the new world power in the following centuries gave way to the imposition of such a "racial" criteria to the new social classification of the world population on a global scale. So, in the first place, new social identities were produced all over the world: "whites," "Indians," "Negroes," "yellows," and "olives," using physiognomic traits of the peoples as external manifestations of their "racial" nature. Then, on that basis the new geocultural identities were produced: European, American, Asiatic,

African, and, much later, Oceania. During European colonial world domination, the distribution of work of the entire world capitalist system between salaried, independent peasants, independent merchants, and slaves and serfs was organized basically following the same "racial" lines of global social classification, with all the implications for the processes of nationalization of societies and states, and for the formation of nation-states, citizenship, democracy, and so on around the world. Such distribution of work in the world capitalist system began to change slowly with the struggles against European colonialism, especially after World War I, and with the changing requirements of capitalism itself. But distribution of labor is by no means finished, since Eurocentered coloniality of power has proved to be longer lasting than Eurocentered colonialism. Without distribution of labor, the history of capitalism in Latin America and other related places in the world can hardly be explained.[2]

So, coloniality of power is based upon "racial" social classification of the world population under Eurocentered world power. But coloniality of power is not exhausted in the problem of "racist" social relations. The coloniality of power pervaded and modulated the basic instances of the Eurocentered capitalist colonial/modern world power to become the cornerstone of this coloniality of power.

Eurocentrism, Cultural Coloniality, and Modernity/Rationality

During the same period as European colonial domination was consolidating itself, the cultural complex known as European modernity/rationality was being constituted. The intersubjective universe produced by the entire Eurocentered capitalist colonial power was elaborated and formalized by the Europeans and established in the world as an exclusively European product and as a universal paradigm of knowledge and of the relation between humanity and the rest of the world. Such confluence between coloniality and the elaboration of rationality/modernity was not in any way accidental, as is shown by the very manner in which the European paradigm of rational knowledge was elaborated. In fact, the coloniality of power had decisive implications in the constitution of the paradigm, associated with the emergence of urban and capitalist social relations, which in their turn could not be fully explained outside colonialism and coloniality, particularly not as far as Latin America is concerned. The decisive weight of coloniality in the constitution of the European paradigm of modernity/rationality is clearly

revealed in the actual crisis of that cultural complex. Examining some of the basic questions of that crisis will help to illuminate the problem.

The Question of the Production of Knowledge

For a start, in the current crisis of the European paradigm of rational knowledge, the latter's fundamental presupposition is questioned: namely knowledge as a product of a subject-object relation. Apart from the problems of validation of knowledge implied, that presupposition raises other problems worthy of a brief presentation here.

First, in that presupposition, the "subject" is a category referring to the isolated individual because it constitutes itself in itself and for itself, in its discourse and in its capacity of reflection. The Cartesian "cogito, ergo sum" means exactly that. Second, the "object" is a category referring to an entity not only different from the "subject" individual but also external to the latter by its nature. Third, the "object" is also identical to itself because it is constituted by "properties" that give it its identity and define it; that is, the properties demarcate the "object" and at the same time position it in relation to the other "objects."

What is in question in this paradigm is, first, the individual and individualist character of the "subject," which like every half-truth falsifies the problem by denying intersubjectivity and social totality as the production sites of all knowledge. Second, the idea of "object" is incompatible with the results of current scientific research, according to which the "properties" are modes and times of a given field of relations. Therefore, there is not much room for an idea of identity as ontologically irreducible originality outside the field of relations. Third, the externality of the relations between the "subject" and the "object," founded on differences of nature, is not only an arbitrary exaggeration of the differences, since current research rather leads to the discovery that there exists a deeper communication structure in the universe. Much more important and decisive is that in such a cognitive perspective, there is implied a new radical dualism: divine reason and nature. The "subject" is bearer of "reason," while the "object," is not only external to it but also different in nature. In fact, it is "nature."

One can, of course, recognize in the idea of "subject" as an isolated individual an element and an instance of the process of liberation of the individual with respect to the ascriptive social structures that imprisoned it in Europe. The latter condemned the individual to one single place and social role during its entire life, as happens in all societies with rigidly fixed

hierarchies sustained by violence and by ideologies and corresponding imagery. This was the case of the premodern European cultures/societies. That liberation was a social and cultural struggle associated with the emergence of social relations of capital and of urban life. But, on the other hand, that proposal is today inadmissible in the current field of knowledge. The differentiated individual subjectivity is "real," but it is not an entity, so it doesn't exist only vis-à-vis itself or by itself. It exists as a differentiated part of, but not separated from, an intersubjectivity or intersubjective dimension of social relationship. Every individual discourse, or reflection, remits to a structure of intersubjectivity. The former is constituted in and vis-à-vis the latter. Knowledge in this perspective is an intersubjective relation for the purpose of something, not a relation between an isolated subjectivity and that something.

Probably it is not accidental that knowledge was considered then in the same way as property, as a relation between one individual and something else. The same mental mechanism underlies both ideas at the point when modern society was emerging. Nevertheless, property, like knowledge, is a relation between people for the purpose of something, not a relation between an individual and something. These phenomena differ in that the property relation exists in a material as well as an intersubjective manner; knowledge, on the other hand, exists only as an intersubjective relationship.

It seems, then, that one can demonstrate the association between individualism/dualism and the European social and cultural conflicts at the time when the main European paradigm of rationality was elaborated. But in that individualism/dualism there is another component, the explanation of which is not exhausted in the internal context of Europe: the "Other" is totally absent or is present, can be present, only in an "objectivized" mode.

The radical absence of the "Other" not only postulates an atomistic image of social existence in general; that is, it denies the idea of the social totality. As European colonial practice was to show, the paradigm also made it possible to omit every reference to any other "subject" outside the European context, that is, to make invisible the colonial order as totality, at the same moment as the very idea of Europe was establishing itself precisely in relation to the rest of the world being colonized. The emergence of the idea of the "West" or of "Europe" is an admission of identity, that is, of relations with other cultural experiences, of differences with other cultures. But, to that "European" or "Western" perception in full formation, those differences were admitted primarily above all as inequalities in the hierarchical sense. And such inequalities are perceived as being of nature: only European culture is

rational, as it can contain "subjects"; the rest are not rational, as they cannot be or harbor "subjects." As a consequence, the other cultures are different in the sense that they are unequal, in fact inferior, by nature. They only can be "objects" of knowledge, domination practices, or both. From that perspective, the relation between European culture and the other cultures was established and has been maintained as a relation between "subject" and "object." It blocked, therefore, every relation of communication, of interchange of knowledge and of modes of producing knowledge between the cultures, since the paradigm implies that between "subject" and "object" there can be but a relation of externality. Such a mental perspective, enduring as practice for five hundred years, could only have been the product of a relation of coloniality between Europe and the rest of the world. In other terms, the European paradigm of rational knowledge was elaborated not only in the context of but also as part of a power structure that involved the European colonial domination over the rest of the world. This paradigm expressed, in a demonstrable sense, the coloniality of that power structure.

As has been widely discussed especially since World War II, the formation and the development of certain disciplines, such as ethnology and anthropology, have always shown that kind of "subject-object" relations between the "Western" culture and the rest. By definition, the other cultures are the "object" of study. Such studies about the Western cultures and societies are virtually nonexistent except as ironical parodies ("The ritual among the Nacirema"—an anagram of "American"—is a typical example).

The Question of Totality in Knowledge

In spite of its absence in the Cartesian paradigm, the intellectual necessity of the idea of totality, especially in relation to social reality, was present in the European debate, early on in the Iberian countries (Victoria, Suárez) and in the preservation of power defended by the Catholic Church and the Crown, and in France somewhat later (eighteenth century) and then already as a key element of social criticism and of alternative social proposals. Above all, from Saint-Simon, the idea of social totality was spread together with proposals of revolutionary social change, in confrontation with the atomistic perspective of social existence then predominant among the empiricists and among the adherents of the existing social and political order. In the twentieth century, totality became a perspective and a category generally admitted in scientific investigations, especially those about society.

European-Western rationality/modernity is constituted not only in a disputatious dialogue with the church and with religion but also in the very process of restructuration of power, on the one hand, in capitalist and urban social relations and nation-states and, on the other, in the colonization of the rest of the world. This was probably not divorced from the circumstance that the idea of social totality was developed according to an organicist image, which led to adopting a reductionist vision of reality.

In fact, that perspective was certainly useful to introduce and to fix the idea of social totality, that is, society. But it was also instrumental in making the same with two other ideas, the first of which is society as a structure of functional relations among each and every one of the parts and therefore linked to the action of one sole logic and thus a closed totality. This led later to a systemic idea of totality in structural-functionalism. The other idea was society as an organic structure, where the parts are related according to the same rules of hierarchy between the organs as the image we have of every organism and in particular the human one. Where there exists a part ruling the rest (the brain)—though it cannot expunge them in order to exist—the rest (in particular the extremities) cannot exist without being subordinately related to the ruling part of the organism.

It is an image diffused with the enterprise and the relations between entrepreneurs and workers, prolonging the legend of Menenius Agrippa's ingenious discourse in the beginning of the Roman Republic, which was to dissuade the first strikers in history: the owners are the brain, and the workers are the arms that form society together with the rest of the body. Without the brain, the arms would be meaningless, and without the latter, the brain could not exist. Both are necessary in order to keep the rest of the body alive and healthy, without which neither the brain nor the arms could exist. Kautsky's proposal, adopted by Lenin, is a variant of this image, where the proletarians are unable by themselves to elaborate their class-consciousness, and the bourgeois intelligentsia, the petite bourgeoisie, or both are the ones who have to teach it to them. Not by accident, Lenin explicitly argued already in his polemic with the Russian Populists ("Who are the Friends of the People") that society is an organic totality. In Latin America, the image has been used repeatedly, recently, for instance, by Jaime Paz Zamora,[3] in a journalist interview, referring to the relation between the political parties and the trade unions, between the intellectuals and the workers in Bolivia: the parties are the head, the unions are the feet. This idea frequently impregnates the practices of most of the political parties and their popular "bases."

This organicist concept of social totality, of society, is not incompatible with the general paradigm of knowledge as a subject-object relation or its systemic variant. They are an alternative option in the atomistic perspective of reality, but they sustain themselves in the same paradigm. However, during the nineteenth century and a great part of the twentieth, social criticism and the proposals of social change could be propped up by the organic view, because the latter made manifest the existence of power as articulator of society. It thus contributed to establishing and debating the question of power in society.

On the other hand, those organicist ideas imply the presupposition of an historically homogenous totality, in spite of the fact that the order articulated by colonialism was not homogenous. Hence, the colonized part was not, at bottom, included in that totality. As is well known, in the Europe of the Enlightenment the categories of "humanity" and "society" did not extend to the non-Western peoples, or only did so in a formal way, in the sense that such recognition had no practical effects. In any case, in accord with the organic image of reality, the ruling part, the brain of the total organism, was Europe and, in every colonized part of the world, the Europeans. The well-known claptrap that the colonized peoples were the "white man's burden" (Kipling) is directly associated with that image.

In this way, finally, the ideas of totality, which elaborated an image of society as a closed structure articulated in a hierarchic order with functional relations between its parts, presupposed a unique historical logic to the historical totality, and a rationality consisting in the subjection of every part to that unique total logic. This leads to conceiving society as a macro-historical subject endowed with a historical rationality, with a lawfulness that permits predictions of the behavior of the whole and of all its part as well as the direction and the finality of its development in time. The ruling part of the totality incarnated, in some way, that historical logic with respect to the colonial world, that is, Europe. Not surprisingly then, history was conceived as an evolutionary continuum from the primitive to the civilized, from the traditional to the modern, from the savage to the rational, from precapitalism to capitalism, etc. And Europe thought of itself as the mirror of the future of all the other societies and cultures, as the advanced form of the history of the entire species. What does not cease to surprise, however, is that Europe succeeded in imposing that "mirage" on the practical totality of the cultures that it colonized and, much more, that this chimera is still so attractive to so many.

The Epistemological Reconstitution: De-Colonization

The idea of totality in general is today questioned and denied in Europe by not only the perennial empiricists but also an entire intellectual community that calls itself postmodernist. In fact, in Europe the idea of totality is a product of colonial/modernity. And it is demonstrable, as we have seen above, that the European ideas of totality led to theoretical reductionism and to the metaphysics of a macrohistorical subject. Moreover, such ideas have been associated with undesirable political practices behind a dream of the total rationalization of society.

It is not necessary, however, to reject the whole idea of totality in order to divest oneself of the ideas and images with which it was elaborated within European colonial/modernity. What is to be done is something very different: to liberate the production of knowledge, reflection, and communication from the pitfalls of European rationality/modernity.

Outside the "West," virtually in all known cultures, every cosmic vision, every image, in other words, all systematic production of knowledge is associated with a perspective of totality. But in those cultures, the perspective of totality in knowledge includes the acknowledgment of the heterogeneity of all reality; of the irreducible, contradictory character of the latter; of the legitimacy, that is, the desirability, of the diverse character of the components of all reality and therefore of the social. The idea of social totality, then, not only does not deny but also depends on the historical diversity and heterogeneity of society, of every society. In other words, social totality not only does not deny but also requires the idea of an "Other" that is diverse, different. That difference does not necessarily imply the unequal nature of the "Other" and therefore the absolute externality of relations, the hierarchical inequality, or the social inferiority of the Other. The differences are not necessarily the basis of domination. At the same time—and because of that—historical-cultural heterogeneity implies the copresence and the articulation of diverse historical "logic" around one of them, which is hegemonic but in no way unique. In this way, the road is closed to all reductionism as well as to the metaphysics of a historical macrosubject capable of its own rationality and of historical teleology, of which individuals and specific groups—classes, for instance—would hardly be carriers or missionaries.

The critique of the European paradigm of rationality/modernity is indispensable; even more, it is urgent. But it is doubtful if the criticism consists

of a simple negation of all its categories, of the dissolution of reality in discourse, of the pure negation of the idea and the perspective of totality in cognition. It is necessary to extricate oneself from the linkages between rationality/modernity and coloniality, first of all, and definitely from all power that is not constituted by free decisions made by free people. It is the instrumentalization of the reasons for power, of colonial power in the first place, that produced distorted paradigms of knowledge and spoiled the liberating promises of modernity. The alternative, then, is clear: the destruction of the coloniality of world power. First of all, epistemological decolonization, as decoloniality, is needed to clear the way for new intercultural communication, for an interchange of experiences and meanings, as the basis of another rationality that may legitimately pretend to some universality. Nothing is less rational, finally, than the pretension that the specific cosmic vision of a particular *ethnie* should be taken as universal rationality even if such an *ethnie* is called Western Europe, because this is actually intended to impose a provincialism as universalism.

The liberation of intercultural relations from the prison of coloniality also implies the freedom of all peoples to choose, individually or collectively, such relations: a freedom to choose between various cultural orientations and, above all, the freedom to produce, criticize, change, and exchange culture and society. This liberation is part of the process of social liberation from all power organized as inequality, discrimination, exploitation, and domination.

Notes

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1 Here is not the place for a more detailed discussion on the origins of the idea of "race." See Quijano, "Raza, etnia y nación en José Carlos Mariátegui."

2 As for Latin America, see Quijano, "America Latina en Ia Economia Mundial."

3 A former Bolivian politician who served as the sixtieth president of Bolivia from 1989 to 1993.

4

QUESTIONING "RACE"

The idea of "race" is surely the most efficient instrument of social domination produced in the last five hundred years. Dating from the very beginning of the formation of the Americas and of capitalism (at the turn of the sixteenth century), in the ensuing centuries it was imposed on the population of the whole planet as an aspect of European colonial domination.[1]

Imposed as the basic criterion for social classification of the entire world's population, "race" was taken as the principal determinant of the world's new social and geocultural identities: on the one hand, "Indian," "Black," "Asiatic" (earlier "yellow" and "olive-skinned"), "white," and "mestizo," and, on the other hand, "America," "Europe," "Africa," "Asia," and "Oceania." On its basis was constituted the Eurocentering of capitalist world power and the consequent global distribution of labor and trade. Also on its basis arose the various specific configurations of power, with their crucial implications for democratization and for the formation of modern nation-states.

In this way, "race," a phenomenon and an outcome of modern colonial domination, came to pervade every sphere of global capitalist power. Coloniality thus became the cornerstone of a Eurocentered world.[2] This coloniality of power has proved to be more profound and more lasting than the colonialism in which it was engendered and that it helped to impose globally.[3]

"Racism" and "Race"

"Racism" in daily social relations is not, to be sure, the only manifestation of the coloniality of power, but it is certainly the most obvious and the most omnipresent. For this reason, it has remained the principal arena of conflict. As an ideology, "race" even prompted attempts in the mid-nineteenth century to build on its basis a whole scientific theory.[4] This in turn provided the rationale almost a century later for the National Socialist (Nazi) project of German world domination.

The defeat of this project in World War II contributed to the delegitimation of racism—at least as a formal and explicit ideology—for a large part of the world's population. But the social practice of racism nonetheless remained globally pervasive, and in some countries, such as South Africa, the ideology and practice of social domination became more intensely and explicitly racist. Still, even in these countries racist ideology has had to concede something—mainly because of struggles on the part of its victims but also because of worldwide condemnation—to the point of allowing "Black" elected leaders to take office. And in countries such as Peru, the practice of racial discrimination must now be disguised—often if not always successfully—behind legal formulas referring to differences in education and income that in this country are themselves one of the clearest consequences of racist social relations.[5]

What is really noteworthy, however, is that for the overwhelming majority of the world's population, including opponents and victims of racism, "race" is not just an idea but also exists as part of "nature," that is, as part of the "natural" materiality of individuals (and not only of the materiality of the social relations of power). In this sense, "race" has remained virtually unquestioned since it first appeared.

In societies founded on the basis of colonial power relations, the victims fight for equality between the "races." Societies lacking such origins (at least in any direct form) may assert that relations between the "races" should be democratic, even if they are not exactly relations among equals. But if we examine the way the issue has been posed, including in such countries as the United States and South Africa where the problem has been most intense, only exceptionally and very recently do we find scholars who have questioned not just racism but also the very idea of "race."[6]

There is thus a profound, tenacious, and virtually universal assumption that "race" is a phenomenon of human biology that has necessary implications for the natural history of the species and hence for the history of

power relations among people. This is surely what accounts for the exceptional efficiency of this modern instrument of social domination. Nonetheless, what we are dealing with here is a blatantly ideological construct that has nothing to do with anything in the biological structure of the human species and everything to do, by contrast, with the history of the power relations of Eurocentered colonial/modern global capitalism. I want to reflect here on the issues raised by this peculiar connection between real social relations and their intersubjective dimension.

Sex/"Gender" and "Color"/"Race"?

The current crisis of the global power structure—perhaps the most profound that it has faced in its five hundred years—deeply affects the way the world's population is classified socially. This classification has reflected, in various ways, all the forms of social domination and all the forms of exploitation of labor. But on a world scale its central axis has been—and, although in decline, continues to be—the link between the commodification of labor power and the stratification of the world's population on the basis of "race" and "gender."[7]

This pattern of social classification has been quite durable. But the rejection of "racial" hierarchy and the resistance to ranking by "gender" have confronted it with a fundamental challenge. Since the early 1970s, the process of commodification of individual labor power appears to be declining in the technologically upper levels of the capitalist structure of accumulation, while it expands only at the lower levels in unstable and precarious ways.[8] Massive world unemployment and underemployment are the obvious consequences. In this new historical context, nonwage forms of exploitation (slavery, serfdom, reciprocity) are being revived,[9] having never completely died out during the last five centuries of capitalist hegemony. So, the relationships between capital and noncapital and between labor and capital are changing. The social reclassification of the world population is a necessary implication of those tendencies. And "race" and "gender" are in the process of redefining their places and roles in global power relations. The growing resistance to discrimination on the basis of "gender" and "race" is one of the dimensions of the crisis.

The capitalist world is, of course, historically and structurally heterogeneous. This means that the crisis in the capitalist pattern of social classification has distinct rhythms and timetables in each part of that world. Resistance by the victims of racism advances in some regions, while

in others it finds not only less space but also, in some cases, open attempts at racism's relegitimation. Such a juxtaposition of resistance to racism with its relegitimation can be seen, for example, in the case of Peru under Fujimorism.[10] But this very juxtaposition at the same time makes the crisis all the more evident. As a result, we finally see called into question not just "racism" but also the very idea of "race." Still, however, even the minority who are moving in this direction find it difficult to shed the old mental chains of the coloniality of power.

Thus, the feminist movement and the debate on the question of "gender" have led increasing numbers of people to admit that "gender" is a mental construct grounded in sexual differences, which expresses patriarchal relations of domination and serves to legitimate them. And some now suggest, analogously, that we should also think of "race" as a mental construct, based in this case on skin color. Thus, "color" would be to "race" as sex is to "gender."

But the two links are not at all equivalent. In the first place, sex and sexual differences are real; they are a subsystem within the overall system known as the human organism, comparable to blood circulation, respiration, digestion, etc. That is, they are part of the biological dimension of the whole person.[11] Moreover, because of this they entail differences in biological behavior between people of different sexes. In addition, this differentiated biological behavior is linked above all to a vital matter: the reproduction of the species. One of the sexes fertilizes, and the other ovulates and can conceive, gestate, give birth, and nurse the newborn.

In sum, sexual difference entails distinct biological roles and behaviors. And although this in no way exhausts—let alone legitimates—the category of "gender," it at least shows that the intersubjective construct of "gender" has a biological point of departure.

No such thing can be said of the link between "color" and "race." First of all, the whole question of using the word "color" to refer to personal traits has to be thrown wide open. The very idea of "color" in this context is a mental construct. If one speaks of political colors ("red," "white," "green"), everyone is presumably disposed to recognize this as a metaphor. But strangely enough, this is not the case when one says that someone is of the "white," "Black," "red," or "yellow" "*race*"! And, more strangely still, few stop to consider that to describe a person's actual skin color by one of these labels requires a total distortion of vision or else a kind of stupidity or, at best, a prejudice.

The history of the "color" construct in social relations has yet to be written. Nonetheless, there are ample historical grounds for affirming that the association of "race" with "color" is belated and tortuous.[12] Color antedates the idea of race; it did not originally have any "racial" connotation. The first "race" was the "Indians," and there is nothing in the historical record to suggest that the category of "Indian" was associated with skin color.

The idea of "race" was born with "America" and originally referred to the differences between "Indians" and their conquerors (principally Castilian).[13] The first conquered peoples to whom future Europeans applied the idea of "color" are not, however, the "Indians." They are the slaves who were kidnapped and sold from the coasts of what is now known as Africa and whom they called "Blacks" ("Negroes"). But, surprising as this may now seem, Africans were not the first peoples to whom the idea of "race" was applied even though the future Europeans were acquainted with them long before they arrived on the coasts of the future America.

During the conquest, the Iberians—Portuguese and Castilian—used the term "Black," a color, as shown in the documents of that period. But the Iberians of that time did not yet identify themselves as "white." This "color" was not constructed until the eighteenth century, when the Anglo-Americans institutionalized the slave status of Africans in North America and the Antilles. Here, obviously, "white" is the constructed identity of the dominators, counterposed to "Black" ("Negro" or "nigger"), the identity of the dominated, as "racial" classification is already clearly consolidated and "naturalized" for all the colonizers and even perhaps among some of the colonized.

Underlying this historical reality is the fact that if "color" were to "race" as sex is to "gender," then "color" would necessarily have something to do with the biology or the biologically differentiated behavior of some part of the organism. However, there is no sign or evidence that any of the subsystems or apparatuses of the human organism (genital or sexual, circulatory, respiratory, glandular, etc.) varies in its nature, configuration, structure, function, or role in accordance with such traits as skin color, shape of eyes, or texture of hair.[14]

To be sure, external bodily traits such as shape, size, skin color, etc. are inscribed in each person's genetic code. In this specific sense we can speak of biological phenomena. But none of this has anything to do with the biological configuration of the organism or with the functions and behaviors or roles of the whole or of any of its parts.

Finally, and in the context of everything we have said, if "color" were to "race" as sex is to "gender," then on what basis could certain "colors" be seen as "superior" to others? In the patriarchal relation between man and woman, "superiority" is attributed to one of the "genders" and not to a particular sex as such or, if so, only by extension from the construction of "gender." Sex is not a construct in the way that gender is.

It is time to recognize that "color" is to "race" only as one construct is to another. In fact, "color" is a belated and euphemistic way of saying "race," a usage that did not become worldwide until the end of the nineteenth century.

The New "Western" Dualism and "Racism"

At the very beginnings of American history, there took root the idea that there are biological differences within the world's population that are decisively linked to the capacity for mental and cultural development. This was the central issue in the famous Valladolid debate over whether or not "Indians" were human. The extreme position, that of Ginés de Sepúlveda, who claimed that they could not be fully human, was rejected in the papal bull of 1513. But the idea of basic biological differences among humans was never questioned. And the prolonged colonial practice of domination/exploitation based on that assumption legitimated the idea permanently. Ever since that time, the old notions of superiority/inferiority implicit in every relationship of domination were considered to be grounded in nature; they were "naturalized" for all subsequent history.

This was certainly the initial moment of what has constituted since the seventeenth century the foundational myth of modernity, namely the idea of an original state of nature and of a process of historical development going from the "primitive" (the closest to "nature," which of course included above all the "Blacks" but also the "Indians") to the most "civilized" (which of course was Europe), with the "Orient" (India, China) in between.[15]

The link between this view of history and the idea of "race" was no doubt obvious at that time from the European perspective. It was implicit in the ideology and practice of colonial domination of the Americas and was reinforced and consolidated through the global expansion of European colonialism. But it was not until the mid-nineteenth century, with Arthur de Gobineau, that this link began to be articulated theoretically.

This time lapse was not accidental, nor was it without consequences in terms of the coloniality of power. On the basis of "America," the Atlantic basin

became the new central axis of world trade during the sixteenth century. The peoples and the dominant groups who controlled this axis soon came to comprise a new historical region, and thus "Europe" was constituted as a new geocultural identity and as the hegemonic center of nascent global capitalism. This position made it possible for the Europeans, especially those of Western Europe, to impose the idea of "race" as the basis of the worldwide division of labor and of trade and also in the social and geocultural classification of the world population.

It was in this framework that the pattern of global capitalist power and its corresponding intersubjective experience took shape over the next three centuries. Europe's position as the hegemonic center of the modern capitalist world-system[16] gave it at the same time full hegemony in the intellectual elaboration of that whole vast historical experience—from the mid-seventeenth century on—and gave it the opportunity to mythologize its own supposedly self-made achievement.

Modernity, as a pattern of social, material, and subjective experience, expressed the essential character of this new global power. But its rationality reflected its European roots. That is, it expressed the Eurocentric view of the totality of the colonial/modern capitalist world.

A core aspect of this Eurocentric perspective was the adoption of a new dualism—a new version of the old dualism—as one of the bases of its worldview: the radical separation (not just differentiation) of subject/reason/soul/spirit/mind from object/body, reflecting the final triumph of Cartesianism over alternative approaches (principally that of Baruch Spinoza).[17]

Virtually all known "civilizations" differentiate between "spirit" (soul, mind) and "body." The dualist view of the dimensions of the human organism is thus ancient. But in all earlier cases the two dimensions are always copresent, coacting, never separated. René Descartes is the first to perceive "body" strictly as an "object," radically separated from the activity of "reason," which is the condition of the "subject." According to Descartes, "reason" is divine; "body," although created by God, is not divine but is part of "nature." Within this framework, both categories are mystified. We confront a new and radical dualism. It is a secularization of the long evolving of medieval Christian theology that separated "soul" and "body," precisely in the same terms. And this is what dominates all Eurocentric thought up to our own day.[18]

Without taking into account this new dualism, it is not possible to understand the Eurocentric elaboration of the ideas of "gender" and "race."

Both forms of domination are older than Cartesianism, but the latter is the point of departure for their systematic elaboration. In the cognitive perspective grounded in Cartesian radical dualism, "body" is "nature," ergo "sex." The role of woman, of the "feminine gender," is thus more closely linked to "sex," to "the body." This makes woman an "inferior gender." "Race," for its part, is also a "natural" phenomenon, and some "races" are closer to "nature" than others and are therefore "inferior" to those that have managed to distance themselves as much as possible from the state of nature.

Against this backdrop, we can insist that without rejecting the shackles of the Eurocentric worldview—that is, of the dualism between "body" and non-"body"—we will not get very far in the struggle to free ourselves decisively from the idea of "race" and of "racism" or from that other form of the coloniality of power, the relations of domination between "genders." The decolonization of power, in whatever frame of reference, signifies from the outset the decolonization of all dimensions of consciousness. "Race" and "racism" are situated, more than any other element of modern capitalist power relations, at this decisive juncture.

Translated by Victor Wallis

Notes

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1 On the invention of the idea of "race" and its background, see Quijano, "Raza, etnia y nación en José Carlos Mariátegui." See also Quijano and Wallerstein, "Americanity as a Concept, or the Americas in the Imaginary of the Modern World-System."

2 On the coloniality of power and on the Eurocentered and colonial/modern pattern of world capitalism, see my articles "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism and Latin America"; "Coloniality and Modernity/Rationality"; and "Colonialidad del poder y clasificación social."

3 The concept of coloniality of power was introduced in my work "Colonialidad y modernidad/racionalidad," originally published in *Perú Indígena* 13, no. 29 (1992), and later in other Latin American journals (English version in Therborn, *Globalizations and Modernities*). See also

Quijano and Wallerstein, "Americanity as a Concept, or the Americas in the Imaginary of the Modern World-System." On the current debate, see, among many others, Mignolo, "Diferencia colonial y razón postoccidental."

4 Gobineau, *Essais sur l'inegalité des races humaines*.

5 On the widespread incidence of racist attitudes in Peru, see the results of a survey of university students of metropolitan Lima in León, *El país de los extraños*.

6 In Latin America, many prefer to think that there is no racism because we are all "mestizos" or because, as in Brazil, the official ideology is one of "racial democracy." A growing number of Latin Americans who have resided for a time in the United States—including students of the social sciences—return home as converts to the religion of color consciousness, of which they have no doubt been victims. They have become racists in spite of themselves. That is, they are convinced that "race," being defined by "color," is a natural phenomenon and that only "racism"—not race itself—is a question of power. In some cases, this leads to confusion among categories in the debate on cultural conflict and racist ideologies, and they are drawn into making extremely childish arguments. In Peru, a bizarre example is that of de la Cadena, "El racismo silencioso y la superioridad de los intelectuales en el Perú."

7 Relations of domination grounded in sexual differences are older than the current hegemonic colonial/modern pattern of power. But this deepened them by linking them with "race" relations and by viewing both sets of relations in Eurocentric terms. The "racial" classification of the world population redefined the place of "gender" in power relations, placing women of dominant "races" above those of dominated "races" but also above the males of the dominated "races." This led to a strengthening of both forms of domination but above all that based on "race."

8 See my "El trabajo en el umbral del siglo XXI."

9 According to United Nations figures, already before the end of the last century there were more than 200 million workers in slavery worldwide. See the interview of Brazilian anthropologist José de Souza Martins in *Estudos Avançados*, no. 31 (São Paulo: Universidad de São Paulo, Instituto de Estudos Avançados, 1997). This is probably a conservative estimate, as it does not include the recent rapid expansion of slavery in the Amazon basin. In March 2004, President Lula issued a decree prohibiting slavery in the Brazilian *fazendas* (haciendas), but in the conflict between landowners and landless peasants organized in the Movemento dos Sem Terra, hundreds of slave workers are discovered in those *fazendas* almost every day.

10 Shortly before Fujimori fell from power, TV reporters documented open racial/ethnic discrimination in certain nightclubs. At first they were officially penalized, but later the Supreme Court ruled that they had a legal right to discriminate.

11 It is essential to bear in mind that unless one accepts Cartesian radical dualism, the "biological" or "corporal" is just one dimension of the person, who must be viewed as an organism that knows, dreams, thinks, loves, enjoys, suffers, etc. and that all these activities occur with and in the body. So, "body" and "biology," if implying not difference within our organism but instead radical separation from "reason" and "spirit," are only categories of Cartesian radical dualism as one of the founding myths of the Eurocentrist perspective of knowledge.

12 See the references in my "Coloniality of Power, Eurocentrism and Latin America."

13 See Quijano, "Raza, etnia y nación en José Carlos Mariátegui."

14 On these questions, see Marks, *Human Biodiversity.*

15 It is extremely revealing that the only cultural category counterposed to "Occident" was "Orient." "Indians" and especially "Blacks" are thus completely missing from the Eurocentric map of human culture.

16 Wallerstein, *The Modern World-System*.

17 This is clearly the position established in René Descartes, *Discours de la Méthode* (1637) and *Traité des passions de l'âme* (1650). A good discussion of this rupture is Bousquie, *Le corps, cet inconnu*. See also Michel, *Philosophie et phenomenologie*.

18 On these questions, see my article "Coloniality of Power and Its Institutions."

5

COLONIALITY OF POWER AND SOCIAL CLASSIFICATION

Introduction

Coloniality, one of the specific constitutive elements of the world matrix (*patrón*) of capitalist power, is based on the imposition of a racial/ethnic classification of the world's population as the cornerstone of that matrix of power and operates in every level, field, and dimension, both material and subjective, of everyday life and at the social scale.[1] Coloniality originated with the Americas and from there spread around the world. With the establishment of (Latin) America,[2] at the same moment and in the same historical movement, the emerging capitalist power became worldwide, its hegemonic centers located in zones situated on the Atlantic, which would later be identified as Europe, and coloniality and modernity were also established as the central axes of its new domineering matrix. In other words, with (Latin) America, capitalism spread worldwide and became Eurocentered, and coloniality and modernity were set up as and to this day remain the constitutive axes of this specific matrix of power.[3]

Over the course of the deployment of these characteristics of today's power, the new social identities of coloniality (Indian, Black, olive-skinned, yellow, white, mestizo) were being configured, as were the geocultures of colonialism (the Americas, Africa, the Far East, the Near East, the West, and Europe). The corresponding intersubjective relations, in which the experiences of colonialism and coloniality were being fused with

the requirements of capitalism, were being configured as a new universe of intersubjective relationships of domination under Eurocentered hegemony. This specific universe is what would afterward be termed "modernity."

Beginning in the seventeenth century in the major hegemonic centers of this world matrix of power—which in that century included, not by chance, Holland (René Descartes, Baruch Spinoza) and England (John Locke, Isaac Newton)—a means of knowledge making was elaborated and formalized in that intersubjective universe to render an account of the cognitive needs of capitalism: measurement, quantification, and the externalization (objectification) of the knowable with respect to the knower in order to control people's relations with nature and among people with respect to nature, especially ownership of the means of labor. Within this same orientation the experiences, identities, and historical relationships of coloniality and the geocultural distribution of world capitalist power were also formally naturalized. This means of knowing was termed "rational," giving to it its character and Eurocentric origins; it was imposed and acknowledged in the whole of the capitalist world as the only valid rationality as well as the emblem of modernity. The major lines of this cognitive perspective remain, despite changes in their specific contents, despite critiques and debates throughout the duration of the world power of colonial and modern capitalism. This is the modernity/rationality that has now at last entered into crisis.[4]

Eurocentrism is therefore not the perspective of Europeans exclusively, or only those who dominate world capitalism, but rather of everyone educated under their hegemony. And though it entails an ethnocentric component, that component does not explain it, nor does it serve as the main source of its meaning. Eurocentrism is a cognitive perspective produced over the long term of the Eurocentered world of colonial/modern capitalism taken as a whole. Eurocentrism naturalizes the experience of people in this matrix of power. That is, Eurocentrism makes it so that this experience is perceived as natural and, consequently, as a given, not subject to being questioned. Since the eighteenth century, especially with the Enlightenment, the mythological idea that Europe preexisted this power patron was established through Eurocentrism: the notion that it had already been a world center of the capitalism that would later colonize the rest of the world, elaborating modernity and rationality on its own and from within.[5] In this order of ideas, Europe and the Europeans stood at the most advanced moment and level on the linear, unidirectional, and continual march of our species. Another of the central cores of Eurocentric coloniality/modernity was similarly consolidated along with this idea: a conception of human-

ity according to which the world's population is sorted into inferiors and superiors, irrational and rational, primitive and civilized, traditional and modern. Later on, especially since the middle of the nineteenth century and despite the continuing spread of capital around the world, the hegemonic perspective began to give rise to a perception of capitalist power as a worldwide whole and of its long-term reproduction, change, and crisis. The place of world capitalism was filled by the nation-state and relations among nation-states not only as a unit of analysis but also as the one valid approach to understanding capitalism, not only in liberalism but also in so-called historical materialism, the most widespread and Eurocentric approach derived from Marx's heterogeneous legacy.

The intellectual revolt against this perspective and against this Eurocentric mode of knowledge making and regulation of knowing was always present, especially in Latin America.[6] But it did not really take off until after World War II, beginning of course in the areas dominated by and dependent on the capitalist world. As for power, it is always from the margins that intellectual revolt can be seen first and best, because that is where the totality of the field of relationships and meanings that constitute power comes into question. The most influential effort coming out of Latin America to show again the worldwide nature of capitalism was undoubtedly by Raúl Prebisch and those associated with him, who thought of capitalism as a world-system divided into "centers" and "peripheries." This view was taken up and reworked by Immanuel Wallerstein, whose theory of a "modern world-system," from a perspective that combines the Marxian view of capitalism as a world-system with the Braudelian concept of the historical *longue durée*, has been instrumental in reopening and refreshing the debate on the reconstitution of a global perspective in the social science research of the last quarter of the twentieth century.[7] Other components of the Latin American debate are active now in this new context, pointing toward a new idea of social-historical totality, the core of a non-Eurocentric rationality. I refer to proposals about the coloniality of power and about the structural-historical heterogeneity of all the worlds of social existence, which I will discuss forthwith.

The Question of Power in Eurocentrism

Power, as we have known it through history, is a space and a web of social relationships of exploitation/domination/conflict primarily articulated in terms of the struggle for control of the following spheres of social existence: (1) labor and its products; (2) depending on the former, "nature" and its

production resources; (3) sex, its products, and the regeneration of the species; (4) subjectivity and its material and intersubjective products, including knowledge; and (5) authority and its tools, especially coercion, for ensuring the reproduction of this matrix of social relations and regulating changes in it. Over the past two centuries, however, up until the questions of subjectivity and gender irrupted into the debate, the Eurocentric gaze has been unable to perceive all of these spheres in the configuration of power, because it has been dominated by the confrontation between two major approaches. One is hegemonic: liberalism. The other is subaltern, though defiant in intent: historical materialism.

Liberalism does not have a univocal perspective on power. Its oldest version (Hobbes) maintains that authority, as agreed upon by previously scattered people, is what places the components of social existence in an order meant for meeting the needs of individual life. Though this view has become current again as an underpinning of neoliberalism, for most of the twentieth century it lost ground to the ascendency of structuralism, structural functionalism, and functionalism, whose common element with regard to this problem is that society is ordered around a limited set of historically invariable patterns so that the components of a society maintain continuous, consistent relationships with each other in terms of their respective functions, which in turn are inherent in the character of each element. Today the old empiricism and new postmodernism coexist and combine with all these variants, for which there is no such thing as a global structure of social relationships, a society as a given totality, distinguishable from others. In this way, they go hand in hand with the old Hobbesian theory.

For historical materialism—the most Eurocentric among the versions in Marx's heterogeneous legacy—social structures are constructed on the basis of relationships established to control labor and its products. These relationships are termed "relations of production." But unlike the variants of liberalism, historical materialism asserts not only that one particular sphere—labor and the relations of production—has primacy over all the rest but also, and just as insistently, that the existing order results from a series of decisions that arise from the primary sphere and permeate the whole. From this point of view, labor control is the base upon which all power relations are articulated and at the same time is the thing that determines each of those relations. Despite their many considerable differences, a set of common assumptions and issues can be discerned in each of these versions, pointing to their common Eurocentric lineage.

There are two questions in particular to highlight here. First, all of these versions presuppose a structure configured by elements that are, despite their diversity in form and character, historically homogeneous and that relate to each other continuously in consistent ways—whether because of their "functions" or the links that determine them—and linearly and unidirectionally in time and space. In this perspective, every social structure is organic or systemic, mechanical. And that exactly is the preferential option of Eurocentrism in the historical production of knowledge. In this option, something called "society," in its capacity as an articulation of multiple existences into a single structure, is either impossible and has no place in reality, as in the old empiricism and the new postmodernism, or, if it does exist, can only do so in a systemic or organic way.

Second, underlying all these versions is the idea that relationships among the components of a social structure are somehow given, ahistorical; that is, they are the product of the action of some agent prior to the history of relations among people. If, as in Hobbes, human actions and decisions are seen as being involved in the origin of authority and order, that is not the case as a matter of historical fact or even a historical myth, properly speaking, but rather as a metaphysical myth that postulates a state of nature, with individual humans who have no relationships with each other apart from continual violence; that is, they have no genuine social relations with one another. If human actions are also seen in Marx as being involved in the origin of "relations of production," for historical materialism this takes place apart from all subjectivity; that is, again, metaphysically, not historically. In much the same way, in functionalism, structuralism, and structural functionalism people are subject ab initio to the rule of certain historically invariable patterns of behavior.

The Eurocentric perspective, in each of its variants, thus entails a historically impossible assumption: that the relations between the elements of a historical matrix of power are already determined prior to any history, that is, as if they were previously defined in an ahistorical or transhistorical ontic sphere. Eurocentric modernity does not appear to have completed the exercise of secularizing the idea of a providential God. Otherwise, conceptualizing the social existence of concrete people as being configured ab initio by historically homogeneous and consistent elements, indefinitely destined to have continual, linear, and unidirectional relations with each other, would be unnecessary and ultimately unthinkable.

The Structural-Historical Heterogeneity of Power

Such a perspective on knowledge would be hard put to account for historical experience. First, there is no known matrix of power whose components relate to each other in this way, especially over the long term. Far from it. What we actually see is always a structural articulation among historically heterogeneous elements, that is, ones that arise from specific histories and distinct timespaces far from one another, which thus have forms and characters that are not only different but also discontinuous, incoherent, and even conflicting with each other at every moment and over the long term. A historically effective demonstration of this, perhaps better than any other experience, is precisely the establishment and historical expansion of the Americas and world capitalism, colonial and modern.

In each of the main spheres of social existence, control of which is disputed by people, whose victories and defeats form the relationships of exploitation/domination/conflict that constitute power, the component elements are always historically heterogeneous. Thus, labor in world capitalism exists today, as it did five hundred years ago, in each and every historically known form (wage labor, enslavement, servitude, small-scale market production, reciprocity), all in the service of capital and articulated around their waged form. But in the same way, in each of the other spheres—authority, sex, subjectivity—each of these historically known forms is present under the general primacy of the forms called "modern": the "nation-state," the "bourgeois family," "modern rationality."

The really remarkable thing about any social structure is that historically discontinuous, distinct, distant, and heterogeneous elements, experiences, and products could be articulated together, regardless of their incongruencies and conflicts, in the common framework that weaves them into a joint structure. The relevant question is to inquire what such a relationship brings forth, allows, or determines and what gives it the character and behavior of a specific, determined historical totality. And as the experience of the Americas and the capitalist world today demonstrates, what first creates the conditions for this articulation in each case is the ability that one group attains or manages for imposing itself on the others and articulating their heterogeneous histories into a new social structure. This is always a history of necessities but also of intentions, desires, knowledge or ignorance, options and preferences, decisions right and wrong, victories, and defeats and thus never of the actions of extrahistorical factors.

The possibilities to act that people have are not endless, not even very numerous or diverse. The available resources are not abundant. Even more significant is the fact that human actions and omissions cannot be separated from what has already been done, what already exists, conditioning the actions (external or not) of subjectivity, knowledge, and desires and intensions. Hence, the options, desired or not, conscious or not, for all or some people cannot be decided or acted out in a historical vacuum. This does not mean, not necessarily at least, that these options come inscribed by extrahistorical, suprahistorical, or transhistorical determinations, like "fate" in the classical Greek tragedies. In short, they are not inevitable. Or was it inevitable that Christopher Columbus would stumble across what he called Hispaniola instead of reaching the place we now call New York? The technical conditions of his venture allowed for one outcome as easily as the other or for the failure of both. Think about the fundamental implications, which are not trivial, of this issue for the history of the capitalist world.

The capacity and strength that allow one group to impose itself on the others is not, however, sufficient for articulating heterogeneous histories into a lasting structural order. They certainly can produce authority, in the form of a capacity for coercion. Strength and coercion—or, in the liberal gaze, consensus—cannot, however, lastingly create or replicate the structural order of a society, that is, the relations among the components of each of the spheres of social existence or the relations among those spheres themselves. Nor can they, in particular, fabricate the meaning of the movement and historical development of the social structure as a whole. The only thing that authority can do is force or persuade people to submit to those relations and to that general meaning of the movement of the society that dwells within them. In this way it contributes to maintaining and reproducing these relations and to controlling its crises and changes.

If, however, liberalism has insisted since Hobbes that authority determines the social order, the structural order of power relations, that is because it also insists that all other spheres of social existence that are articulated into this structure are "natural." But if this nonhistorical character of social existence is rejected as impossible, then the explanation for why social existence consists of specific spheres or fields of social relations and why those fields tend to be articulated in a joint field of relations, the structural configuration of which and whose reproduction or excision over time is known by the concept of society, must be sought in a different historical occurrence. Where can that occurrence be found? The difficulties

with structuralist and functionalist theories have already been pointed out not only in accounting for the historical heterogeneity of social structures but also because they imply necessarily consistent relations among their components. We are left, then, with Marx's proposal (one of the sources for historical materialism) regarding labor as the primary sphere in any society and labor control as primary for any social power. This proposal raises two problems that must be discussed.

First, it is true that the experience of Eurocentered, colonial/modern capitalist power shows that labor control is the prime factor in this matrix of power, which is capitalist above all else. In consequence, the control of labor by capital is the central condition of capitalist power. But in Marx this implies, on one hand, that this and all other factors are historically homogeneous and, on the other hand, that labor ever and always determines the character, place, and function of all other spheres in the power structure. Nevertheless, taking a second look at the experience of the global matrix of capitalist power, there is nothing to indicate that its components or even its basics—whether labor, capital, or capitalism—are historically homogeneous. On the contrary, within each of these categories we find every form, stage, and level in their respective histories, not merely coexisting but rather articulating and combining with one another. For example, wage labor exists today, as it did at the dawn of its history, alongside enslavement, servitude, small-scale market production, and reciprocity. And all of these articulate with each other and with capital. Wage labor itself differs with every historical form of accumulation, from so-called original or primitive accumulation, through extensive surplus value, to every gradation of intensity and every level that current technology permits and contains, and up to those forms in which individual labor is virtually insignificant. Capitalism necessarily encompasses this entire complicated and heterogeneous universe under its domination.

Regarding the unidirectional chain of determinations that allow labor to articulate the other spheres and keep them articulated over the long term, the experience of the Eurocentered, colonial/modern capitalist global matrix of power does not in any way demonstrate that its capitalist feature makes any of the other features necessary or inevitable. Moreover, the capitalist character of this matrix of power undoubtedly has decisive implications for the character and meaning of intersubjective relations and authority relations and for relationships surrounding sex and its products. But, first, it is only if we ignore the historical heterogeneity of these relations and the way in which they are ordered within each sphere and with

each other that we could possibly think that these implications are unilinear and unidirectional. And second, at this point in the debate it should be obvious that although the current mode of control of labor has implications for social intersubjectivity, for example, we likewise know that opting for a capitalist form of organizing and controlling labor required an intersubjectivity that would make such a thing possible and preferable. Determinations therefore are not and cannot be unilinear or unidirectional. And they are not only reciprocal. They are heterogeneous, discontinuous, inconsistent, and conflict-ridden, as should be expected for relations among elements that each have those same characteristics. The articulation of heterogeneous, discontinuous, and conflict-ridden elements in a common structure, within a given field of relations, thus necessarily entails relations of reciprocal, multiple, and heterogeneous determinations.

Structuralism and functionalism were never able to see these historical necessities. They took a wrong turn, reducing those necessities to the idea of functional relationships among the elements of a social structure. In any case, however, for a structural-historically heterogeneous structure to move, develop, or (if you will) behave like a historical totality, these modes of reciprocal and heterogeneous determination among its components are not enough. It is essential that one (or more) of them have primacy—in the case of capitalism, control over labor and authority, combined—not as a determinant or as the base of determinations in the historical materialism sense but rather strictly as the axis or axes around which the whole complex is structured. In this way, the joint movement of this totality, the meaning of its development, encompasses and transcends each of its component parts. That is, a given field of social relations behaves like a totality. But such a social-historical totality, as an articulation of heterogeneous, discontinuous, and conflict-ridden elements, cannot be closed in any way, nor can it be systemically consistent like a machine, constituting an entity in which the logic of each element fits that of each other component. Its joint movements consequently cannot be unilinear or unidirectional, as would necessarily be the case for organic or systemic or mechanical entities.

Notes on the Question of Totality

Regarding these issues, it is essential to keep researching and debating the implications of the epistemological paradigm putting forward the relationship between the whole and the parts with respect to social-historical existence. Eurocentrism has led virtually everyone to accept that within a

totality, the whole has absolute, determinative primacy over each and every one of its parts and therefore that there is one and only one logic governing the behavior of the whole and of each and every one of its parts. The possible variations in the movement of each part are secondary, with no effect on the whole, and are recognized as particularities of a general rule or logic for the whole to which they belong. This is not the proper place, for obvious reasons, to begin a systematic debate on this paradigm, which in Eurocentric modernity has in the end been recognized as one of the keystones of rationality, performed as spontaneously as breathing in concrete knowledge production, treated as beyond question. All I propose to do here is to raise the narrow question of its implications for the specific knowledge of social-historical experience. Under this rubric, it is necessary to recognize that every social-historical phenomenon consists in and expresses a social relationship or a web of social relationships. Therefore, its explanation and meaning can only be found within a field of relations larger than the one to which it belongs. Such a field of relations, with respect to which a given phenomenon may be explained and made sense of, is what here is termed the social-historical totality. The continued presence of this paradigm in social-historical research and debate, particularly since the late eighteenth century, is no accident: it accounts for the recognition of its tremendous importance, especially because it made freedom from empiricist atomism and providentialism possible. Nevertheless, not only has atomistic empiricism remained part of the debate, it has now found new expression in so-called social-philosophical postmodernism.[8] Both of these reject the idea of totality and of its necessity in knowledge making.

The renewal and expansion of the atomistic view of social-historical experience under the full-blown crisis of modernity/rationality is also no accident. This is a complex and contradictory matter. On one hand, it accounts for the fact that it is more evident now that the dominant ideas of totality leave out many, too many, areas of social-historical experience or embrace them only in a distorted way. But on the other hand, the explicit association between denying totality and denying the reality of social power in the new postmodernism is again no accident, just as in the old empiricism.

Indeed, what the totality paradigm allowed us to notice in the history of concrete people's social existence was precisely power as the most persistent form of structural articulation within the social sphere. Ever since, whether to question it or defend it, the starting point has been to recognize its real existence in people's lives. But most of all, it was the critique of power that

ended up at the center of social-historical study and debate. By contrast, in the atomistic view, whether in the old empiricism or the new postmodernism, social relationships do not form complex fields of social relations in which all distinguishable spheres of social existence, and therefore of social relations, are articulated together. That is to say, something called "society" would have no place in reality. Therefore, finding an explanation and a meaning for social phenomena would be neither possible nor necessary. Contingent experience, description as representation, would be the only thing that was necessary and legitimate. The idea of totality would be not only unnecessary but, above all, an epistemological distortion. The notion that long-lasting structures of social relationships exist would give way to the idea of unstable, changing flows that never quite solidify as structures.[9]

To deny the reality of social power, empiricism and postmodernism have to deny the idea of social-historical totality and the existence of a primary sphere in the social configuration that acts as the axis for articulating the other spheres. In the old empiricism, power exists only as authority in a single sphere of social relations that themselves are, by definition, discrete. In postmodernism all the way back to its poststructuralist origins, power exists only at the scale of social microrelations and as a discrete, fluid phenomenon. It thus makes no sense for any of these sides in the debate to think of changing something called "society" as a whole and to that end locating its axes of articulation or the determinant facts that need to be changed. Historical change would be strictly an individual matter even if there were many individuals involved in social microrelations.

In this confrontation between the organic, systemic ideas of totality, on one hand, and the denial of any notion of totality, on the other, we would seem to be dealing with completely opposed options, even irreconcilable epistemic perspectives. Both, however, have a Eurocentric lineage in common: for both positions, the only thinkable paradigm of totality is the Eurocentric one. Put differently, both are based on a presupposition that is never discussed or made explicit, which is that any notion of totality implies that the whole and the parts correspond to a single logic of existence. That is, they have a basic homogeneity that maintains the consistency and continuity of their relationships, as in an organism, a machine, or a systemic entity. From this perspective, denying the need for the notion of totality in knowledge production is extreme but not entirely arbitrary. For our current social-historical knowledge needs, today this notion of totality means distorting reality as seriously as the disadvantages of the old atomistic empiricism did.

But what happens when we face totalities that consist of an articulation of historically heterogeneous elements whose relations are discontinuous, inconsistent, and conflict-ridden? The answer is that relations between the whole and the parts in social existence are real but necessarily very different from what Eurocentrism postulates. A social-historical totality is in a relationship field structured by the heterogeneous and discontinuous articulation of diverse spheres of social existence, each of these in turn structured from historically heterogeneous elements that are discontinuous in time and conflict-ridden. This means that the parts in a social power relationship field are more than mere "parts"; they are parts with respect to the entirety of the field, the totality that it constitutes, and consequently they move within the general orientation of that whole, but they are not parts in their separate relationships with each other. Each of them is a complete unity in its own configuration, because they likewise have historically heterogeneous constitutions. Each element in a historical totality is particular and at the same time specific, perhaps even singular. Each of them moves within the general tendency of the group, but they each have or may have relative autonomy, which may be or come to be in conflict with the group. This is also where we find the notion of social-historical change.

Does this mean that the notion of totality has no place or meaning here? Not in the least. What articulates all the heterogeneous and discontinuous spheres in a social-historical structure is a common axis around which the whole tends to move, generally as a group, acting as a totality. But that structure is not and cannot be closed, just as, to the contrary, an organic or systemic structure cannot help but be closed. Therefore, unlike the latter, if such a group tends to move or behave in one singular direction, it cannot do so unilinearly or unidirectionally or unidimensionally, because there are many heterogeneous and even conflicting impulses or logics at work within it, especially considering that there are human needs, desires, intentions, choices, decisions, and actions constantly at play. In other words, historical processes of change are not and cannot be a matter of transforming one historically homogeneous totality into another equivalent one, whether gradually and continuously or in fits and starts. If that were the case, change would entail one totality, with all its components, making a complete exit from the historical stage and then another one derived from it entering to take its place. This is the central, necessary, explicit idea in gradual, unilinear evolutionism, one also implied by the variants of structuralism, functionalism, and also—though it runs counter to its formal discourse—historical materialism. It is not, however, what happens in real experience, least of all

with the world matrix of power that was established along with the Americas. Change affects the components of a historical field of social relations in a heterogeneous, discontinuous way. This is probably the concrete historical meaning of what is seen as a contradiction in the historical movement of social existence.

The perception that a field of social relations is made up of homogeneous, continuous elements, even if they are contradictory (in the Hegelian sense), gives rise to a view of history as a series of changes that consist of the transformation of a homogeneous, continuous whole into another equivalent one. The debate about whether this takes place gradually and in a linear fashion or in fits and starts, which can usually be passed off as an epistemological confrontation between "positivism" and "the dialectic," is thus purely formal. It actually entails no epistemological break. This shows that what leads many to set aside any notion of totality is that the systemic or organic ideas surrounding it have come to be seen or sensed as a sort of intellectual straitjacket, since they force us to homogenize actual experience and thus see it in a distorted fashion. This does not mean, of course, that we have to deny the possible or proven existence of organic or systemic totalities. Indeed there are organisms and mechanical objects whose parts relate systemically to one another. But any attempt to view social structures in the same way necessarily distorts them.

From an organic or systemic perspective on social-historical totality, any attempt to manage social-historical totalities, especially when it comes to planning for change, can only lead to experiences that have come to be known, not by chance, as totalitarian. At the same time, however, since it is not inevitable that every idea of social-historical totality has to be systemic, organic, or mechanical, simply denying all notions of totality in social-historical knowledge can only be associated with denying the reality of power at the social scale. In reality, denying all notations of totality reveals the ideological slant linking it to the current established power.

The Question of Social Classification

In the 1980s in the midst of the world crisis of capitalist power, the already foreseeable became undeniable as the bureaucratic despotism regimes—the rivals of private capitalism and the democratizing processes in the capitalist societies and states on the "periphery" and also of the worker movements aimed at destroying capitalism—fell in defeat. This context helped bring flows to light within historical materialism that until then had remained

fairly underground, currents that had begun to feel a certain unease with the concept of social classes that they had inherited.[10] But before long the baby was thrown out with the bathwater, as often happens, and social classes were eclipsed on the intellectual and political stage. This result obviously formed part of the worldwide defeat of the regimes and movements that had contested the world hegemony of the hegemonic centers of capitalism or that stood up to capitalism. And it furthered the imposition of the neoliberal discourse of capitalism as a sort of universal common sense, which from that time until quite recently became not only dominant but virtually "the only way to think."[11] It is less obvious, however, whether those who had formerly frequented the fields of historical materialism rid themselves, after the defeat, of one of their weapons of choice only or primarily so they could pass over more easily into the rival camp.

Though that is the most frequently heard explanation, it is probably not the best. It is more likely that what had been happening with the question of social classes among the followers and devotees of historical materialism had been similar to what had gone on with organic or systemic notions about totality: the defeats and, most of all, the disappointments within their own political camp ("actually existing socialism") had made productive use of their version of historical materialism with regard to social classes ever more problematic. That version had managed to turn class from a "dynamic to a static" category, as E. P. Thompson put it, and to a large extent class was, as Parkin described it in the late 1970s, "one of the Marxist products that have been manufactured and marketed in western universities" of Europe and the United States.[12] Given that for a wide majority this was the only version of social classes seen as legitimately correct, treating it too as an intellectual straitjacket came to be seen as common sense. The efforts to make this straitjacket more bearable, though there were not many of them, gained a wide audience in the 1960s. Think, for example, of the response to the works of Nicos Poulantzas, at one end, and of Erik Olin Wright, at the other.[13] Much more fertile efforts, though with smaller audiences at first, such as the work of E. P. Thompson, unfortunately did not lead to a complete alternative proposal.[14]

Where do the difficulties with the theory of social classes in historical materialism come from? The clearest trail leads us to a history with three distinct steps. The first step is the creation of historical materialism in the late nineteenth century as a product of the positivist-Marxist hybridization in late Engels and the European social-democratic theorists, especially those from Germany, with broad long-standing reverberations among so-

cialists from around the world. The second step is the canonization of the version termed "Marxism-Leninism" that was imposed by bureaucratic despotism under Stalin beginning in the 1920s. Finally, the third step is the new hybridization of that historical materialism with French structuralism following World War II.[15] Historical materialism, with respect to the question of social classes, as in other areas with respect to Marx's theoretical legacy, is not so much a rupture as it is a partial, distorted continuation. This intellectual legacy is admittedly heterogeneous and even more so in its last stages, produced precisely when Marx began to question the Eurocentric cores of his own thought, unfortunately without finding an effective resolution to the epistemic and theoretical problems that this entailed. It thus allows for heterogeneous readings. But historical materialism, especially in its Marxist-Leninist version, attempted, not without success, to make Marx's legacy pass for a systematically homogeneous work and to impose its own reading in order to get itself accepted as his only legitimate heir.

As is well known, Marx expressly stated that he was not the discoverer of social classes or of their struggles, since bourgeois historians and economists had done so before him.[16] But although he curiously does not mention it, there is no doubt that it was in the works of Henri de Saint-Simon and the Saint-Simonians that the basic elements of what a century later would be known as the theory of social classes in historical materialism were first formulated, long before Marx.[17] The is true in particular in the famous *Exposition de la Doctrine de Saint-Simon*, first published in 1828 by the so-called Saint-Simonian Left, which had great influence in social and political debates for much of the nineteenth century.

There are yet more remarkable points on which Saint-Simon coincides with historical materialism with respect to the question of social classes. Considering that the *Exposition de la Doctrine* was written after three hundred years of Eurocentered, colonial/modern world capitalist history, it is amazing that the text shows an absolute blindness to the following points: (1) Under capitalism, every form of labor exploitation/domination coexisted and became associated with one another. (2) In the world of capitalism, the social classes did not include only "industrialists" on one side and "workers" or "proletarians" on the other; there were also "slaves," "serfs/servants," "plebeians," and "free peasants." (3) The structure of domination that originated in the colonial experience of "Europeans" or "whites" and "Indians," "Blacks," "Asians," and "mestizos" entailed profound power relations, which in that period were so closely tied to forms of labor exploitation that

they seemed to be "naturally" associated with each other. (4) The capital-wage relationship was not the only power axis, not even in the economy; instead, there were other power axes that existed and acted in spheres that were not solely economic, such as "race," gender, and age. (5) In consequence, the distribution of power among a society's population did not derive exclusively from relations surrounding labor control, nor could it be reduced to such relations.

Marx's inquiry into social classes was probably linked to the Saint-Simonian debate. But along with the similarities, there are also noteworthy differences that may be worth pointing out here. In the first place, it is true that Marx maintained the same (Saint-Simonian and Eurocentric) perspective of a unilinear, unidirectional historical sequence of class societies almost to the end of his work. However, it is now well known that as he became familiar with the historical research and political debate of the Russian Narodniks (populists), he realized that this unidirectionality and unilinearity left out other decisive historical experiences. He thus became conscious of the Eurocentrism in his historical perspective, but he did not make the appropriate epistemological leap. Historical materialism subsequently chose to condemn and omit this period of Marx's research, clinging dogmatically to the most Eurocentric aspect of his legacy.

On the other hand, it is true, as everyone knows, that there is a perceptible distinction between the view on class relations that his theory on capital entails and the view that underlies Marx's historical studies. In his theory, capital is a social relationship specific to production, the two fundamental terms of which are "capitalists" and "workers." The former are those who control the relationship, and in that capacity they are the "functionaries" of capital. They dominate the relationship, but they do so to their own private benefit. In that capacity, they are exploiters of the workers. From this point of view, both terms are the basic social classes in *Capital*. On the other hand, however, above all in his analysis of the French conjuncture, particularly in *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*, Marx takes into account various social classes that, depending on the conditions of politico-social conflict, emerge, consolidate, or retire from the scene: commercial bourgeoisie, industrial bourgeoisie, proletariat, large landowners, finance oligarchy, petite bourgeoisie, middle class, lumpenproletariat, big bureaucracy. Likewise, in *Theories of Surplus Value*, he notes that Ricardo neglected to emphasize the constant growth of the middle classes.

Subsequent historical materialism, especially its Marxist-Leninist version, has dealt with these differences in Marx's inquiry through three

proposals. The first is that the differences are due to the level of theoretical abstraction in *Capital* and conjunctural history in *The Eighteenth Brumaire*. The second is that these differences are, moreover, transitory, since as capital develops it will in any case tend to become polarized into the two basic social classes. The third is that the theory in *Capital* implies that it is dealing with a social relationship structured independently of people's wills and consciousnesses, and as a consequence the way people are distributed within that social relationship is necessary and inevitable due to a historical law that is beyond them. In this view, social classes are presented as structures created by the nature of the social relationship; their occupants are the bearers of their determinations, and as such people's behaviors should reflect those structural determinations.

The first proposal finds confirmation in Marx's own words. Thus, in the famous incomplete chapter on classes in the third volume of *Capital*, Marx contends that "the owners merely of labor-power, owners of capital, and land-owners, whose respective sources of income are wages, profit and ground-rent, in other words, wage-laborers, capitalists and land-owners, constitute then three big classes of modern society based upon the capitalist mode of production."[18] "Nevertheless," he continues, not even in England—despite its being the most developed and "classic" of modern capitalist societies—can it be said that "the stratification of classes does not appear in its pure form," given that the middle classes "and intermediate strata even here obliterate lines of demarcation." But he immediately notes that all this will be cleared up by the unfolding of the "law of development of the capitalist mode of production," which continuously leads to polarization between the basic classes.

With *The Eighteenth Brumaire*, however, there is a double displacement—of problematics and of perspective—that cannot be explained solely by the fact that the work is a conjunctural history analysis. The movement of Marx's thought entails, first, the idea that the French society of the time contained not only wage labor but also many other diverse forms of labor exploitation, all articulated with the dominion of capital and to its benefit. This fact somehow heralds the differentiation between capital (the relation between capital and wages) and capitalism (heterogeneous relationships between capital and all other forms of labor), confronting it in advance of the theory of the articulation of modes of production later produced by historical materialism. Second is the idea that classes are formed, fall apart, or are consolidated, whether partially and temporarily or definitely and permanently, according to the course of concrete struggles by concrete groups

of people struggling for the control of each sphere of power. They are not structures or categories that exist prior to such struggles.

This line of Marx's thought is also present in *Capital*, despite all its well-known ambiguities. Therefore, the third proposal establishes a basic difference between Marx's perspective and that of historical materialism. In the latter, social classes occupy a sort of set of structural pigeonholes into which people are sorted and placed according to their production relationships. In Marx, by contrast, we see a concrete historical process of classifying people, that is, a process of struggles in which some people manage to subjugate others as they dispute the control of labor and production resources. In other words, relations of production are neither external to nor prior to people's struggles but instead are the result of struggles among people for the control of labor and production resources, of victories by some and defeats by others, as a result of which people place themselves or are placed and classified. This is undoubtedly the theoretical proposal entailed in the famous chapter on "primitive accumulation."[19] Otherwise, the line of analysis in *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* makes no sense. In Marx's line of thought therefore, social classes are neither structures nor categories but historically rather produced (and in that sense historically determined) relationships even when this view is reduced to just one of the spheres of power: labor. Historical materialism, on the other hand, as E. P. Thompson points out, sticks to the "static" (in other words, ahistorical) view that attributes to social classes the status of structures established by relations of production coming into existence outside of people's subjectivity and actions, that is, prior to any history.

Historical materialism since World War II has acknowledged that there are complicated outstanding problems with its evolutionist, unidirectional view of social classes and class societies. In the first place, because it has repeatedly been seen that there are some "precapitalist" classes even in the "centers," the peasantry in particular, who have not left the historical scene of "capitalism," nor do they appear disposed to leave, while others, the "middle classes," have tended to increase as capitalism has developed. In the second place, the dualistic view of a passage from "precapitalism" to "capitalism" was not broad enough to account for the experiences of the "Third World," where very complex and heterogeneous configurations of power did not correspond to the expected stages in the Eurocentric theory of capitalism. Nevertheless, historical materialism could not find a theoretical solution backed up by historical experience, arriving only at the proposal of an "articulation of the modes of production" without giving up on

the idea that those formed a sequence. That is, such "articulations" were still conjunctures in the transition from "precapitalist" modes to "capitalism."[20] In other words, they consist of the coexistence (transitory, of course) of past and present in their historical vision. Historical materialism is hostile to the idea that these might not be "articulated modes of production" but rather capitalism as a world power structure within which and in the service of which every historically known form of labor and of social labor control and exploitation are articulated.

Then again, the idea of "class" was introduced in the natural sciences before being used in the social sciences. The Swedish naturalist Linnaeus, in his famous eighteenth-century botanical classification system, was the first to employ it. He discovered that it was possible to classify plants according to the number and placement of stamens in their flowers, as those tend to remain unchanged over the course of evolution.[21] Basically the same way of knowing seems to have led French historians in the eighteenth century, followed by Saint-Simonians in the early nineteenth, to classify the population of Europe by "classes." For Linnaeus, the plants were already there, in the "plant kingdom," a given of nature, and based on a few of their empirically differentiable characteristics it was possible to "classify" them. The people who studied and debated the society of north-central Europe in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries applied the same perspective to people, finding that it was possible to classify them too based on their most constant characteristics, especially their place in the social structure of wealth and poverty, command and obedience. It was the Saint-Simonians who discovered that the main source of these differences lay in control over labor and its products and the products of nature that were used by labor.

The theorists of historical materialism did not make any decisive ruptures or changes in this knowledge perspective from the late nineteenth century on. Of course, when they transferred the noun "class" from the natural world to the social world, they had to associate it with an adjective to legitimate that shift: class ceased to be botanical and became social. But the shift was basically semantic. The new adjective by itself could not suffice to cut the umbilical cord linking the newborn concept to the naturalist womb or to provide it with an alternative epistemic atmosphere to develop in. In Eurocentric thinking, heir to the continent's Enlightenment, society was an organism, a given closed order, and social classes were thought of as already given categories within "society," much as were the classes of plants within "nature."

Note in relation to these questions that other terms with the same naturalist origins—"structure," "processes," "organism"—in Eurocentrism pass into social knowledge with the same cognitive attachments as the term "class." The obvious linkage between the Eurocentric idea of social classes and the ideas of "structure" as a given order in society and of "process" as something that takes place in a structure casts a bright light on the persistence in them of the cognitive signs of their naturalist origin and thereby of its lasting impact on the Eurocentric perspective within social-historical knowledge. There is no other way to understand or explain the idea of historical materialism or of sociologists of "industrial society" according to which people are "bearers" of class structural determinations and therefore should act in accordance with them. Their desires, preferences, intentions, wills, decisions, and actions are configured according to those determinations and should correspond to them. The problem created by the inevitable distance between this assumption and the subjectivity and external conduct of people so classified found an impossible solution in historical materialism: this was a problem of "consciousness," which could only be brought to the exploited masses by bourgeois intellectuals, much as pollen is carried to the flowers by bees (Kautsky-Lenin) or be elaborated and developed in a state of continual progress toward an impossible "possible consciousness" (Lukács).

The naturalist, positivist, and positivist-Marxist stamp of the Eurocentric theory of social classes also brings up two crucial issues: (1) In its origins, the theory of social classes is conceived exclusively on the basis of the European experience, which in turn is conceived according to the Eurocentric perspective. (2) The only really meaningful differences that can be perceived among Europeans, since aristocratic hierarchies were abolished by the French Revolution, are those relating to wealth/poverty and command/obedience. These differences refer, on one hand, to people's place and roles with respect to control over labor and the natural resources that serve labor (production relations) and, on the other hand, to people's place and roles in the control of authority, ergo the state. The other differences that were linked in eighteenth- and nineteenth-century European populations to power difference, primarily sex and age, are "natural" from this perspective; that is, they form part of the classification in "nature." In other words, the Eurocentric theory on society classes, not just in positivist-Marxist historical materialism or among Weberians but in Marx himself, is reductionist and refers only and exclusively to one of the spheres of power: control over labor and its resources and products. And this is especially

striking above all in Marx and his heirs, because even though his formal purpose is to study, understand, and change or destroy power in society, he considers absolutely no other instances or social existence in which power relations among people are formed or considers them merely as derivatives of "relations of production" and determined by those.

This all means that the idea of social classes was elaborated in Eurocentric thought between the late eighteenth and late nineteenth centuries, when the perception of the totality as seen from Europe, by then the "center" of the capitalist world, had already been definitively organized as a historical duality: Europe (for these purposes, mainly western Europe and England) and non-Europe. This duality implied, moreover, that much of what made up non-Europe, though it existed on the same temporal stage, really corresponded to the past in linear time, the end point of which was obviously Europe. In non-Europe, every nonwage form of labor existed in that same nineteenth-century moment. But from Saint-Simon to the present, Eurocentrism has only seen the "precapitalist" or "preindustrial" past in such forms. That is, those classes are either "precapitalist" or nonexistent. Non-European or "nonwhite" identities had been imposed on non-Europe. But like age or gender among Europeans, such identities corresponded to "natural" power differences between Europeans and non-Europeans. The modern institutions of authority were being formed or had already been formed in Europe: modern nation-states and their respective identities. But in non-Europe, only tribes and ethnic groups were perceived as part of the "premodern" past, as they were to be replaced at some future time by nation-states, "like in Europe." Europe is civilized. Non-Europe is primitive. The rational subject is European. Non-Europe is an object of knowledge. Correspondingly, the science for studying Europeans will be called "sociology," while that for studying non-Europeans will be called "ethnography."

At this point in the debate, it is not good enough to stay within the known parameters, because that will not address all the issues or solve all the problems raised for knowing and acting. Sticking to an insistence that the question of social classes has to be historicized—that is, related to the concrete history of concrete people instead of maintaining a "static" or ahistorical view of social classes, replacing Marx with Weber, or exploring their fruitful intersections, as tends to be done in academic sociology—will lead nowhere. All that happens in any of these options, or in all of them together, is that people get classified by some of their given differential characteristics, and there is really nothing fundamental to be gained if one set

of characteristics or another are chosen, or should be chosen, to make the classificatory system less "ideological" and more "objective."

The important factor in the classification of the elements of nature, as befit Cartesian rationality, was discovering the "properties" that define and simultaneously create kindred ties among specific "objects" or that distinguish them individually and show their proximate genus and specific differentia. But with the question of social classes, what is really at stake and has been since the idea was first introduced is something radically different: the question of power in society. And the problem is that none of those options, taken either together or separately, are capable of letting us apprehend and probe how power is historically constituted, much less how world and colonial/modern capitalist power is constituted.

For all these reasons, it is appropriate to leave the Eurocentric theory of social classes behind and move on to a historical theory of social classification. The concept of social classification, in this proposal, refers to the long-term processes by which people compete for control over the basic spheres of social existence, from the results of which a matrix is configured for the distribution of power centered on exploitation/domination/conflict relations among the population of a given society and history. It was pointed out above that in this approach, power is a web of exploitation/domination/conflict relations configured among people in the contest over the control of labor, of "nature," of sex, of subjectivity, and of authority. Therefore, power cannot be reduced to "production relations" or to "order and authority" either separately or together. And social classification refers to people's places and roles in the control of labor and its resources (including "natural" resources) and products, of sex and its products, of subjectivity and its products (above all, the imaginary and knowledge), and of authority and its resources and products.

In this specific sense, any possible theory of social classification of people necessarily requires an inquiry into the history, conditions, and determinations of a given distribution of power relations in a specific society. That distribution of power among the people of a society is what classifies them socially, determines their mutual relationships, and generates their social differences, since their empirically observable and differentiable characteristics are the results of those power relations and their signs and traces. One can start with the latter to attain a first moment and a starting level of comprehension of power relations, but it makes no sense to act as if that is where the nature of people's place in society resides, that is, their social class.

The Heterogeneity of Social Classification

Ever since the Americas were introduced into colonial/modern world capitalism, people have been classified according to three lines, each distinct but articulated into a common global structure by the coloniality of power: labor, gender, and race. Age hasn't been introduced into social power relations in the same way, though it has been in particular spheres of power and also around two central axes: control over the production of resources for social survival and control over the biological reproduction and regeneration of the species. The former entails control over the labor force, the resources and products of labor; this includes "natural" resources and is institutionalized as "property." The second entails control over sex and its products (pleasure and descendants), based on property rights. "Race" was incorporated into Eurocentered capitalism based on both axes. And control over authority is organized to guarantee the power relations thus configured. From this perspective, the resulting "social classes" are heterogeneous, discontinuous, and conflict-ridden. The coloniality of power is the axis that articulates them in a common structure, as will be shown below. Insofar as all the elements that enter into the constitution of a matrix of power originate as discontinuous, heterogeneous, contradictory, and conflict-ridden in space and time—that is, they change or could change in each of these instances based on their changing relationships with each of the others—power relations are not and cannot be a sort of preexisting set of structural pigeonholes into which people are sorted and from which they take on this or that set of characteristics and are supposed to behave accordingly.

The way in which people come to occupy a place and a role with respect to the control of the focal instances of power—completely or partially, temporarily or permanently—is a matter of conflict. In other words, it consists of a struggle, violent or not; of defeats and victories; of advances and setbacks. It takes place on individual and collective terms, with acts of loyalty and betrayal, persistence and defection. And given that every relationship structure is an articulation of discontinuous, heterogeneous, and conflict-ridden spheres and dimensions, places and roles do not necessarily have the same positions and relations in every sphere of social existence or at every moment in their respective space/time. That is, people can have, for example, one place and one role with respect to labor control and another very different, even opposite place and role with respect to the control of sex or subjectivity or in the institutions of authority and not always the same ones over the course of time.

From this point of view, the Eurocentric idea that people who occupy certain places and exercise certain roles at a given moment in a matrix of power constitute, on that basis alone, a community or a historical subject points us in a historically unproductive direction. Such a notion would only be plausible if it could also be accepted that such people occupy places and carry out roles that are symmetrically congruent with one another in every one of the focal instances of power. The sorting of people into relationships of power consequently has the character of processes of social classification, declassification, and reclassification of a population, that is, the character of a sorting articulated within a long-term social matrix of power. This is not just about the fact that people change and may change their places and roles in a matrix of power but also the fact that the matrix, as such, is always at stake, given that people are constantly competing and that the resources, reasons, and needs of these conflicts are never the same at every moment of a long history. In other words, power is always in a state of conflict and in processes of sorting and resorting. Its historical periods can be distinguished precisely in terms of such processes.[22]

It consequently cannot be said, based on an alternative to a Eurocentrist approach, that a population affected at one moment and in one form of a social classification process will never gain the characteristics of a real group, a community, and a social subject. But such characteristics only come about as a part and a result of a history of conflicts, of a memory matrix that is associated with that history, that is perceived as an identity, and that produces a will and a resolve to weave together the heterogeneous and discontinuous particular experiences into a subjective collective articulation that will make up an element in real material relationships. The collective struggles of sectors of workers who organized themselves into unions, into political parties, and the struggles of even broader communities that group themselves together as religious identities and that endure over the long term are historical examples of such processes of subjectivization among broad and heterogeneous populations that are even discontinuous in time and space.

Nevertheless, not every process of social subjectivization or of constituting collective subjects can be recognized as a process of social classification. In some cases we are dealing with a problem of forming identities, an identity process that does not put these instances of social power at stake in any way. From our perspective, only those processes of subjectivization whose sense is conflict over exploitation/domination constitute processes of social classification. In world capitalism, the issues of labor, race, and

gender are the three focal instances with respect to which these conflict-ridden relationships of exploitation/domination are ordered. Therefore, the processes of social classification consist in any case of processes in which these three instances associate or dissociate with each other in regard to the exploitation/domination/conflict complex. Of the three focal instances, it is labor—that is, exploitation/domination—that stands out as the central, invariable sphere. Domination makes exploitation possible and finds it acting on its own only very rarely. The other focal instances are, foremost, instances of domination, given that sexual exploitation in particular is discontinuous. That is, while the exploitation/domination relationship between capital and labor is continuous, the same type of relationship does not occur between male and female in every case or under every circumstance; thus, it is not continuous. Likewise, in the relationship among "races," we see foremost domination. In short, the articulation between instances of exploitation and domination is heterogeneous and discontinuous. And by the same token, social classification as a process in which the three instances are associated/dissociated also necessarily has the same characteristics.

One idea originally proposed by Marx as a clearly historical matter was later mystified by historical materialism: that of class interest. To the degree that the idea of class became reductionist and was ahistoricized, class interest in capitalism was reduced to the relationship between capital and wage labor. The interests of other workers were always seen as secondary and subject to being subordinated to those of wage workers, especially to those of the so-called industrial working class.

What happens, however, if we assume, as we must today, that capitalism articulates and exploits workers under every form of labor and that the domination mechanisms used to that effect—"race" and "gender"—are used differentially in this heterogeneous universe of workers? First, the concept of class interest also has to be thought through in terms of its structural-historical heterogeneity.

Next, it is necessary to establish, at each moment and in each specific context, the common axis of the exploitation/domination/conflict relationship between all the workers, subject to every form of labor and every form of domination, and capitalism and its functionaries. For these reasons, the key question about social classification of the processes of social subjectivization in the face of exploitation/domination is determining the specific historical conditions with respect to which it is possible to perceive the modes, levels, and limits for association among people involved

in these three instances (labor, gender, and race) in a specific period and context.

In any case, no process of social classification, of subjectivizing people in the face of capitalism, could be so certain as to reproduce and sustain itself over the period necessary for leading the victims of capitalist exploitation/domination to their liberation if, from the immediate perspective of the concrete people involved, these three instances are perceived and handled separately or, worse, in conflict with each other. Not by chance, maintaining, accentuating, and aggravating the perception among the exploited/dominated of these differential situations in relation to labor, race, and gender has been and is an extremely effective means that capitalists have of maintaining their control of power. The coloniality of power has had the central role in this history.

Coloniality of Power and Social Classification

In known history before world capitalism, it is clear that in power relations, certain attributes of the species have played a key role in the social classification of people: sex, age, and labor status are undoubtedly the most ancient. After the conquest of the Americas, phenotype was added. Sex and age are differentiating biological attributes, though their place in exploitation/domination/conflict relations is associated with their elaboration as social categories. Labor status and phenotype, by contrast, are not differentiating biological attributes. Skin color, the form and color of hair and eyes, the form and size of the nose, etc., have no impact on a person's biological structure and surely even less on their historical capacities. And similarly, being a "manual" or "intellectual" worker is unrelated to biological structure. In other words, the role that each of these elements plays in social classification—that is, in the distribution of power—has nothing to do with biology or "nature." Such a role is the result of disputes over control of the social spheres.

Hence, naturalizing the social categories that account for the place of these elements in power is a naked product of social history. The fact that these categories that identify places and roles in power relations pretend to be nothing more than terms for "natural" phenomena, whether or not they refer to anything real in nature, is a very effective indication that power, all power, requires this subjective mechanism in order to reproduce. And it is interesting to ask yourself why. While the production of the social category of "gender," based on sex, is without a doubt the most ancient in social

history, the production of the category "race," based on phenotype, is relatively recent, its full incorporation into the classification of people in power relations being barely five centuries old: it begins with the Americas and the worldwide spread of the capitalist matrix of power.[23]

The phenotypic differences between victors and vanquished have been used to justify the production of the "race" category, though it is above all an elaboration of domination relations as such. The importance and significance of the production of this category in the Eurocentric and colonial/modern world capitalist matrix of power could hardly be exaggerated: the attribution of the resulting new social identities and their distribution in world capitalist power relations was established and reproduced as the basic form of universal social classification in world capitalism and as the foundation of new geocultural identities and their power relations in the world. It likewise became the backdrop to the production of new intersubjective relations of domination and to a perspective on knowledge that was imposed around the world as the only rational one. The racialization of power relations between the new social and geocultural identities was the mainstay and the fundamental legitimizing reference for the Eurocentered character of the matrix of power, both material and intersubjective. That is, for its coloniality. It thus became the most specific element of the Eurocentered and colonial/modern world capitalist matrix of power, and it penetrated every area in the social existence of the Eurocentered, colonial/modern world matrix of power. The implications of the coloniality of power in the capitalist world need to be studied and established in a systematic (not systemic) fashion. Within the limits of this text, I will confine myself to proposing an outline of the major issues.

A. Coloniality of the Universal Social Classification of the Capitalist World

What began with the Americas was imposed all over the world. The whole world's population was classified, above all, into "racial" identities and sorted between the dominant/superior "Europeans" and the dominated/inferior "non-Europeans." Phenotypic differences were used, defined, as the external expression of "racial" differences: at an early period, primarily the "color" of the skin and hair and the form and color of the eyes; later, in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, other features as well, such as facial form, skull size, and the form and size of the nose. Skin color was defined as the most significant "racial" marker, being the most visible, for

differentiating between the dominant/superior people, or "Europeans," on one hand, and the entire set of dominated/inferior "non-Europeans," on the other. In this way, the dominant/superior Europeans were handed the attribute of "white race," and all the dominated/inferior "non-Europeans," that of "races of color."[24] The gradation ladder between the "white person" of the "white race" and each of the other skin "colors" was taken to be a gradation between superior and inferior in the "racial" social classification.

B. Coloniality of the Political and Neocultural Articulation

Territories and territorially based political organizations, whether partially or totally colonized or not colonized, were classified within the Eurocentered matrix of colonial/modern capitalism precisely according to the place that the "races" and their respective "colors" held in each case. In this way, power was articulated between "Europe," "America," "Africa," "Asia," and, much later on, "Oceania." This helped naturalize Eurocentered control over the territories, over the production resources found in "nature." And each of these categories, imposed from the Eurocenter of power, has ultimately been accepted up to the present day by most people as an expression of nature and geography, not of the history of power on this planet. The dominant groups of the nonwhite races were subject to becoming tributaries, that is, intermediaries in the chain of value and wealth transfer from the colonial periphery to the Eurocenter, or dependent associates. The nation-states of the center were established first with the colonial states and later with the dependent nation-states as their counterparts.

As part of this relationship, the processes of creating citizenship, of unequal but real representation of the various social sectors, and of repaying workers' production and taxation in the form of public services (called the "welfare state"), have ultimately remained a privilege of the center, because the cost of all this is to a great extent paid for through the exploitation of labor in the colonial periphery under undemocratic and nonnational conditions, that is, through overexploitation. Due to these findings, none of the countries whose populations are for the most part victims of racist or ethnicist power relations have been able to emerge from the colonial periphery in the struggle for "development."[25] And the countries that have been incorporated into the "center" or that are on that path are the ones whose societies either have no coloniality relations, precisely because they

were never European colonies, or that were colonies but only briefly and partially (Japan, Taiwan, China), or ones where the colonized populations were at first small minorities, such as the "Blacks" during the formation of the United States of North America, or where the aboriginal populations were reduced to isolated minorities if not exterminated, as happened in the United States, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand. All this suggests once more that the coloniality of power entails, both in international power relations and in the internal relations within countries, what in Latin America has been termed structural-historical dependency.

C. Coloniality of the World Distribution of Labor

The world distribution of labor as guided by the coloniality of power has been equally decisive for modern/colonial Eurocentered capitalism. Capitalism has organized labor exploitation into a complex worldwide apparatus based on the predominance of the capital-wage relationship. For many theorists, this is all that capitalism consists of. Everything else is "precapitalist" and, as such, outside of capital. We have known since the Americas, however, that capitalist accumulation has never, at any time, gone without the coloniality of power up to the present day.

This is precisely why the diagram of a capitalist world arranged into a dual "center" and "periphery" is not random, though it probably would have been better to think of them as "colonial center" and "colonial periphery" (in the sense of coloniality and not merely, and not so much, of colonialism), to avoid the "naturalist" spillover of physical geography in the imagery. In the center (the Eurocenter), the form of capital-labor relationship that dominated—not only structurally but also, long-term, demographically—was wage labor, which is to say that the wage relationship was primarily "white." In the "colonial periphery," on the other hand, the wage relationship became structurally dominant over time, but it was always in the minority demographically as in every other way, while the most widespread and sectorally dominant were all the other forms of labor exploitation: enslavement, servitude, small-scale market production, reciprocity. But all of these were from the first articulated under the dominion of capital and in its benefit.

Globally, the wage relationship has always been, to this day, the least widespread geographically and demographically. The universe of labor and workers under capital was, by contrast, diverse and heterogeneous. In consequence, the "social classes" among the world's population were

not restricted to the place where people were in control of labor and its products, and moreover, even in that narrow sphere they were in fact still ordered primarily based on the coloniality of power. In the Eurocenter—as conceived in isolation, separate from the colonial periphery—social classification inevitably appeared only in relation to labor, since the "Europeans" still did not perceive themselves as racially differentiated, as they do today, however, now that the victims of the coloniality of power have managed to establish themselves in the original seats of the colonizers. Their "social classes" were therefore conceptually separate from and differentiated from "races," and their reciprocal relations were thought of as external. Globally, however, as was always the very condition for the existence of capitalism, "social classes" were differentially distributed among the planet's population on the basis of the coloniality of power: in the Eurocenter, the dominant ones are the capitalists, while the dominated are the wage workers, the middle classes, and the independent peasants; in the colonial periphery, by contrast, the dominant ones are the dependent tributaries and associates of the capitalists, while the dominated are the enslaved, servants, small-scale independent market producers, wage workers, middle classes, and peasants. This social classification, differentiated between the center and the colonial periphery, has been the central mechanism in the apparatus of global accumulation in benefit of the center. Indeed, it is what has made it possible to produce, maintain, and pay for the loyalty of the exploited/dominated "whites" in the face of the "races," above all on the "colonial periphery" but also within the "center," as is still the case, especially in the United States.

D. Coloniality of Gender Relations

Throughout the colonial world, the formal-ideal norms and matrices of sexual behavior for the genders, and consequently the family organization matrices for "Europeans," were based directly on racial classification: sexual freedom for males and faithfulness for women was, throughout the Eurocentered world, the counterpart to "free" (that is, not paid for, as in prostitution) sexual access for white males to Black and Indian women. In Europe, by contrast, prostitution for women was the counterpart to the bourgeois family matrix. Family unity and integration, imposed as axes of the bourgeois family matrix in the Eurocentered world, was the counterpart of the continuing disintegration of kinship units among the nonwhite races, who were appropriable and distributable not only like pieces